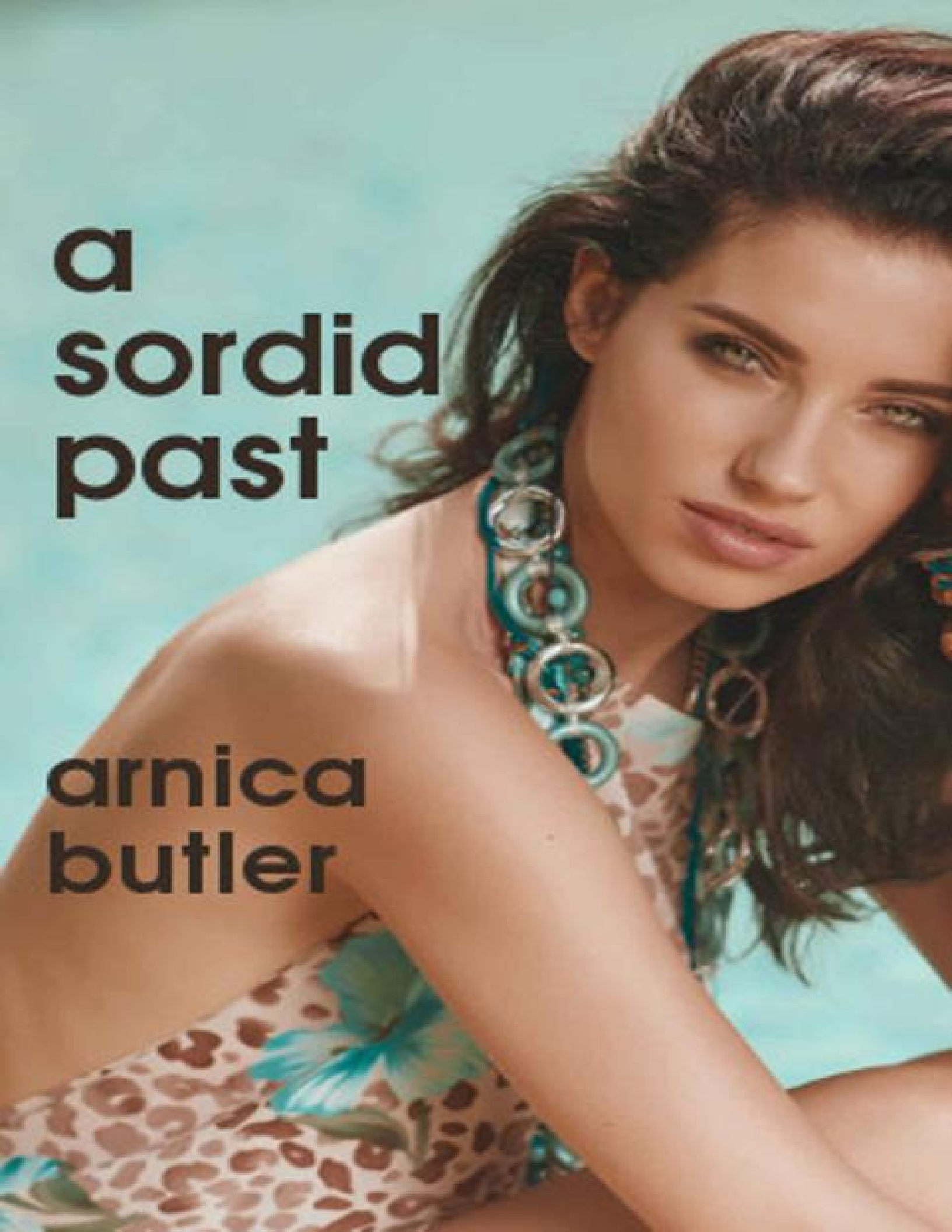


**a
sordid
past**

**arnica
butler**



A SORDID PAST A HOTWIFE NOVEL

By Arnica Butler

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CHAPTER 1

In my line of work, you get to thinking you know people.

Don't ask me how I ended up where I am; I don't even know. I didn't even think of applying to law school until I was almost finished with university, and that decision was pretty much a whim from a night of too much drinking at The Sink. I met this ambulance chaser who'd made millions, and I had no better prospects in life, and no real idea what I actually wanted to do. But I was smart and I could get a good score on the LSAT without doing much, and going to school for another three years seemed like an easy way to put off making a real decision.

Yada, yada, yada, I got drunk some other night at a law school cocktail party and all of the sudden, I'm a criminal prosecutor.

After a while, that job is like the inverse of The Matrix: you see the real world with your eyes, but it's instantly transformed into their life story. I don't see redheads, blonds, or brunettes. I see three-time offenders, addicts, and ten-year mandatory sentences. I see pimp rolls a mile off, gangbangers from even further away. Dress an addict up nice and put him in the docket on the twelfth week of his sobriety, looking like a respectable citizen, and I still see him for what he is, still see the little glint in his eyes, blinking forever, reminding him of what he really wants. I still see the kind of glint in his eye. Coke, meth, booze, sex, ponies, whatever it is.

And then it just all rolls out from there: I see it on a yellow legal pad in my own writing. Their next court date, two years in the future, what it will be for, and what they will get for it.

Maybe Beth has her own superpowers. Maybe she blinded me with her small, curvy body and ludicrously long limbs, her big eyes nearly the same color as mine but darker and luminous. Her even-keel temperament, her poise, her tameness in general.

Maybe I just didn't look because I didn't want to see anything but what she seemed to be: perfect, out of my league, for some reason enthralled with me.

Whatever it is, I can say this with confidence:

*Beth, and Beth alone, of all the people I think I've ever met,
surprised the fuck out of me.*

*

"This doesn't seem so bad," Greg said.

It was a typical beach-town bar and grill. The food smelled fine, the patrons looked happy, and there were quite a few of them, which was always a good sign.

"The way you described it, I expected there to be fish guts and vomit all over the floor," he added.

Beth rolled her eyes and pushed past him. "Don't write your review until forty-eight hours have passed," she snarked. She was looking around, her arms folded over her chest. When she turned back to him, she seemed a little less annoyed, perhaps even relieved. "I think maybe it's under new management," she told him. "They got rid of the carpeted floor, so that's a bonus."

A spritely blond high-school aged girl appeared and escorted them to a table. A waitress, slim, a little older, and mildly disinterested in her job, took the drink order.

"Pretty average," Greg commented, leaning across the table. "I'm kind of disappointed."

His wife leaned on her hand, putting her elbow to the outside of the booth. As she did, she removed whatever had been holding up her bun and let her hair fall to the side of her face. She grinned at Greg and fanned the plastic menu up and down. "Don't get too excited, cowboy. It's the same menu."

For a moment, looking over at Beth, Greg had a flash of inquietude. Something was off about her, and it wasn't just her clothing choices.

Her hair was piled up in a bun - which she professed to hate, finding it the "height of slovenliness" - and she was wearing cutoffs from an oversized pair of jeans, several sizes larger than her small frame required and which came down to her knees, her glasses, and an oversized shirt he had never seen before that seemed to be splattered with paint. She had no make-up on, but the prettiness of her face - smooth, fair skin; alluring, boxy nose; oversized lips; wide, olive-colored eyes - could not be hidden, even with her large, round glasses.

"What's with the outfit?" he had asked, jokingly, upon arriving in Walla Beach. Beth was a stunning beauty with a lithe body on a small frame, curves in all the right places, and she had a way of making anything she wore look sexy. While she didn't tend to wear low-cut shirts or tiny shorts, there was something about her proportions that made almost any casual outfit look scandalous.

But it could have just been that Greg was hopelessly in love with her, and painfully aware of his good fortune.

This getup, however, which she seemed to be uniformly wearing in Walla Beach, was the only thing he'd ever seen her wear that did her no justice whatsoever.

Beth rolled her eyes. "It's just some crap I found in the house."

Secretly, he wasn't entirely displeased: at least she wasn't out trawling men in that getup. He was back in the city a great deal of the time - a necessity of his job and political aspirations - and Beth had remained here, "cleaning up" the ramshackle "estate" her aunt and uncle had left to her after passing away in a car accident.

She had provided, and clearly would not provide, more explanation than that for her clothing. Greg had quickly chalked it all up to the cleaning, including the glasses. She wouldn't want dust in her contacts. He guessed... never mind that she barely needed them and went without them, or glasses, at least half the time.

So the clothing was one thing, but there was something else, something in her gestures and attitude, and he couldn't really put his finger on -

"See?" she said, tapping a finger on the menu. "Same misspelled words and everything."

Greg looked at where she was pointing on his own menu. "Icее Tea. Shoot, I thought that was like a tea slurpee or something."

Beth put her other fist to her cheek and hinged from the cheekbones to peruse the menu. "God. They literally have not done *anything* to this in like, what... almost twenty years."

"Chicken teenagers," Greg read off, chuckling.

When he looked up at Beth, she seemed unsettled again. She had pushed her hair to cover her face and was peering through the loose strands. She looked like a very bad investigator on a stakeout. Her eyes moved

quickly, scanning the room, and then she turned back to Greg. "Don't get those," she said, very seriously.

"Here we are," the waitress broke in, her voice facilely cheerful. She set two beers on the table. "Y'all ready to order?"

As if to emphasize that they had better be, she took out her pen and order pad as she asked, and stabbed the pad with the tip of the pen at the end of her question.

"Have the wings," Beth said, pushing her menu toward Greg. "They're deep fried, so less likely to kill you."

"Heh," the waitress said, a real smile flashing across her face, gone just as quickly.

"Wings it is," Greg said. "And some...?" He looked at Beth, who waved at him dismissively.

"Fries, I guess," she mumbled.

"You don't want anything?"

Beth looked up at the waitress and shook her head, and the two exchanged a kind of commiseration. This prompted Greg, almost like a parasympathetic reaction, to blurt: "She used to work here, you know," to the waitress.

The woman whose eyes shifted coldly back to his face was not his wife. Her eyes narrowed, and he could actually see her pupils dilate rapidly. The look was brief, but terrifying.

"Oh," was all the waitress said, in a voice that could not have been more saturated with disinterest had she tried. She slid the menus off the table, bumping Greg's overfilled beer glass and sloshing a bit of beer on the table, which she ignored. "So.. just fries? And the wings? Two pounds or one?"

"Two."

"One."

Greg smiled up at the waitress. "One, I guess."

As she left, Beth followed her with her eyes, turning her face into her curtain of hair, which she had also, inexplicably, colored to remove all the highlights. Which was fine, because she actually looked more beautiful, but in combination with the other changes to her appearance - all made after their decision to come here and try to salvage her aunt and uncle's place - it was just another unsettling curiosity.

Greg was smiling at her when she turned back to him. "Well, I, for one, am excited. It's not every day you get to eat at a place your trusted wife will not eat at."

Beth smiled, keeping her lips terse, but obviously genuinely amused. Or at least Greg thought so.

He hoped so.

Ordinarily, he felt as close to Beth as he thought anyone could feel to his wife. In addition to being beautiful, she was poised and confident in public, witty and fun in private, and possessed a very exquisite and indefinable gift for "wifing:" she nurtured without being condescending or making Greg feel more like her child, advised well and sparingly, and most importantly, she was not prone to getting hung up on what most men considered minor details - which, if you believed Greg's colleagues' stories about their wives, were of extreme importance to most women. The result was a great marriage that Greg treasured. Beth was "a keeper," but also the envy of more than a few men he knew.

Her personality in Walla Beach was confounding, to say the least. And she was, uncharacteristically, very secretive about it, deflecting any comments he made about her hair or clothing, or strange behavior, and changing the subject when that didn't work.

He couldn't complain: her method of changing the subject was to initiate sex, which he knew in his heart was motivated more by her desire to have a fireproof way of changing the subject than by a sudden rekindling of their sexual life. But he was a guy, and she was hot, and so her detours had been 100% successful so far.

She took a sip of her beer and frowned at it. "God," she commented. "Nothing changes."

Greg raised his eyebrows.

"Flat," Beth explained dryly, but she took another sip anyway. Then she peered through her hair curtain.

Seemingly satisfied with whatever she had seen, she sat up, leaning back against the booth, and gathered her hair back up into a bun.

Her eyes darted to the door, or really any movement within the restaurant, as they chatted, but she seemed to relax after her second beer came and Greg held up a French fry - slightly underdone for his taste, a little wilted-looking, for Beth's reflection. It always felt nice to be right, he

reasoned. The wings were still not at the table, which made him wonder how the undercooked fries had escaped, but Beth *had* warned him.

She waved the French fry away dismissively. "I told you, this place is crazy bad. Looks like nothing's changed."

She seemed to pale momentarily.

Greg stuffed the fry into his mouth and chewed obnoxiously. "It's great. The best half-cooked fry I've ever had."

She smiled, but her eyes were looking into another universe.

"So, anyway," he said, picking through the basket for the more cooked fries. Beth had already warned him that sending anything back was dangerous for his health, and so far, her predictions had all been accurate. "I think the thing to do, the easiest thing to do, is to just contract someone for the -"

"No."

Greg stopped digging, his hand suspended over the fry basket.

No.

Just "no."

That wasn't like Beth, either. At all. Beth didn't issue firm refusals, or firm agreements, for that matter. She didn't interrupt, and she didn't take unreasonable, intractable stances.

"No," Greg repeated. "No, to...?" He raised his eyebrows and held his hands out. *To what, Beth?* he was saying. She hadn't even heard what *part* of the repairs he wanted to contract out. He wanted Beth to realize she had interrupted him, break her stern, silent stare, and laugh at herself.

She did not.

"No to contractors," she said, reaching for her napkin, which was, inexplicably, white cloth. She shook it harshly after pulling out the silverware and set it on her lap, lips pressed together so hard she looked like she might break a tooth.

"To all contractors?" Greg said, half-joking. Surely she would laugh at the absurdity of such a statement.

Beth looked up from her lap and met his eyes, and she looked as resolute and serious as he had ever seen her. If this was a joke, she was taking it to the next level. "Yes."

"Plumbers?"

She said nothing.

"Electricians?"

"We don't need an electrician."

"I thought you said -"

"We'll just leave it. Someone would buy it as-is. I'm sure of it."

Greg stuffed some fries in his mouth, unsure of what to do or say. Recalcitrance wasn't really Beth's thing. He was unprepared for it. Beth's eyes darted around, and she placed her hands in her lap.

"What is your deal?" he asked, exasperated.

She looked at him with an almost venomous expression, and then softened. She sighed and tucked a loose strand of hair behind her ear. "I'm just... I'm sorry. I just don't want to deal with this. I don't want to be here. That's all."

There were a lot of things Greg wanted to ask her about that, because she very rarely told him anything about her life here. When she did, it usually came in point form or as a list: she worked at Mark's, at the surf shop, as a lifeguard, at the Daisy Mart, at Kong Burgers, at the Ice Cream Cone, at Louie's Bar. She left town and never went back.

The end.

He could only assume it was unhappy memories, and that was fair. This was a one-horse tourist town, and she didn't want to be back here.

"I just don't get the contractor thing," he said, aloud, a continuation of his thoughts.

Beth was taking a really, really large gulp of beer. She seemed to tip the glass even further when he said this, and take a few extra swallows. She made a comical, and also grotesque, "ahhh" sound when she was done, and did something she had never - to Greg's recollection - ever, done before: she used her lower lip to pull the foam from the beer down from above her upper lip.

Greg stared.

"Every contractor in this town is an idiot. And a crook. No contractors from here. We leave the electric as-is, we do the rest ourselves."

"You know how to put in a new tub?" Greg asked.

"I'll YouTube it. It can't be that hard, if these idiots can do it."

Greg didn't know who "these idiots" were, but Beth was getting cranky, un-poised, and confrontational. It was all uncharacteristic and weird, but as on many other nights in Walla Beach, he didn't feel like digging, and running the chance of making it worse.

He reached for her hand. "Contractors would make the work go faster," he suggested. "We could be out of here faster."

He didn't even know why he was harping on it. Especially not now: this could be a different conversation, some other time, when Beth wasn't already agitated.

She snorted. "You obviously haven't met any of these guys."

He dropped it with a shrug. It was hard to know what had gotten into Beth, but it seemed like she was just upset about being back in this town, and there wasn't anything he could say that would be right.

He chewed on some fries and looked at Beth, who was looking everywhere but at him.

The waitress returned and set down a basket of overcooked wings. Greg looked down at it and then up at her, grinning, and was about to open his mouth to make a smart-ass remark, when Beth interrupted him preemptively. "Just be glad they're cooked," she said dryly.

The waitress glared at her, and Beth shrugged, and then they both smiled in agreement.

"I wasn't going to say anything about the wings," Greg said, smirking at Beth. He *had* been, but something about the whole weird ambiance of the night had flipped a switch inside. He looked up at the waitress. "I was *going* to say, going to ask, rather, if you knew of any good plumbers in this town?"

The waitress seemed utterly flummoxed. "Plumbers..." she said, as if the word came from a different language. Greg was about to pat her on the hand and tell her not to worry, and then take his licks from Beth, when the waitress's eyes went wide and she brightened up. "Oh, yeah, wait... there's a Black-something, Black...bo...burn...no..." She turned, putting her hand to her head to scratch through the bun, scrunching up her face. "I'll ask the -"

"It's okay," Beth said quickly. "He's joking."

"Blackwell," the waitress was already saying, smiling. Beth's sentence caught up to her shortly after that, and she frowned. "Well. Anyway. That's it, if you do need it," she said.

"Thank you," Greg said, smiling apologetically. "I do actually need it. Not a joke."

She left, and Greg and Beth stared at each other over the table.

Beth broke first, laughing. It was the first truly Beth-like thing she had done all night. She reached for a wing and held it up for inspection,

then bit into it. It was clearly dry, and she had to tug with her teeth to get it off the bone.

She tossed the half-eaten wing on her bare plate. "Mmm," she joked. "Just like old times."

Greg was still not sure what to make of her mercurial mood. He took a wing out and looked at it carefully before trying it.

"I'm sorry," she said, as he chewed. The meat was so tough his jaw was beginning to hurt by the time he had it sufficiently ground down to swallow.

"About the wings?" he asked, reaching for his beer.

"I warned you," she laughed. "No. I'm sorry for all the weirdness. I just... want to get out of here. You're right. I'm sorry. A plumber is a good idea."

Greg paused with his hand hovering over the beer. He raised his eyebrows and exaggerated an expression of shock.

"Shut up," Beth said, smiling.

"Did you just say... wait... I think I heard you wrong -"

"Okay," Beth said, rolling her eyes.

"I'm *right*?"

She shook her head and picked out a French fry, ignoring him, but in the most adorable way possible.

He took a sip of beer. "I'm *right*," he said, as if he had an audience.

Beth chewed on her French fry and smiled.

She seemed to be returning to normal.

Greg reminded himself that things between them were often - not bad, but just not like they used to be. It was stress. Stress from the pandemic, stress from his career, stress from the whole situation. Sometimes it really helped to remind himself that even the best couples complained of the same kinds of problems that he had with Beth - which weren't huge, but were tiring him out. It wasn't like things were *bad*, it just felt like there was some friction between them. Conversations veered, emotions changed suddenly, they bickered about silly things more than usual.

And it wasn't all Beth. A lot of it was him, and he recognized that. Just here, in Walla Beach, it was something totally different.

Of course, she had just lost her aunt and uncle. She had said she didn't feel anything much about that, because they hadn't spoken in ages,

but maybe it wasn't true.

He tried to finish the wings, and he was hungry enough that he could choke down half of them, but after that, they abandoned the food at the same time by tossing their nearly-raw fries back into the basket.

"I stand corrected," he announced. "This is all very bad."

Beth shrugged and smiled. "Nowhere else was really open," she said, diplomatically, sounding much more like her old self. "Aren't you still hungry, though?"

Greg shook his head. He was just glad that Beth seemed to be swinging back to a good mood. She was a real pendulum since having to come back to her "home" town.

She looked over her shoulder and eased out of the booth. "'K. I'm just going to run to the ladies' and we can go. You get the bill." She stood up, and stretched a little, like she had been on a long flight. "This was your idea, after all," she added, with a smile.

Beth was gone for an unusually long time.

When she returned, she looked pale and her mouth was downturned, as close to frowning as Beth could actually get. Her mouth was large and generous, and seemed to be physically disinclined to turning downward.

"What's up," he asked, the beer close to his mouth for a final swig.

Beth shook her head, and again her eyes looked around frantically. "Probably the food," she said. "You pay yet?" She didn't wait for his answer, her eyes falling on the cash and change piled on it at the edge of the table. "Let's go, then."

So they left.

He didn't think much of it.

His own stomach was also protesting the meal, if only out of sympathy.

CHAPTER 2

I don't like lying, and I don't do regret. I try not to do either. One just causes problems, and the other is a waste of time.

But having to go back to Walla Beach, I was going to have to do some of one and then some of the other.

I knew as soon as the phone rang – the phone-phone, the landline, in our house, the phone that only solicitors and my aunt ever called – that the news was bad. It was six in the evening; there was no reason to think it wasn't an annoying solicitor, but the very first trill sent ice water through my veins. I just knew.

I answered, "Trace. What is it?"

Crossing the kitchen to get to the phone, drying my hands on a tea cloth, it had seemed like years had passed and I had plenty of time to think about it all. It was them. Somebody was dead or in the hospital. Well then, it had to be uncle Joe, and so when I saw Robbins on the caller ID screen, I assumed it was my aunt Tracey, calling to tell me so. In fact, by the time I had the phone to my ear, I was already expecting a death notice: Tracey didn't call me about hospitalizations. She didn't call me about anything, actually. Joe had gone in for a triple bypass here in the city and she hadn't even told me about it until the day he was being discharged. We had met up for a weird lunch and I hadn't talked to them since.

"I... hello. I'm trying to reach an... Elizabeth, uh... Quinn. Or possibly Brown?"

The man on the other end of the line was a lawyer. I'm married to one, I would know. I let him give his spiel. He was an attorney, calling from the offices of J. Robbins and associates. My eyes drifted to the caller ID to confirm this: it was true, there was Robbins, as I had seen, but prefaced by a "J." and followed by an "& Associ..."

He assumed I'd heard the news. I had not. He was terribly sorry to be the one to give it to me, then.

"There really isn't anyone else to give me that kind of news," I said. My voice sounded wooden, and I felt like I was outside of myself. "My parents died in a car accident too," I said. As if it mattered.

He was sorry.

He held their will.

I'd been left the entire estate, which was pretty nice of those guys, all things considered, but I suppose they didn't have anyone else to leave it to. Joe didn't care a ton for me, but he hated the idea of the government getting any of his money.

It all squared.

I listened.

"Right," I said at the end. "Well... so how much do I owe you, then?"

He didn't get the joke. He blathered on about how I could just have him handle the estate and all the legal matters and he would just get paid out of the payout.

I tried again. "Right. So, like I said, how much do I owe you?"

This time he laughed. "Oh, yeah, okay, I see. Well, actually, there is a decent sum here if these records are correct -"

"They're probably not," I assured him.

"Well... and then, there is the house."

The house.

"Okay," I said. I was still a little stunned. "So... what do you need from me?"

He asked if it was possible for me to get down there.

Possible, yes.

Desirable, not at all.

This is where the lying comes in.

I love, love, Greg Quinn.

I saw him one night when I walked into a bar with some girlfriends. Across the room, standing there with a drink in his hand and talking to some friends. Don't ask me why, but it happened: I looked at him, he looked at me, there was something like electricity in the air, and I just knew.

How? Why? Who knows? He is a good-looking guy, but he wasn't standing there with muscles bulging or some kind of look about him. He looked like an office cog: dark suit, boring tie loosened at the neck, similarly dressed and nondescript suits around him. He was clean-shaven, brown-haired, a strong jaw and a nice face. The only thing catchy about Greg are his eyes: they're very light olive green and no woman fails to comment on them. I'm envious of them, personally. I hope our kids get them. But I couldn't see that from where I was.

He wasn't doing anything much, I couldn't hear his voice. There was nothing special about him from that far away, and yet I just knew.

I knew he would come over, and he did. I knew I would give him my number, and I did. I knew he would be a guy with a dependable job, and he was. I knew he would be funny, and kind, and I knew we would have sex on our first date, and all of those things ended up being true.

So when I sat down in a booth at that bar with my girlfriends – I mean, a gaggle of not-very-close friends from school who didn't know anything about me at all – I went cold with fear. It had never happened before, because like I said, I don't do regrets.

But it all just kind of came crashing over me, right then and there, before I even talked to him, before I even knew his name. Here was Mr. Right, and he was going to want to know all about me and all about my life. Shit.

I remember I looked out the window at a neon sign that read, Chinese Jade Room.

It meant: Chinese [food]: Jade Room. And that was pretty obvious, because it had pictures of Chinese food all over the window.

So not much lost by leaving a detail out.

That's what I thought. I think about it a lot, because I really remember making my decision that way, based on the bad but survivable grammar of the Chinese restaurant across the street from that bar.

When he asked for my name, I told him it was Elizabeth.

And then, I heard myself saying:

"But most people call me Beth."

He's a smart guy, Greg. He tipped his head back, looking a little surprised. Something – recognition, I guess, and this would make sense later, when I found out what he did for a living – flickered in his eyes.

"Huh," he said. "You really don't look like a Beth."

Oh, yeah. I almost said. What do I look like?

I'm glad I never asked that.

Sometimes, now that I'm here in Walla Beach again, I lay awake in the dark, staring at the ceiling, wondering what would have happened if I had said that.

I imagine Greg answering the question I never asked.

"You look like... a Liza."

And who knows what I would have said to that.

*

Mark's hadn't changed at all, and from the looks of it, that included the bathroom not having been cleaned since the last time she was there. Beth stood with her foot holding the door open, looking for paper towels so she could leave the bathroom without touching anything, and surveyed the scraps of toilet paper floating in pools of unknown fluids.

"Never mind," she said, under her breath.

The middle stall, the only one that historically was worth the danger of entering the bathroom for, was occupied. The toilet flushed and the door snapped open, all in a great, loud, hurry, and a tall blond woman, teetering on red heels, crashed out of the stall, obviously drunk.

She looked at Beth, who was still standing in the door, and hiccuped, then fell towards the sink and turned on the water.

Beth's heart had stopped, and she felt like the oxygen was draining away from her brain. Tiny stars were forming at the corners of her eyes, swarming inward, passing through her vision.

Anna.

Anna, as if the whole town had been wrapped up in plastic and put in a freezer until Beth returned. Anna with platinum hair and her dark roots just peeking out. Anna with her trashy good looks, her everywhere-rural features, her eyeliner and her bright lipstick. Anna with her insistent smattering of freckles across her nose that she caked with foundation that inevitably wore off to reveal them, Anna with the dark brown eyes that matched and betrayed her true hair color. Anna encased in tight, cheap fabric, a shade of purply, whoreish red that did not match her lipstick. Anna.

Beth paused, replaying Anna's expression as she had looked at her. She hadn't recognized her, but she was thinking about her. She was leaning in toward the mirror, unsteady on her too-high shoes, and smearing a different shade of lipgloss on her lips. Her eyes moved and she looked at Beth, but she went back to the mirror just as quickly.

"Not gonna fucking bite you," she slurred, and pressed her lips together.

Beth made a sound, something she hoped sounded like a laugh, and made a dive for the first stall.

“Use that one I just come out of,” Anna slurred, her head falling forward and almost hitting the mirror. She hiccuped. “Only one. That works.”

Beth was already shutting the door. Anna was already shrugging. “Suit yourself,” she said.

Anna's eyes were on the mirror now, Beth could see through the stall, as she sat down, in her shorts on the toilet. She could see them scrunching up, could see the thoughts churning in Anna's mind. But she dropped her lip gloss, cursed, and must have forgotten what she was thinking about.

She left, after careening into the washbasin because she pulled the door too hard, and then careening into the door as an overcorrection.

Same old Anna.

Beth waited, considered actually using the toilet, but didn't want to move just yet. Her heart was pounding, and she felt sick. Her hands were clammy.

God, so what? So what if someone saw her, and recognized her?

It had been ten years. Nothing had changed around here, evidently, but people couldn't possibly have not changed *at all*.

Anyway, what would they do?

She'd maybe have to explain her change of name, but that wasn't too hard. She had a story for that. She had a name with infinite nicknames, like Charles. And then what? It wasn't like Anna was going to say hello and then turn to Greg and tell him everything Liza Brown had ever done in this town.

Beth cringed and held her stomach, because she felt a very real pain at that moment.

Who was she kidding?

That was *exactly* what Anna would do.

At least the Anna she knew.

And that Anna, by the looks of it, was still alive and well, if thoroughly pickled - preserved, perhaps, by all the alcohol she'd consumed.

Maybe, Beth thought hopefully, she's been so drunk for ten years that she doesn't even remember me.

She waited ten minutes before leaving, just to be sure.

CHAPTER 3

A Few Days Later

"I'm not going there," Beth repeated. She looked Greg up and down. She looked more tired than anything else. "*You* shouldn't go there, either."

"Is it a biker bar?"

Beth rolled her eyes.

"Is it like the Christmas Bar we went to in New Orleans?"

Beth folded a shirt over her arm and grinned. They had entered a bar in New Orleans that had been decorated like Christmas, and according to the owner, was so decorated all year round. It also, they discovered later than they would have liked to, was the bar of choice for a lot of neo-Nazis. That the Adam Sandler film "Eight Crazy Nights" had been playing silently on the wall had amused and alarmed them both endlessly.

Beth looked up at the ceiling as though she needed to think about the question. She shook her head. "No."

"Worse?"

She sighed. "It's just a dive. People get in fights there every night. The cops on duty just drive straight there and wait in the parking lot, you know? That kind of place."

"And you worked there?" Greg said.

He had the kind of tone that he used for making an argument by asking a question, and he could see Beth stiffen. She hated that. She usually snapped, "Don't cross-examine me."

Today, she did not.

Beth folded with increasing force. She was sorting through laundry they'd taken to a laundromat about thirty miles away, in a town called White Beach that was nowhere near a beach. She had claimed that their clothes would melt in the dryer, if they didn't get chewed up in the washer, at the laundromat in Walla Beach, which had seemed pretty fun to Greg. It had a bar and a bowling alley attached.

But Beth had worked *there*, too.

"It seems like," Greg said, picking a shirt out of the basket, "you veto *every* place in this town."

"Ding-ding-ding," Beth said dryly, shaking out another shirt.

"It can't all be that bad."

“It is.”

Greg sighed. “Beth. I’m sick of this room. I’m sick of the house. I need to blow off some steam. Nothing here has turned out to be as bad as you said it would.”

“Everything in this town is exactly as bad as I said it would be, and you know it.”

“Not true.”

“You didn’t go into the bathrooms at Mark’s,” she said. Her voice trailed off near the end of her sentence. This sentence-ending had been happening a lot lately, and Greg had noticed, in addition to the fact that Beth seemed... *shifty*. Changeable. Moody. Flaky. All the things she just... wasn’t, normally.

He didn’t answer her immediately, and she finally looked up.

Something – he couldn’t exactly say what – was exchanged between them. Beth’s eyes moved like mercury, or perhaps he only imagined it.

“You know what?” she said cheerfully – much too cheerfully, if you asked him. “Why don’t *you* go? You can see for yourself what kind of shithole it is.”

He knew this tactic of Beth’s, because she deployed it often. He had never given her any reason to believe it wouldn’t work. When she really didn’t want to do something, she always told him to go do it by himself. Like going to a bar was any fun by himself, like he wanted to run marathons or take road trips by himself.

But he had, at this point, really had enough.

“You know what?” he said, volleying back an equally cheerful voice that he hoped she found as fake as he found hers. “I *will*.”

“Oh-kay,” Beth said, folding another shirt and setting it down on the pile.

He waited, only a beat or two, for her to retract her statement. It was, after all, reversible at this point. Or she might agree to go with him.

But she didn’t, she just kept folding, and perhaps because she had a smile on her face like she knew she had one, and less likely because he actually wanted to go, Greg took an unneeded jacket off the hook and shoved his wallet into his back pocket.

“See you, then,” he said, kissing her on the cheek.

Beth smiled. “You’ll see something, all right.”

And that was how he ended up at “*Teddys*.” No apostrophe.

*

“I saw you,” the woman said, squeezing between his stool and the empty one next to him. Her bare thighs pressed against his jeans as she squeezed in. She collapsed into the seat like she was getting home from work and taking a load off.

Greg looked over from his perch, which he had been stubbornly holding for half an hour while nursing a single beer. She was dressed in cutoffs that barely covered any part of her thigh, and which had crept down her backside when she sat, so a whale-tail of dark tan crocheted swimsuit peeked out above the blue of her shorts, delineating the smooth, plump expanses of her sun-kissed skin. A loose white crop top slipped from her shoulder, and bumpy material lurked beneath it where her ample breasts pushed against the shirt. Greg was relieved, and yet somewhat disappointed, that she was at least wearing the top half of the bikini.

“The other day,” she continued, turning toward him by rotating the bar stool, which was like a large high chair. She lifted her right leg to cross it over her knee, and as she did, Greg could not help but catch a flash of the soft swell of her mound pressing against the beige swimsuit, a sliver of pale skin peeking out.

She was pretty, in a really trashy kind of way. She had the kind of face that belonged equally in a trailer park or on a runway, but she was helping it generously in favor of the former with her wild makeup: black eyeliner, expertly applied but smudged, encircled her eyes, and her lips betrayed remnants of a bright red lipstick that had long worn off but still stained her skin.

“You relations of the Robbins?” she squawked, fishing in a large brown handbag for something.

“Uh...” Greg began, not sure how to field the question.

“Cuz’ I seen your car up there,” she continued. “It’s a rental, right? Red?” She turned to Greg, holding a pack of cigarettes in her hand.

“Uh.. yeah, no, uh... that’s not, my car,” Greg stammered. He was getting a bad read off this girl, and frankly, the whole town. But he couldn’t decide if it was Beth’s hysterics, or his own paranoia, or just a general feeling of doom that had been pervading his mind for a year or so now.

“Red one? You sure? I saw you drivin’ it. Right Petey?”

She yelled this last question, abruptly, and it confused Greg until the bartender, a portly man wearing a shirt that read, *Petey Smiles, The Man, The Myth, The Legend*, grunted in agreement.

Greg took a sip of his beer. “Yeah, that’s... it’s my wife’s car, you’re thinking of.”

Something about this statement changed everyone in the bar, or at least it seemed so to Greg. The woman, who had already been sitting too close to begin with, leaned even closer, smiling. The bartender stopped pouring for a moment and looked from Greg to the woman, his expression something like pity and fright. Someone snickered behind him.

“Oh, you’re *married*,” she said, smiling. She had acquired an all-new level of flirtatiousness, the kind that certain women made no effort to hide. She leaned on her hand, in a disturbing gesture that reminded Greg of Beth, and grinned.

“You watch that one, son,” someone said behind him, laughter in his voice. “She done broke up every marriage in this town.”

She was already turning toward the voice, rolling her eyes – another disturbingly similar gesture to one of Beth’s. “Can it, Sonny, you know that ain’t true.” She bumped Greg’s leg as she spun and smiled sweetly at him. “He’s still married.”

Whoever had made the comment – and Greg didn’t dare turn around to see for himself, was removing his large bulk from the table where he had been sitting, watching the game. He was singing, comically, “*She’s a maniac, maniac, I know...*”

It all seemed to be an act, and one that had been rehearsed a million times over by the same cast and crew. The bartender chuckled, the woman leaned back on the bar and asked for the usual, which he was already making and handed to her instantly, and the gentleman behind them sang his way into the corridor.

“You freaked out yet?” she asked Greg. “People get freaked out when they come in here.”

Greg smiled and shook his head. “I’ve seen a lot of stuff,” he told her.

She took a cigarette out of her pack and snapped the cigarettes toward him. He shook his head and watched as she put it in her mouth and brought a lighter to the end.

His mouth was open to comment on the statewide smoking ban, but he thought better of it.

“Anna, get that thing outside, I got no strikes left and ain’t got no money for fines,” the bartender, suddenly full of energy, snapped.

Anna dropped the lighter into her open purse and inhaled, before tossing the cigarette into a used glass with melting ice in it, which had been there since Greg walked through the door.

“So... you somebody’s cousin or what?” Anna said, glaring at the bartender, who was glaring back. It took Greg a minute to realize the question was for him.

He pondered what he should say, but only for a moment. He was pretty good at sounding like he was answering questions forthrightly, without saying anything at all. It was a skill most prosecutors had, and it probably explained why a lot of prosecutors went into politics.

But she didn’t wait for him.

“Wait a minute,” she said, a frightening light flickering to life in her eyes. “You married, you said? Who’s your wife? *Shit*,” she breathed. “You ain’t married to *Liza*, are you?”

Like something out of a movie, the entire bar seemed to go silent. The bartender stopped drying the glass he had in his hand, and Anna stared at him with an open, smiling mouth.

“Uh, no,” Greg said. He felt himself smoothing his shirt, as if he was wearing a tie, and it made him cringe – it was a tick, a tick he got when he felt uncomfortable for someone else, and it was a tell when he was playing poker. “No, my wife is Beth. Beth, uh, her maiden name was Brown.”

The bartender and Anna exchanged glances. Her smile was getting bigger, more sinister somehow.

“Brown, huh?” she said.

Greg gave his head a little jerk. It was a gesture he used with perps, sort of a push to keep them thinking, get them talking, let them give themselves the bad news instead of him.

To his surprise, Anna mirrored his head-tilt, with a sly smile.

“Beth,” she repeated, and snorted.

It wasn’t too often that Greg had no idea what to say, or what to even try to say. Somewhere in the back of his mind, he could feel that a very bad realization was about to be made. He knew the feeling. It crept up on him, washing up through the layers of his brain from the base of his skull. He

already knew it, and he knew he already knew it, so there was nothing to do but sit there, the cold chill of some bad reality pouring slowly over him as the feeling made its way to thought.

“Whelp,” Anna said, picking up her glass and tipping it toward Greg with enough drunken force that the liquid splashed over the side, “Here’s to you and your *wife*.”

Greg thought he heard another snicker.

“How come she ain’t here?” the bartender asked. He was grinning. Everyone, it seemed, was exchanging glances with each other, everyone but Greg in the know.

They were clearly actually waiting for the answer. Anna sipped her drink.

“Uh... she’s uh...” In his mind he thought of few things: she’s tired from all the work on the house, she doesn’t really want to run into anybody she knows, she’s not really a social person... but as he spun through all the lies or excuses he could come up with, it rose up from the fog of his brain: the thought.

Elizabeth.

Beth.

Liza.

“She don’ wanna come see all her old pals?” Anna finished for him, after waiting for him to finish his sentence. She snorted again and brought her drink to her mouth. “Figures,” she muttered.

“I think she’s just, uh, you know. Overwhelmed. By the funeral, and everything.”

“Huh,” Anna said. She looked at Pete the bartender. “You go to that funeral, Petey? You see Liza there?”

“Beth,” Greg said, feeling like he was grappling for a life saver in an ocean that was getting rapidly more stormy.

Anna gave him the side-eye and fished the cigarette out of the glass. She held it in a closed fist and turned back to face Greg. “You got a picture of her or somethin’? Just to make sure we’re talkin’ about the same gal.”

Her eyes dropped to his phone, and his followed.

Pete leaned on the bar on his elbows. “Come on, dude,” he said.

Greg shook his head, slowly. “I, uh... I have, um, no idea if, uh... I should -”

“Everybody in this place is an old friend,” Anna practically yelled.

“We’re all *real* close in Walla,” Pete confirmed. He had a strange grin on his face. Greg felt sure he heard another snicker, or at least a nasal snort, from behind him.

“I ain’t seen Liza anywhere in town,” Pete said, after Greg sat there, more unsettled than he had been in a long time.

Beth’s strange behavior – the glasses, the ugly clothing, the refusing to go to restaurants or look up any of her old friends, her insistence that no one ever stayed long in this town anyway – were all starting to make a very bad kind of sense to him now.

She hadn’t *wanted* to run into any of these people.

Which was fine, and something he could understand.

What he *couldn’t* understand is why she hadn’t just *told* him that.

Maybe this Liza, and Beth, were not the same person.

This thought was exactly the lifeline he had been looking for, and so he latched onto it. These creepy people knew some person named Liza Brown, and they obviously had some shared history with – he got the sense – a very seedy underbelly.

But Brown was not an uncommon name around here (it was on every third mailbox he had seen on the whole drive through the county), and this was all, clearly, just a simple misunderstanding.

He was already reaching into his pocket for his phone as he had these thoughts. He swept his fingers over the screen and unlocked it, turning it to face Anna. The homescreen picture was of him and Beth on their honeymoon, which they took about a year after they got married because he couldn’t get enough time off before then. Beth was radiant, wearing a sexy red swimsuit, her sun-kissed hair full of salty beach waves.

Anna leaned in to squint at the photo. “Shhhhhhhhh,” she hissed, leaving her verdict hanging in the air for a moment, undecipherable.

She put her fist to her mouth and got the damp cigarette between her lips. It bounced as she grinned and said, lighting it, “That’s Liza, sure as shit. Classed the fuck up, but you can’t shine the -”

The bartender, a big, pot-bellied guy who looked more slow-moving than a sloth, shot his hand out and was twisting the phone toward his own face before Greg even realized what was happening. “Whooo-ey,” he said. “Sure is. I would not forget them-” He cut himself off. “Damn. How long ago this was?”

Greg blinked. The man’s absurd syntax had derailed him. “It...”

What *difference* did it make?

Liza.

He was racking his brains now, while Anna and the bartender exchanged a few smart-ass remarks he barely heard, trying to think of every time Beth had told him a story about her hometown. Trying to think of everything she had said, everything he knew, about her time here. She had never – and you would think it would have come up – mentioned that she had called herself Liza previously.

But now that he sat there, reaching for what he knew about Walla Beach and her life here, he realized that she had never given him very much at all. No stories, no anecdotes, no details. She had listed off places she'd worked, but had never talked about her jobs or anything she'd learned from them. She had claimed to not have any real friends in high school, and had painted herself as a loner and a recluse.

Or had she? he wondered. Had she painted that picture of herself, or had *he* painted the picture himself, based on the fact that she didn't say much about it at all?

"So what's she doin' now? Liza?"

Greg was opening his mouth.

"Beth, that is. *Riiiiight*. Beth. Very respectable, Beth."

The bartender had released his hand and was looking at him with his unblinking, dull eyes, eager for the answer.

"She had, a, um, business. For a while. Then, you know." He waved his hand around to indicate the pandemic, or maybe her aunt and uncle's deaths, or maybe just to indicate that life in general had "happened."

To his surprise, they nodded solemnly, as so many people of a certain socioeconomic class did so readily. He had noticed this as a prosecutor: there was a whole segment of the world that simply saw life as a thing that happened *at* them. Babies were conceived and then born, DUIs were slapped on them, people were shot, kids were caught stealing or smoking pot, drugs were sold, and police got wise to things and stopped by to arrest you. A lawyer was shoved in your cell and made you sign some papers and then you went to jail. Or not. It was a world in which people had little agency, and things just happened. The whole bar seemed, suddenly, to be of this ilk, nodding for a moment of solemn silence about Beth's bad luck. All of "this."

“Uh-huh,” Anna said, after giving Beth’s misfortunes the time they deserved (several seconds). “So you, what? Some kind of sugar daddy?”

She was smoking now, and Petey didn’t seem to care now. She blew a stream of smoke toward Greg at the end of her question, and gave him a smile. From a different woman, in different makeup, in a different place, it might have been sexy. From Anna, it was twisted and dangerous.

Greg pondered a reaction to this, but fortunately for him, Anna didn’t wait. She grabbed the phone out of his hand and began digging through it. “You got any other pictures of her, then?” Anna was saying.

Greg reached for the phone, and she moved it just out of reach with a twist of her chair, swiveling her back toward him. Greg fought off the impulse to keep grabbing for the phone and make a scene. These days, anyone could be filming, and footage like that could be career-ending for someone interested in politics.

“Oooh,” she cooed. “This where you live?” She spun back and held the phone out so that Pete could see a picture of the house.

Greg had composed himself by then and reached out in a calm, smooth motion to take the phone from her hand. “Was. That *was* where we lived,” he said quietly.

Pete seemed touched by this, and Anna made a wide “oh” with her mouth and looked down at the ashtray he had set on the bar for her.

“Anyway,” Pete said. “Tell her come on down, drinks on the house.”

“Yeah, Pete, you ain’t seen *me* in a long time neither,” someone called, indicating that indeed, everyone present in the bar was listening in on the conversation.

“You ain’t quite so mem’rable,” Anna quipped, and another round of disturbing laughter went around the room.

“Okay,” Greg said, sliding off his bar stool. “I better get going. What do I owe you?”

“Ohhhh,” Anna whined, putting her hand out on Greg’s forearm. “We scared him. Honey, don’t you pay no mind to us, we’re just jokin’ around. Here. Pete, get him another drink, I’ll buy you a drink, sit down.”

“I really -”

“Don’t be ugly,” Anna said sharply, invoking the disturbing Southernness that seemed latent in the people of these parts. They weren’t caricatures, drinking sweet tea and cawing like Foghorn Leghorn. But on occasion, a fierce insistence on some kind of manners erupted from them,

coated in a sugary smile, with a vague threat vibrating in their voice. This was such an occasion, and without anyone doing much else, Greg was delivered of a sense that if he didn't stay to have Anna's drink with her, his chances of getting shot – accidentally, mind you - were going to increase exponentially.

He smiled. This was excellent practice, he decided, for his eventual politicking.

"I'll stay," he said, shakily feigning bravura and sitting back down as suavely as he could, "but I never let a lady pay for my drink. What can I get *you*?"

It was tempting to add, "little lady," but he was glad he hadn't.

Anna hooted uproariously. Pete the bartender seemed quite pleased. Drinks were poured. The heaviness lifted. Greg breathed a sigh of relief as he sipped the drink – a whiskey and water, or faded soda, and it was terrible. He would have to call Beth to drive him home, or walk, because he was going over the limit.

He would cross that bridge when he came to it.

Anna's foot, encased in a tall sandal that, like everything else about her, was simultaneously sexy and trashy, rolled in a circle, and Greg both sensed and dreaded another round of questions. He was starting to suspect that he should call Beth and get the story straight, or ask for advice, or maybe just have her come rescue him, but he didn't know how long he needed to stay here drinking with Anna in order to be able to leave without "being ugly."

"I think I got some old pictures of -" Anna began abruptly, but just then the door opened and the entire bar erupted in greetings for the man who entered. Anna was the only person who seemed, without looking to see who it was, annoyed by his presence. She set her drink down and stubbed out her cigarette as the other men slapped hands and greeted the newcomer with grunts and last name exchanges.

"Hey, Pinker."

"Monks."

Greg eyed him out of the corner of his eye with his elbows on the bar. He was wishing, deeply, that he had never walked into this place. The guy was above-average height, a strong build, a lot of tattoos on his forearms, a clean white shirt and smudged tan Carhartt work pants. A thick black beard - but not the hipster, oiled kind; it was tangled and feral –

covered his jaw. He looked, at first glance, like a lumberjack, but something dangerously intelligent moved behind his eyes.

Anna spun on her chair and rolled her heel provocatively, leaning her elbows back on the bar and jutting her shoulders back.

“Jesus, Annie. You smokin’ in here again?” he asked. He didn’t bellow. He looked Greg up and down, expression neutral, and fished a pack of cigarettes out of a side pocket, removing one and lighting it in one fluid motion. Cigarette between his lips he jutted his jaw at Pete. “Cold one, man.”

Then he sat down.

Anna was delighted with something, Greg could see. She was grinning now, making no effort to hide her mischievous sentiments, even if Greg couldn’t know what thoughts inspired them. Her fingers moved playfully, and her knee bounced a little. She reminded him a bit of a dog waiting for a treat or a walk, shaking inwardly with the excitement.

Greg slammed his whiskey water drink and set it down on the bar. “I better run,” he said.

But Anna had already spun to face the newcomer. “Hey, Pink,” she slurred, revealing to Greg for the first time that she was verily intoxicated. She must have come in half in the bag. “Guess who this guy here is?”

“Pink” looked at Greg in the mirrors behind the liquor shelves. His hair had the faint shape of a ballcap still pressed into it, because no one in these parts would dare go into a building – even a dive bar – with their hat on.

“The new dentist,” he said dryly.

Anna leaned over to him and cupped her hand next to his ear. Her jaw moved but there was no way to hear what she said.

The man barely reacted to her proximity, and his reaction to her words could have been measured only in millimeters, a shift of his eyes, a hardening of something behind them. He picked up the beer Pete put in front of him and took a swig of it, while Anna spun back to face the bar, glowing with excitement, watching everyone in the mirrors.

The man set his beer down.

Anna waited for his reaction, mouth open in a smile, foot bobbing excitedly.

“No shit. Huh.”

“*And*,” Anna said, almost gleefully, “*and*, Liza’s back in *town*, i’nt she? I mean, sorry, ‘scuse me... *Beth*. Beth is back in town.”

The man was cracking a peanut now, and a minute grin appeared on his lips. “Lizzie-Beth,” he said. He chewed almost contentedly. Then his eyes shot from his fingers to Greg’s in the mirror. They were a cold, dark blue, and like everyone else, a danger lurked beneath them. It had surfaced.

The same cold fear that Greg had experienced earlier crept over him again, but with a different twist. This cold radiated from his chest, and then sank into his groin, where it was taking on distinct sexual undertones, like cool fingers gently squeezing his balls.

To Greg’s surprise - and if he judged Anna’s expression correctly, hers as well - “Pink” grunted, took the beer and the peanuts, and stood up. He walked over to a table and sat down, facing the silent TV in the corner where a baseball game was playing. He left his cigarette poised in the ashtray, a thin wisp of smoke curling into the stale air.

Pete swept away the peanut shells and put the cigarette out without comment.

Anna leaned over toward Greg, her shoulder touching his, the scent of a cheapish hair product wafting into his nostrils. “That’s Zach Pinker,” she said, watching Greg’s face in the mirror. She was hoping for something; her face could not have been more expectant than if she had just revealed that JFK was shot by Ted Nugent.

There was just one problem for Greg: he didn’t know *who* Zach Pinker was, or what Anna expected him to do once he found out.

All he could be certain of was that Anna *expected* him to know who Zach Pinker was.

The fingers on his balls squeezed tighter. He felt a little ill.

It left only one possibility, really, even though his mind was racing looking for something else. Anything else, any different, plausible thing.

But there was no other plausible explanation.

Zach Pinker was an ex-boyfriend.

And judging from Anna’s gleeful expression, he was not some passing fancy, but a real, true kind of ex.

“Is he?” Greg said as blandly as possible.

Anna watched him in the mirror and then laughed. “Ah-huh,” she laughed quickly. Then she grinned openly, picking up her drink, swirling

the ice around. There was nothing left but dirty-looking water, but she brought it to her lips anyway.

She was still watching him, expecting something more.

“You ain’t even know who he is,” she said haughtily, after a few moments of tense silence. “Oh, honey.”

She was reaching with one hand into the big purse she had dumped on the bar.

“Anna, now, don’t even think about it. Daley’s gonna be here in half an hour and I told you I ain’t got no more strikes.”

Anna sighed. “Lord,” she muttered. She fished a cigarette out and spun to face Greg again. She placed her hand – her nails were manicured in a very eighties-looking French manicure, something Greg only knew because his older sister had tortured him with these facts when she had babysat him as a teenager. “Want to come outside with me, honey? I can tell you some stories.”

Greg saw his own shoulders sag in the mirror. He didn’t want to go outside with Anna, and he didn’t want to stay inside with all these crazy dudes, who did seem to be watching the TV and to have forgotten all about Liza, or Beth. But still.

“I gotta... go. Uh, Pete, right? How much do I owe you?” He made a move for his wallet.

“Thirty’ll do it,” Pete said, without pausing to calculate.

“Oh... kay,” Greg agreed, figuring it was high, but not wanting to haggle over the price of escape. He started to slide a card out of the leather and Anna clucked. Pete shook his head. “Cash only, man.”

“Yeah. Right,” Greg said. “Of course.”

Anna was grinning, holding her cigarette in one hand and stroking the end of it with the fingers of the other. It was an unsubtle reference to stroking the head of someone’s cock, and she wanted that to be known.

No cash. He had already known that before he looked in, but he made a show of searching through it anyway.

“Sho – it,” he muttered, changing to the expletive, which he felt would be better received. He folded his wallet and started to put it back in his pocket. “You got an ATM here?”

“It’s across the street at Daisy Mart,” Anna said, her eyes glinting. She moved her head in the direction of the door and pulled Greg out of his chair with her, taking him by the arm, like he was her date. To Pete she

growled, “Don’t you get in a big hissy about it, Petey. He’ll be coming right back, and if he don’t... Zach’ll pick up the tab.”

She smiled the same dangerous, saccharine smile at Greg that she had used before. “Least he can do,” she said, her voice sultry.

*

“Gotta tell you, you don’t really seem like Liza’s type,” Anna said, leaning on the ATM. Curiously, in the stark fluorescent lighting under the Daisy Mart, her makeupper face acquired an austere prettiness to it. He shoved the thought out of his mind, and did his best not to look at her slender, tanned thighs, or the appealing crescent of tanned stomach that peeked out from under her crop top depending on how she moved. She draped herself over the ATM and gazed at him.

It was not subtle. Her fingers wandered arousingly over the machine while he punched in his PIN and took out one hundred dollars. Then he prayed quietly as the machine considered whether or not to dispense it.

“Uh... what kind of tip is standard around here?” he said, clearing his throat.

“Hmm,” she commented. “What kind of tip is standard where you’re from?”

Greg looked at her as the money whirled and the machine spat it out. “Fifteen, then,” he said. He considered, briefly, giving her forty to take back, but the truth was he didn’t trust a single bleached hair on her head.

She slipped her arm into his as they exited the Daisy Mart, and Greg wasn’t sure how to politely and safely extricate himself from her grip. They crossed the street, and she lit her cigarette without letting him go, bringing her linked hand up to light it. She took a drag and held him there, captive, while she blew out the smoke. “N’I ask you somethin’?” she said, her tone suddenly very different.

It was shocking only for a moment, but Greg remembered that she was drunk, and she was clearly a seasoned drunk, so she could be so wasted she wouldn’t even remember this conversation. She let go of his arm and turned to face him. “You cool with everything? You know. With Liza. ‘Scuze me, Beth.” She smoked again and blew her smoke at him with irritation, as if he had somehow argued with her.

Her mercurial mood shifted again, and she grinned. Her eyes dropped to his crotch, and she took a long, appraising stare, still grinning. “Oh,” she said, like she had just found the cure for cancer. “I get it. Maybe you *are* Liza’s type. Hmm?”

She had the cigarette between her lips, and was blinking rapidly with her blackened eyelashes, looking like some grotesque impression of an ingénue.

Greg just opened his mouth and shook his head, making a confused face as he did. The implication was clear, he had just never, ever, had a woman say something like that to him. In real life, that was.

“Uh-huh,” Anna said, smiling now. She had it all figured out, you could see. She nodded to agree with her own assessment. “That all makes sense.” She smoked and then cracked up, as if someone had just told her a joke. “Cuz Liza wunnunt anyone to... well, you know.” She looked Greg up and down out of the side of her eyes. “Settle down. ‘Specially with some, you know... suit. What is it you do, anyway?”

Greg answered, his stomach flipping in circles, his heart racing. This woman was just talking drunk, trashy shit, he told himself. She wouldn’t remember anyway. He had met a thousand drunks like her before: they were up, walking around, talking, making some sense, but they were empty shells. He was irritated, and there were thousands of reasons why, but none came to the surface of his mind as a complete thought.

“I’m a lawyer,” he said, unwisely.

And then - who could say why? Maybe because he got a little rush when her eyes went wide? - he added, “Thinking of running for office.”

She nodded and smoked, and her head seemed to get heavy. He had regretted telling her – or for that matter, anyone in this shithole – about his political intentions, the moment he did. He couldn’t even put on a finger on *why* he had said it. He was relieved that the news had been boring enough to Anna that she almost seemed to be nodding off.

Unfortunately for him, the words were making their way through the syrupy alcoholic sludge in her head. They finally reached their destination, somewhere in her remaining consciousness. Suddenly, she jerked her head up, eyes wide, and snatched the cigarette from her mouth. “For *office*?” she shrieked. Then she shrieked again, tipping her head back with a very mean-spirited mirth. “Your ass is married to *Liza Brown* and you gonna run for office?” She spun around, tried to grab the door, and missed before flapping

about, grasping it, swinging it wide open, and throwing herself into the bar before it bounced back violently and caught her on the hip.

It all happened before Greg could react. He reached for the door and grabbed it, but Anna was already headed toward the bar, her hand up, waving frantically. She still had the cigarette in her hand. “Pete. Pete. You gotta hear this,” she was saying.

“Hey,” Greg said. His voice had a note of desperation now, but he didn’t care, because he *was* suddenly desperate. The full weight of his error – and he could not for the life of him think of why he had made it – was coming into view. The sinking feeling had now blossomed fully into panic. He seized Anna’s arm, and squeezed hard, pulling her into a chair and sitting down, pulling her with him into the adjacent chair.

She looked down at his hand on her arm, surprised. “Hey,” she began, but her voice was lower.

Greg squeezed just a little harder. “Listen, Anna, you gotta... here...”

“Don’t have to fucking manhandle me,” Anna grumbled, jerking her elbow. But it didn’t leave Greg’s grasp, because he was clinging on for dear life. They tipped over an empty shot glass and it tinkled loudly.

Pete raised his eyebrows, and Anna squirmed and complained, and Greg hushed her and put a hand up to calm her down. He did not see, but could feel, that all the attention in the bar was suddenly focused on them.

“Here,” Greg repeated, handing over all the cash to Pete. “That’s for my tab.” Anna was glaring at him, and she jerked her elbow away.

“Dude, what the *fuck*?” she spat.

Greg held up a hand again. “I’m sorry, I just... didn’t want you to... Pete, the rest of that is for Anna. Whatever she wants. Have a few drinks on me, Anna.”

He could see that Anna had forgotten, in her rage and drunkenness, what she had been rushing in to the bar to say. Greg was also drunk, and things were becoming muddled for him as well. But he had wagered – and, it seemed, correctly – that Anna would forget what she was all steamed up about, if only he changed the subject enough times.

“Pete,” he said, turning to Pete, who was suspicious of the whole scene but also seemed to be fairly accustomed to Anna acting like this. *He could still be on my side*, Greg thought.

Whatever that was, his side.

“Pour us a couple of shots. Anna, I’m sorry, I didn’t mean to get you all upset, okay?”

Zach Pinker had risen from his seat during this transaction, but with an air of having done so not because of the commotion, but simply because he wanted to. He was now at the bar, leaning sideways on it now, rough-looking hands folded together, an unreadable expression on his face. Anna was frozen in place, her mouth open, her eyes wiggling a little, as she searched her rapidly vanishing memory for some clue as to what she had been upset about.

Greg, an avowed atheist, was praying silently to himself.

Pete set the shot glasses down and held up a bottle of tequila. Greg hated tequila, especially this grain-alcohol garbage, but he looked to Anna for the final say. She was still agitated, looking like a pressure cooker about to explode.

Then she laughed, drunkenly. “Tequila,” she slurred, grinning. She folded over on herself and turned to Zach, putting a finger to his jaw and drawing a line down to his chest. “Now *that’s* a guy knows how to treat a lady.”

Zach looked at Anna coldly, obviously used to her act. He ordered another beer, but sat down to drink it at the bar, his eyes rigid on the mirror. Greg avoided meeting them.

Greg was inwardly heaving a sigh of relief: Anna was clearly the town drunk, and she was going to forget what he had told her, and he could be on his way.

His priority, now, was to leave and never enter another establishment in this godforsaken place, before anything else happened.

And yet.

And yet.

His own mind had been slowed by the booze, and then hijacked by a moment of panic. But now, Anna’s words, and all of their disturbing implications, were screaming in his ear.

You ain’t even know who he is. Oh, honey.

You cool with everything? You know. With Liza?

Your ass is married to Liza Brown and you gonna run for office?

He looked at himself in the mirror. Greg, he tried to reason with the face that looked back at him. *This is a drunk woman in a bar in a one-horse*

beach town. You love your wife, you trust your wife, you're drunk. Get up. Leave. Sleep on it.

But who was Zach Pinker? And why was Anna so delighted to introduce them? And what was “everything” that he could be “cool with?” And what was so spectacularly crazy about running for office while married to Liza Brown?

And who *the fuck* was Liza Brown?

Okay, okay, okay, he thought. Don't panic and say something stupid.

Get up.

Go home.

Ask your wife about all this.

Go now.

CHAPTER 4

Beth set herself to working on the upstairs floors, where she had peeled back the tacky linoleum to uncover a decent hardwood that just needed refinishing. She didn't have an electric sander, but she needed something to do, and preferably something that burned off all her nervous energy. So she started sanding, by hand.

It disturbed her that Greg was out on the town by himself. She knew the chances of him running into any of the old crew – or specifically, the people she'd prefer he *never* ran into – were slim. And she also knew that even if he did, the odds of them having a conversation that would lead to talking about her were also slim. And that was why she had opted to stay home instead of going with him.

Greg wasn't an idiot: he had noticed her acting funny, avoiding going out, cutting conversations short, changing the subject. She knew he also wanted to ask her why she was dressing like a slob.

But at this point, after so many years of letting her past fade into oblivion, of putting it all behind her, of pretending, even to herself, that she had never been *that* person – well, she just didn't want to deal with it.

She didn't want Greg to find out about *her*.

She sighed as she had this thought, and looked up at the ceiling in despair. She groaned when she saw the water stains, which seemed bigger than the day before. *Why* did Greg have to get political ambitions? She couldn't stop him, but she couldn't bring herself to tell him that a danger lay in her past.

Not that the residents of Walla Beach would ever have known about Greg Quinn marrying her, or even cared. These people didn't even know what a representative was, much less who represented a county full of "cidiots" hundreds of miles from them. She doubted they even knew what a state legislature was.

And it wasn't like Greg was going to go around telling everyone about his political career: he wasn't running yet, and these people weren't his constituents. He wasn't a blabbermouth for precisely that reason. And even if he did happen to mention it, so what? No one knew he was married to her, and no one would...

But even as she talked herself into this narrative, she had a sinking feeling that something would slip. Someone would tug on the veil, and the whole facade would fall away.

And then Greg would know what kind of person he had married. And possibly that would put his career in danger.

And more than possibly, she would have to come clean about herself. And she feared what she would see in his eyes if she did.

She sawed away with the sandpaper, until she had gone through all the sheets and worn them down to smoothness. She looked at the sad patch of wood she had sanded. Her arms throbbed from overuse.

It was then that she heard the footsteps. She knew it was Greg, but in her chest, her heart pounded with the same fear as though she believed it was a burglar.

Somehow, she just knew.

*

“I ran into some old friends of yours tonight,” he said. His voice was loud, his eyes glassy. He was drunk, much more than usual.

Beth’s chest was tight. She looked out the window, seeing headlights bounce through the trees as a car turned around and headed back up the driveway. So she had no reason to ask, except to buy herself a moment to think: “You didn’t drive, did you?”

“Anna,” Greg continued, coming into the room, surveying the pile of used sandpaper, the patch of sanded floor between her legs, which were spread open in a v-shape. Then he looked back at her.

Beth very much wanted to get control of herself, but adrenaline had poured into her system. Her chest felt like an elephant was standing on it, and her limbs were filled with ice water. She could feel every hair on her body rise to attention. The sweat she had worked up sanding the floor was now chilling her.

She started to move the hand sander back and forth again. “Anna?” she repeated, as if she didn’t recognize the name.

Greg said nothing. But she could feel his fury, his instability. God, he was probably *really* drunk if he ran into Anna.

“Yeah,” he said, confrontationally, walking over to a chair and turning it around before sitting in it backward. “*Anna*. She seems to know

you really well.”

Beth looked up, her sanding slowing to a halt. “What is this?” she asked, trying to be lighthearted. “Police interrogation?”

“She seems to think,” Greg continued, totally unmoved by her attempt at a joke, “that your name is Liza. Is that true? That you used to go by Liza?”

Beth tried to will her blood pressure to stop spiking, and she gripped the sander in both hands so that if she was shaking, he wouldn’t notice. The cold in her limbs spread inward, and she was so cold now that she thought her teeth might chatter.

Greg had deliberately phrased his question in his most lawyerly way, leaving no way for her to "omit" anything, or be confused by the question.

The back of her neck, however, was hot. Unconsciously, she put her right hand to it and rubbed. Cold sweat coated her palm.

“Oh,” she said. It wasn’t as if she had never, ever, thought through this possibility, especially now that they seemed to be trapped here for the time being. “Anna Green.”

She tried to sound cheerful, like she was marveling at remembering somebody trivial she had nearly forgotten. “Must be her,” she added. She put her hand back on the sander and tried to sand, but the tool slipped out of her soaked grip. She wiped her hands on her jean shorts without thinking, and then looked up to see if Greg had noticed.

He had.

“How many Annas did you know in this town?” he asked, eyes narrowing.

She stumbled a little. “How many...?” She stopped herself. Repeating the question, Greg had told her on more than one occasion, was a sure sign that someone was looking for a moment to concoct a lie. “Uh, you know... maybe...” But these were the mumblings of a liar, a person who had forgotten that they were lying about remembering something. She changed tack, but she knew it was too late. “What? I don’t even... understand that question.” She shrugged, put her hands back on the sander, sawed back and forth. “Just her, I guess.”

“Uh-huh.”

She shot him a look. “You sound a little hostile,” she pointed out. She moved forward and back with the sander, stretching herself out. Whether Greg was hostile or not, she knew he had a nice view of her legs,

spread out like they were, and so maybe he would get distracted by what he claimed to be her best feature. Her legs were very slender and almost impossibly long.

“You’re changing the subject,” Greg said coolly.

“You’re drunk,” she shot back. Then she folded her legs up and stood. “I’m not going to talk to you when you’re like this.”

Greg wasn’t having it. “I’m drunk,” he said. “But not that drunk. I just want to know the answer to my question. And you’re avoiding it.”

She put her hand on her hip. She knew which question he wanted the answer to, there was no way to forget it: it was ricocheting in her head, playing to the sound of a carousel at a circus.

“What question is that?” she said, trying to sound annoyed. But she sounded scared, and she heard it in her own voice. She felt her lips quiver, and so she pressed them together and hugged herself in an attempt to steady any shaking that Greg would pick up on.

He was annoyingly good at that.

“Liza. *Liza*. Did you go by the name Liza when you lived here?”

Greg shot the question out like machine-gun fire, a man assured that he already knew the answer.

She laughed under her breath, haughtily. “Why are you asking me like that? God. Yes, I used to go by a different nickname when I lived in this dump and went to high school with a bunch of losers. Congratulations, Sherlock. You found one more person who had a stupid nickname in high school. *Gorbs*.”

Greg did not react to this the way she had anticipated. He kept his eyes on her, his mouth open in slight disbelief – a disdained disbelief, if she had to categorize it. His head moved to the right, then to the left, in a slow and disapproving shake, his eyes never leaving hers.

Oh God, she thought. *How much does he know?*

“Why didn’t you ever say anything about that?”

“Anything about what, Greg?” she said, feigning exasperation. “A stupid nickname?” She fidgeted with some boxes.

Greg said nothing. He was still looking at her with disbelief on his face.

And then he dropped a bomb.

“Who’s Zach Pinker, then?”

Beth looked down at her feet, maybe hoping to see whatever had left her body and sunken into the floor, leaving her utterly empty. She didn't have a thought in her head, couldn't even nail herself down to a feeling.

Try to be funny? Try to be angry? Try to be cool? Try to blow him off?

"Oh, God," she said sullenly. "Did you run into him, too?"

"I *did*, Liza Brown. I ran into him, and I ran into Anna. And Anna had some very interesting things to say to me."

Panic gripped her. She shot a look at him. "Like *what*?"

"Like about Zach Pinker and you."

Beth's knees actually gave out, and she felt herself crumpling to the floor. She had read about that in books, but it was something she never believed in. Now here she was, folding up on the floor like an empty pair of pants, and she couldn't do anything about it.

"How much did she tell you?" she whispered.

It must have been something close to everything. Anna was like that. She couldn't keep secrets, and she had an axe to grind with Beth. A girl-fight ax, the kind of vague feminine hatred that hid behind friendship and had nothing to do with any kind of reality they actually lived. It was a feral, jungle-borne competitive axe, and she could have said anything at all.

Then she looked up at Greg. "Look, listen to me. I didn't tell you about all of this because... because... it just never came up. Okay? And I just, I wanted to put it behind me. And you. And none of this was ever going to matter, except that we had to come back here to this stupid -"

"Is this why you've been acting so weird?"

She nodded. Tears were coming to her eyes so she looked down to hide them.

"So what, you and Zach Pinker. And what?"

Beth snapped her eyes up to look at Greg. "What do you mean, 'what'?"

"I mean, and what *else*, Beth? Your different name. Your ex-boyfriend you never mentioned. Your girlfriend Anna. 'The stories I could tell you,' she says. 'You cool with everything, with Liza?' That's what. *What else?*"

Beth stared at him, her mouth open. She shook her head. Anna hadn't, it would seem, told him anything much.

Or she had, and he was pretending that she hadn't.

But it seemed like maybe she could get away with not telling him the whole story. She felt her spirits lifting, her body temperature returning to normal. She sniffed. “Just that,” she sniffed, wiping her nose on her wrist. “I mean, what else is there?”

She was fishing, and he knew it. She could see it in his eyes.

“And then,” he said quietly, “Anna said, ‘you’re married to Liza Brown and you’re running for *office*?’ She said it like that, Beth. What did she mean by that?”

“*WHY?!?*” Beth howled, her own voice light-years ahead of her thoughts. “Why? Why? *Why* would you fucking tell her that?!” She stood up, knocking over some of the boxes in her rage-induced intoxication. “How could you be so *stupid*?” She slapped her hand to her forehead. She started shaking her head, and tears welled up in her eyes.

“How could I be so stupid? How could *I* be so stupid? What the hell is that supposed to mean, Beth? I was so stupid because running for office is something I’m doing. I could be so stupid because I have a wife named Beth Quinn, not Liza Brown. I could be so stupid because I didn’t expect to go into a bar and mention I’m married to you and have the whole creepy town and some lumberjack mongoloid laugh at me and ask me why I’m crazy enough to marry you. That’s why!” He knocked over an empty box as he waved his hands around. Beth couldn’t tell if it was accidental or a deliberate punch. She jumped.

“So get talking, Beth,” he yelled. “Get talking about whatever it is I need to know about Liza Brown.”

There were many ways to go with this. Beth had a sense that she should take the highest road, and just tell him the truth.

But the thing about the truth was: she had never really lied about it. She had simply omitted it.

All of it.

A lot of it.

Most of it.

All of it that probably mattered.

And the thing about omissions was this: it was hard to know how to reverse them completely. It was hard to know how much Greg really wanted to hear, what was enough that he would feel like he had the truth. Details? Every single one? Broad strokes? Could she get away with pretending like she didn’t have a clue what it was that Anna was hinting at?

The tapes were gone.

She closed her eyes. Then she opened them and spoke calmly.

“Look. I don’t know what Anna said to you, but this is all just... bullshit. She’s a vindictive, crazy little brat, and she had the hots for Zach all through high school and beyond. But Zach and I... dated, I guess. And she was jealous. The rest of it... it’s just Anna making a big deal out of basically nothing.”

“The whole bar seemed to think it was something.”

An intense, uncontrollable rage shot through her. It blinded her; for a moment she only saw white. Now she was shaking again, but it was with a white-hot rage.

“Those *fuckers*,” she said, taking note of the two swearwords she had uttered, unusual for her, “have a big laugh because of some stupid shit from ten years ago, and you were like, what? ‘Oh, a bunch of knuckle-dragging morons in a bar were like heh-heh-heh and snickered when I mentioned I was married to the high school hotty, and so I’m going to go home and grill her?’ About what? Huh, Greg? What are you asking me? If I fucked my boyfriend from high school? Is that it? What a fucking exposé. I guess you didn’t fuck Jenny Carpenter, right? Or Mariah, or Angie? Christ. What did you think? I was a virgin?”

She paused, panting lightly from her outburst. Greg looked defeated, and utterly confused and she almost felt sorry for him. It was tempting to soften her tone, to apologize, to laugh all of it off. But the anger was still boiling inside of her.

It wasn't directed at Greg, of course. Her heart felt a little bruised that she had to keep going, commit to this line, make him think he was barking up the wrong, stupid tree.

Because if there was one thing she really didn’t want, one thing she just didn’t need right now, it was Greg thinking less of her.

For any reason.

That was all behind her now.

And it didn’t need to be revisited.

“Screw those guys!” she yelled. “But you, too. What are you *even* doing, coming home drunk and asking me stuff like this?”

Greg looked sheepish for a moment. But she had, as on many other occasions, underestimated his prosecutorial abilities, even while he was

drunk. This was a man who was always on the spot, and for stakes that were much higher than whatever he thought was happening here.

“I told you about Jenny. And Mariah. And Angie,” he said, his voice wooden. “And you told me about... about Steve Gallino, about that guy Mark, about some dude named Chance. About Mexico. We *told* each other about all of that. But you never said a word about this guy... this... Zach.” He was looking at her, giving her what he called the dead-eyed stare of truth. “So, what I want to know, Beth, is this: *why is that?*”

She scoffed at him. She did it to buy herself a moment to think, because it was a good question. It was the *right* question, if what he wanted to do was uncover the truth.

“There’s nothing *to* tell,” she said quietly. “It was... an omission. Okay? Because it just... it just... never came up.”

“So that’s it.”

“What’s ‘it?’”

“You just dated this guy Zach. And fucked him. And that’s all there is to this story. There’s nothing else. You’ve told the whole truth, and nothing but the truth?”

Beth was cold, and she found it hard to breathe.

It wasn’t the whole truth. But again, what did that even mean? Did telling the whole truth involve telling every detail of, say, eating a Fig Newton on a Tuesday afternoon when she was in high school?

“It’s all there is to Zach,” she said. “I don’t know what else you think is there, or what Anna made you think is there. But yeah. I dated Zach. I had a long, stupid, immature relationship with him. We had a lot of stupid fights, a lot of people witnessed them. And I fucked him. A lot.”

She was suddenly angry again, and she knew that it welled up from inside her where she was angry with herself, or with Zach, or with some combination therein. But she directed it straight at Greg, and even as she was speaking, she felt terrible for what she was saying. But she couldn’t stop, because she could see that this was a soft spot for Greg, and if she kept pushing on it, she might get him to recoil from the whole thing and drop the subject.

She folded her arms across her chest and stepped forward. “I fucked him *a lot*. I did things with him that I will never do with anyone else. And it was fun. And I liked it.”

She could see how her words were hurting Greg. He looked like he was taking a punch with each syllable, and she wanted to take it all back. His face was pale, his lips a jagged line of pursed anger and hurt.

Her own heart felt crushed, too. Tears were welling up in her eyes. “But then, I grew up. And I realized that he was a meat-head and a jerk. And I left this town, and I stopped being Liza Brown. And I moved on with my life, and then I met you, and I didn’t mention any of that. You know why? You know why Greg? Because it didn’t *matter* anymore.”

She spun and stomped out of the room and down the stairs. She snatched the car keys from the wall, which prompted Greg to stomp across the floor and yell, “Where are you going?! Beth?!”

“Out!” she shrieked.

And damn, if that wasn’t just like old times, stomping out of this kitchen with someone yelling at her, furious.

At least now she had a better car.

CHAPTER 5

She regretted everything she'd said almost as soon as she got out of the house, but she didn't want to go back in just then. She turned left at the driveway, planning to drive out of town, on the back roads, and then come back home.

It was ill-advised, selfish, and silly, but she didn't want to go back and apologize just yet.

She pounded the steering wheel in frustration and yelled.

A large, untamed conservation area that had been a former plantation took up thousands of acres just outside of town. Few lights, few farms or houses, for miles in almost every direction.

At least that was how it had been back in the day. She turned down a dirt road to follow an old route, one that she and Anna would take in their car on their way out to parties at their friends' houses, out in the boonies. She did it almost without thinking, and when she realized what she was doing she decided to turn around and go back to apologize to Greg. There was a concession road about a mile from where she was, where she could easily turn around. It was easy to end up in a ditch on these crappy roads, which didn't seem to have been improved since she had lived here.

At the top of the hill, however, a bright light glowed, almost ominously. It looked like something out of a movie about alien invasions. Curiosity got the better of her and she drove up to the crest of the hill to see what it was.

She could see from the top of the hill that an immense... what? Farm? Greenhouse? had been built on what had been a modest crop field that often lay fallow in the past. Now, a huge garage, an enormous greenhouse, and a really large, well-kept home were on the property, and a *parking lot* had been swept over the infertile fields.

She kept driving, just to see what it was.

"What the...?" she said aloud, as the sign came into view.

Pinker Landscaping

She turned into the parking lot. Bright lights blazed above her, and the inside of the immense building and greenhouse was brightly lit, though empty and obviously closed. It looked like an enormous, well-run business.

But *Pinker*?

She stared at the sign, dumbfounded. Sure, the simplest explanation was usually the right one, and in that case, "Pinker" could only mean *the* Pinker - Zach - the only Pinker she had ever heard of being in this town. Zach didn't have his dad's last name, and his mom was dead.

But Zach also didn't have: money, or much of a work ethic, or, as far as she had ever known, an interest in landscaping.

As she pondered the whole bizarre situation, a truck pulled into the drive that led up to the immense house she had seen. It slowed, and then the reverse lights lit up, and it wheeled backward to the turnoff to the parking lot.

It took her a few seconds to put it all together, and by the time she had, it was too late to take off without looking like a fool. She put the car in reverse and looked around helplessly: there was no way to get out except to go toward the truck, and the truck was coming right toward her.

She couldn't see the driver. But she already knew who it was.

"Shit. Shit, shit, shit, shit, shit, shit," she whispered.

Her assumption that it was Zach was confirmed when the truck drove up, almost like it would t-bone her. She leaned over and opened the glove box, like she was looking for something inside, but she turned to look at the lights.

More natural, she told herself. Act like you do not even care.

She recognized his frame - unchanged, still fit, broad-shouldered and muscled, a bigger guy, but no portly belly or flabby arms had come for Zach Pinker. He walked straight to the window, assertive and calm, like he had always been.

She had gone out of her way to avoid Zach Pinker. But she had always believed that if she ran into him, it would just be awkward. She had painted him in her mind as a loser, a guy who had never gone anywhere or done anything, and so anything that had happened ten years ago would be a thing of the past.

She loved Greg.

She never thought about Zach.

Almost never.

And so, when she saw his face, as he leaned over to look into the car, one arm on the roof, the last thing she was expecting to happen was for her stomach to flutter, and a warm, real, ache in the lowest reaches of her abdomen to turn to liquid and seep into her panties.

She was still leaning over, pretending that there was something in the glove box. Her chest was tight, her blood racing, and her pussy throbbing. Just from seeing him through the window.

"Liza Brown," he said, and the way he said it could have meant anything.

She stopped moving, sat up. Feigned complete surprise, which wasn't very hard because it was all very surprising in its own way. "Zach? What, uh...?"

The window was rolled up. Zach reached down and opened the car door, standing aside after he did, like he was a chauffeur and letting her out.

And this was the thing about Zach. This was how he did things. He just *did* them, and the way that he did them had some kind of gravitational pull that you couldn't escape. If he opened your car door and stood to the side like that, you just got out of your car. You didn't know why, or ask why, or think about doing something else.

You just did it.

It was infuriating, and Beth hated him for it.

But she turned off the engine, unclipped her seatbelt, swung her legs over to the side, and stood up. She positioned herself in the line of the car door, so that he couldn't shut it. He started to push it anyway, because that was the sort of thing Zach did. And so she moved.

They were face to face now, staring at each other. Beth was trying, desperately, to find a thought in her head to cling to. All of her contingency plans for if she ran into him - plans she'd lain awake thinking through, things she'd rehearsed saying in the car alone - it all went out of her head.

"Nice beard," she said, idiotically. She actually didn't like it, and she was grateful that he had it, because she feared that beneath it, his face had only gotten better, more intense. A brief thought of his stubble against the inside of her thigh made her entire body twitch, and then, almost like no time had passed between this moment and the last time she had fucked him, she felt the thick, straining bulk of his cock inside of her, and a wave of her juices gushed into her underwear.

Zach rubbed the beard thoughtfully. His eyes were on her, still containing the same hypnotic power, and she looked away. She folded her arms over her chest and jerked her head in the direction of the greenhouse. "Don't tell me this is all yours."

"How long you been in town?" he answered, as if that were the logical answer to the question she had asked.

She shook her head and looked at her feet. "No," she said, nonsensically. No, she wasn't doing this. No, she wasn't going to answer him. No, she was not wildly aroused by his presence. No, to all of it.

She couldn't see him, just the motion of his body, as his core shook almost imperceptibly with a private chuckle.

"Whatcha doin' here, Liza?" he asked. There it was, the dangerous undertone, the voice that would swoop in and get her to do almost anything.

"Beth," she said, looking up at him. She almost yelled it. "I go by Beth now."

"Yeah, I heard about that," he said, fishing a pack of cigarettes out of his pocket. He held it towards her before taking one, and she shook her head again and shifted her position, leaning against the car, crossing one ankle over the other. She was trying to look nonchalant. She would shoot the shit and then get out of here, that was the plan.

He lit the cigarette and the scent of it, mixed with the scent of him - all still the same, tobacco and soap, sweat and the red clay earth, and then just *him* - made her dizzy, crave a cigarette. Her insides squeezed. She moved a hand, barely, toward the door handle. "I gotta -" she began.

"Can't believe you come into town, don't even stop by to say hello."

She looked over at the greenhouse. "Didn't know where to find you," she said.

Zach took a drag of his cigarette, and as he did, he looked her up and down. If he had used a feather to stroke her bare skin, she would have felt it less than his eyes moving over her body.

He made no comment on his assessment, just looked back at her eyes. She held them steadfastly on a point in the center of his forehead, no matter where they wanted to go. And they wanted to go everywhere: she wanted to assess whether he was still -

Still what? she demanded of herself. Built? Muscled? She already could see that he was. It's not like anything would have happened to what was down there... was she hoping to find a bulge pressing against his jeans, confirm that he still had a thing for her?

"So you're married now," he stated flatly.

"And you have a... landscaping business," she said. She sounded corny, not like herself. He would pick up on that, and she knew it.

Maybe he was married. Maybe like her, he had changed completely. Maybe she was reading all of this all wrong. She looked at his chest, just while she tried to figure out how to ask that question without making a fool of herself like she just had. Almost as if he was reading her thoughts, he moved just a little closer.

She leaned back, but the car was there, and there was not much she could do but press against its form.

Zach stood in front of her, unmoving. Another wave of intense, animal arousal whirled through her, but this time it came in the form of a flash-fantasy: she could almost feel his body leaning into hers, feel herself spinning around, pressed against the still-warm hood of the car. In her pussy, the throb of longing that she felt transformed into a memory: the feel of his cock, almost too large, his balls, slapping against her sticky thighs, the feral, overpowering thrust of his cock that left sweet, raw bruises in unspeakable places.

Just as quickly, her mind played out the aftermath: Greg's face, when - not if, *when* - he found out, the crushing pain of having destroyed something beautiful and steady, and *right*, the ever-downward pull of the addictive sexual obsession she had felt with Zach.

The two emotions mixed: shame and arousal, and the effect made her so nauseated she knew she would never be able to expunge the bad taste of it. This wasn't something she could do, it wasn't something she could fall into.

The hypnotic spell she had been under snapped, shaking her from the paralysis she had been experiencing. She willed her hand toward the handle of the car door. "I, uh... didn't mean to -"

"You dress like that all the time?" Zach said, disarming her again. But he was stepping back, lifting his hand, so that when the car door opened, he could take the top of it and pull it open for her. "Some city thing, or what?"

She sat down in the car. Her senses were coming back to her in direct proportion to the increased physical distance between her and Zach. She felt her thighs slide against each other in silky wetness as she climbed in, but her mind was refocused: she needed to get out of here, now.

She reached for the door, and Zach pushed it toward her. "I'm renovating," she told him, hoping to sound dry and disinterested. "What's the story with the beard?"

She got nothing more than a dry laugh, exhaled through his nose, with no smile accompanying it.

They closed the door together, and Zach lifted a hand in one of his too-cool-for-school gestures, stepping back from the car. But his eyes were still on hers, holding her captive, tempting her. There had never been a feeling, in her whole life - not even with Greg, who she loved, *really* loved - like the one that she had when Zach stared at her like that, with his cock deep in her pussy, fucking her until she came, over and over again. Only after she was exhausted would he free her of that magnetic power, turn her slippery body over, and pound her distended pussy full of cum. That had been her favorite part, if she had ever been forced to disclose it: the reduction of her body, through several rounds of excruciating pleasure, to nothing more than a puddle of sweat and her own juices, that could do nothing more than lie there and take the pleasurable abuse of his animal fucking.

But she would never, *ever*, reveal that to anyone. Not Zach - who seemed to know it anyway - and certainly *never* Greg.

She gripped the steering wheel to brace herself against another shudder. Then she smiled, put the car in gear, and looked forward, toward the greenhouse.

A rap at the window made her jump.

She rolled it down, flustered.

"That's my place, up there," Zach said. "Havin' a few friends over Saturday night. You should come by. Bring the hubby, what's his name? Greg?"

"Yeah," she said quickly, stunned.

"He some kind of politician, that it?" Zach said. His face hadn't changed much, but she knew him well. The most dangerous qualities in him were alight, swimming behind his cool veneer. He talked like a hick, but Zach's thoughts were more profound, more devious, more intelligent than the rest of these people.

Fear stabbed her in the chest. *Goddammit*, why had Greg told them that?

She looked out the windshield again. "Not yet," she said. It didn't strike her as a good enough downplaying of Greg's career, so she added, "He's just a lawyer."

"Liza Brown. Married to a senator."

"Repre-" she began, looking up quickly to Zach, who was already smiling.

Devious.

He pounded twice on the roof of the car. "Stop by Saturday," he said. "It's always a good time."

And then, because Zach was the kind of guy who told people to do things, and rarely asked questions, and because even when he asked questions he didn't wait for answers, he turned, very calmly, and strutted back to his car.

Which was fine by Beth, because she didn't have a chance to say the words that had already formed in her mouth.

We'll try.

CHAPTER 6

After Beth left, Greg briefly considered calling a cab back and returning to town, but he didn't know what he would do there. He wasn't going to confront anyone, and even if he thought he had the mettle for it, he was an attorney with a license to keep, and that kind of confrontation stood the chance of going really wrong.

He opened up all the cupboards in the kitchen, and even went out to the small attached garage that was filled with junk, in search of more alcohol. He found a bottle labeled Jack Daniels, but the color of the liquid was more than a little off, and he decided to give it a pass.

Lacking any booze to keep his bad mood fed, he tried calling Beth. The phone only rang and rang before delivering him to her voicemail. It wasn't unusual for her, because she often kept it turned off, but it infuriated him.

Not enough to leave her a message.

But it was still infuriating.

A moment of clarity came to him: he was drunk. This would all seem different in the morning, and from past experience, he knew that it would probably also look a lot more like his own fault. It was probably in his best interests to go to bed.

He looked around aimlessly, searching for some reason not to do just that, but none presented itself. He climbed the stairs morosely, showered with his ears attuned to the sound of Beth returning, and went to bed in much the same way: with a drunk's hesitation, the vague sense that the messes wreaked by his drunkenness could be untangled, if only *something* changed.

He was asleep within minutes after lying down.

He didn't hear Beth come home, except in the vaguest of senses. He heard her come into the house; she came up the stairs and stood by the door for several moments, looking into the room they were sharing. He didn't want to start a fight, so he pretended to be deep asleep.

She turned and walked out, and he could hear her doing something downstairs. By then, perhaps he had sobered up sufficiently to have an intelligent thought. He let himself drift off to sleep.

He woke up in the fevered heat of too many drinks, and it took him a moment to remember where he was and the events of the evening. They came slowly percolating into his mind as he lay there. He was lying on his stomach, and he felt like cringing as the events of the evening replayed in his mind.

But as the fog of his memory wore off, the realization that something had *woken* him up rose to the forefront of his mind.

Beth was in bed next to him, and he could feel the radiant heat of her body along the left side of his own. There was a slow, minute motion, steady and rhythmic, shaking the bed ever-so-slightly.

Greg went cold, stunned, when he registered Beth's breathing: she was masturbating next to him in the bed.

This went on for some time, and Greg didn't dare move, not even his eyes. He got an erection, and it pressed painfully against the mattress. All the time, he had a sinking feeling in his gut, and it got deeper and more twisted, as he remembered what had led up to her leaving, what he had learned that evening about the woman he had believed he knew so well.

When she came, her body seized and jerked, and a small gasp left her lips. She was otherwise silent.

Greg waited a long time, listening to her breathing as it slowed, until he was sure she was really asleep. Then he rolled over cautiously and looked at his wife.

Her hair crowned her head like a halo, and she looked like a painted doll as she slept blissfully.

The question clanged inside of him, loudly and violently:

Who was this person he had married?

*

A patch of moving sunlight woke him the next morning, creeping across the bed and over his eyes. It gouged through his eyelids, and he lay there, on his stomach, feeling his hangover come to life. His head felt desiccated, and his mouth was bone-dry. But he clung stubbornly to an attempt to sleep, because the fragments of the previous evening had been stirred up in his consciousness.

Beth was not next to him in the bed when he at last opened his eyes and rolled over to face the inevitable music of the night before.

But she had propped up a note next to a tall glass of a supplement drink that she took when she had a hangover and insisted that he took as well.

Good morning.

Well. It was a start.

He drank the drink, which for once hit the spot, and then called out. "Beth?"

Getting no reply, he eased himself into the bathroom and stood underneath the showerhead. For a few minutes he just tried to steady himself and clear the careening, leaden hangover from his head.

But the slivers of the previous evening, specifically all of the comments from Anna that had been so alarming, began to coalesce, and from the same coherent and disturbing thought that had plagued him as he fell asleep last night:

His wife had secrets, and something about those secrets was very, very bad.

Sure, she had claimed that there was nothing more to Anna's suggestions than that Zach Pinker was an ex-boyfriend, and that had been an explanation that he had been happy to try and believe last night.

But it didn't add up, and it didn't explain why she had reacted so... unusually, and violently, to the news that he had mentioned running for office.

Above all, it didn't explain where she went, and why - *why?* - she had come home and, of all things, secretly masturbated.

There was a sticky substance linking all of these things together, something Greg knew was probably very bad.

It wasn't going well with his hangover.

He stayed in the shower until the water turned cold, which really didn't take very long in this house. He turned the faucet off and stared at the subway tiles, dripping, slightly chilled.

He hated fights with Beth, and he *hated* disagreements that didn't get resolved the night before. He hated waking up and having to smooth things over first thing. It didn't happen often, and even when it did, it was usually some banal, petty dispute, like whether or not laundry should be folded this way or that. This had the very unpleasant quality of feeling actually

important, and therefore unavoidable, and he was pretty sure she had some ammunition for making a case that it was his fault.

He sighed, grabbed a towel, towed off for far longer than required, and then dressed slowly, before trotting down the stairs, after giving himself a silent pep talk in the mirror.

Beth was not downstairs, and he worried for a moment that she had left in anger - not a typical move by her, but a possibility - before he recalled her nice note and the drink she'd left him. The kitchen was much cleaner than the night before, which was one of the positive outcomes of having a "discussion." Someone always went to town on the housekeeping. Beth called it "Anger Cleaning."

He glanced out the window just in time to see her car turning into the driveway. He caught a glimpse of her face: neutral. She was driving in an ordinary, non-aggressive way. Hope fluttered in his stomach: maybe this would just... resolve.

She was wearing the Walla Beach uniform: long, shapeless cutoffs and an oversized t-shirt, hair in a bun, and glasses. As she unloaded the car, hefting a laundry basket out of the back, the shirt slipped a little on her shoulder and revealed the creamy contours of her collarbone and part of her chest.

It was a pretty non-sexual body part, but the sight of it still stimulated him.

He opened the door for her and held it. She winked at him as she came through the door. "How's the head, slugger?"

She leaned over her teetering baskets to kiss him and then wedged her way through the small door frame. "You were out cold. So I took all this crap to the laundromat. Now we have..." she hefted the baskets onto the old table, "towels and linens. Ta-da."

She looked up at him and lifted a hand to push a stray lock of hair from her face, blowing at it at the same time, which was one of his favorite nonsensical habits of hers.

Greg was uncertain about her mood, so he smiled in a way that he was sure came across as nonplussed. But Beth was already talking in an instant. "Look. About last night. And Zach. And Anna... and all that. I'm sorry. It was a stupid fight, these are stupid people, they don't have anything better to do with their time than get drunk and talk shit."

Relief traveled through Greg's spine. He tried to think of something congenial to say, but his mind was slow-moving. Beth was already talking again by the time he had thought of a single thing to say. She was reaching into the laundry baskets, fishing something out. "I think maybe we need some mental space," she said. "I know we said we'd stay here and try to save money and work on... all of this," she said, sighing as she looked around. "But I think we should take a break. So..." her face brightened. "I took the liberty of getting an Air BNB in White Beach for the weekend. I know it's not here, and I know it's expensive, but -"

"It's a great idea," Greg said, his words sticking to the back of his throat. He cleared it and smiled. "I love it."

Beth blew and swiped at her stray hair again. "Phew," she said, and he saw the first genuine smile from her that he had seen in a while. "I'm glad to hear that."

She came around the table, smiling, and slipped her arms around his waist. Other than her ridiculous clothing, she seemed like her old self, and even though something about it all was obviously "off," Greg let himself get taken along for the ride.

After all, he was powerless against Beth's charms, and there was no point in pretending he wasn't. And he didn't really *want* for last night to have even happened, or for his wife to have some dark secret, or to fight about it.

He didn't want to go to White Beach, either, but he would go anywhere with Beth for a weekend, if it meant escaping this weird town and whatever it was that she wanted to hide from, or hide from him.

So it wasn't very hard for him to delude himself, and kiss her back, and agree to go to White Beach for the weekend.

Even though until they sold this heap of a house, they were flat broke.

And so that's what they did. And by the time the next week rolled around, it was almost like the whole thing had never happened.

CHAPTER 7

Several days after returning from White Beach

The envelope was on the steps to the front porch. Manila, legal-sized. A dirt-caked garden gnome with a broken hat sat atop it.

Greg looked around. It was a stifling day, cicadas trilled relentlessly, and the scene had the distinct quality of the beginning of a horror film.

Beth was in Harrison, a "town" with a paint supply store, and he was returning from the hardware store. They had decided to tackle their renovations as quickly and as dirtily as possible, put the house up, and pray it sold quickly so they could get back to the city and put Walla Beach out of their mind forever.

And now this.

He removed the gnome, seeing the imprint of the statue in the garden bed, overgrown with weeds, next to the porch. He tossed the gnome into the tangle of weeds and picked up the envelope.

It was light, with a small hard object sliding inside of it. On the outside of it, in black marker and block letters was written:

MR AND MRS QUINN.

He stared at the envelope, which bent toward the ground where the object weighed it down.

He looked around one more time, as if there was anything to be gained by staring into the mess of untended property around the house or listening to the shrill buzz of the insects. He knew what was inside the envelope, as anyone would: the shape, the weight, the feel of the package indicated that a USB key was inside.

Once inside, he sat down at the kitchen table. It was one of those old-school tables from the sixties, with chrome trim around a tacky Formica top that had been burned in several places by the placement of a pot directly on the surface. The envelope wasn't sealed, just held closed by the flimsy metal tabs at the top. He unfolded them and turned the envelope over into his upturned palm. A USB key - cheap, the kind you find at any drugstore nowadays, fell into his hands.

There was nothing else in the envelope.

A feeling of sickness gripped him, starting somewhere in his groin and working up to his stomach. It was so overpowering that he quickly moved through nausea, to pain, to an entirely different state of illness that he had never experienced. In spite of the stifling heat, he was suddenly cold, and his hands were damp with sweat.

USB keys usually meant photos, or videos, and USB keys left anonymously on porches with strange addressees usually meant something bad. Maybe he had watched too many movies. Nothing like this had ever happened to him in real life.

He pushed the chair away and moved, in slow motion, or what came to him as stop-motion, up the stairs and into the bedroom piled with junk that he had been using as a makeshift office. The heat was stifling, but he barely noticed it, and he didn't think at all to turn on the air conditioning unit crammed into the little window. He moved like a zombie to his laptop, sat down on the frilly white twin bed, opened the computer, and inserted the USB key.

Then he stared at the screen for a few moments.

A few things went through his mind: he should wait for "Mrs. Quinn;" he should throw it away, where was the associated request or explanation? He wasn't really about to get blackmailed, was he?

He pulled up the contents of the stick.

Dozens of files, all of them video files. mp4s. They had not been named, but instead contained meaningless strings of numbers.

It felt like a live animal was in his stomach. Sweat dripped from his temple onto the keyboard of his laptop. He swiped it away, wiped his brow. Only then did he realize that the chill that had overtaken him had gone away, and now he was so hot he felt lightheaded.

But he did nothing about it. He stared at the files, mouse hovering over the first one.

What's the rule? Never ask a question you don't know the answer to, never open a file you don't know what it contains, never do *anything* like that. How many lawyers wish they could go back in time and retract their curiosity, their over-sharing client's stories, un-hear or un-watch something?

He clicked on the file.

The beginning of the file had no sound, so even as the horror he was watching unfolded on the screen, he was trying to fiddle with the sound on his computer. A very, very young Beth - but Beth, definitely - with blond

streaks in her hair and a strangely-makeupped face, was sitting on a bed. She had her legs crossed, and what looked like a black two-piece swimsuit on. She was smiling, talking.

It looked like the beginning of a cheesy porno. There was no reason, necessarily, to think that: it was a girl, sitting on a bed, smiling. Some part of his mind wanted badly for it to not look like a porno, that part of his brain was throwing ideas into the swirling hurricane that was overtaking his mind: maybe it's a presentation of some kind, a funny skit, something they put on Instagram... was there Instagram this long ago?...

The sound corrected itself, suddenly, and the trail end of a male voice saying something roared, cut off by a tinkling laugh, and a female voice that sounded so unlike like Beth, but which at the same time *was* Beth, saying, "whatever you say."

And then she looked off to her left, smiling: something was coming toward her.

Greg's legs gave out on him, his knees folded, and he gripped the laptop so it wouldn't fall over, as he slid off the edge of the bed to the floor.

The cock came in from the right side of the screen first, then the body it was attached to. The very young Beth licked her lips, smiling, and reached for it. Her hand closed over it, and her mouth opened.

"That's it, baby. Open up for him."

She opened her mouth, and a hand appeared, pulling her head toward the pelvis of the man whose cock was disappearing into her mouth.

Greg stared at the screen, as the full, numerous inches of cock disappeared, all in one go, into his wife's mouth. But the killer, the knife that tore through him, was that her eyes went to the camera.

"Now suck it," the voice said, and it sounded vaguely familiar. It was coming from near the camera, probably behind it.

Greg's mouth was open in disbelief. He stared as Beth, with her eyes on the camera, or the cameraman, sucked hard on the cock in her mouth. Her nostrils flared as she tried to manage breathing, and her cheeks puffed out grotesquely. Her eyes grew watery, but she kept on sucking, as the voice on the camera told her she was doing a very good job.

"Think you can do two?" the voice said, as she released the cock in her mouth to catch her breath.

The young Beth on the screen, lipstick faded, mouth surrounded by a light, swollen pink, mascara smearing slightly below her right eye, nodded

eagerly.

And then, to Greg's horror, the camera moved, and the scene panned out, and yet another guy appeared on the left side of the screen, dick in hand, head somewhere above the scene, anonymous.

Beth turned to him and took his cock in her other hand, while she stroked the cock of the guy she had just sucked on. Then, with her eyes still on the cameraman - or on Greg, who at this point had been sucked deeply into the scene and no longer knew where he was - she opened her mouth and pulled the new cock inside.

Sucking earnestly, like she had with the first dick, she worked hard on this second man.

"Now give Donny there a little attention, honey. Alternate. Suck them both off, give them each a turn."

Beth complied, her mouth smiling each time she released one cock and turned to work on the other. She pumped her head on each dick two times, taking them all the way into her mouth, her eyes on the camera the entire time.

This went on for what seemed like an eternity, Beth's eyes hovering placidly over first one dick, then the other, taunting him, looking straight into *his* eyes while she gagged on cock. A sticky slurping sound came from her mouth, and her eyes eventually spilled over, her mascara making a dark river on each of her cheeks.

"Donny, you gonna fuck her or what? Get up on that bed, keep sucking on Jay, baby. Donny's gonna see if you can take his dick."

"She can take it," someone assured the narrator.

The characters on the screen changed positions with the same awkward movements of any amateur porn stars, Beth climbing onto the bed, then hungrily stuffing "Jay's" cock back into her mouth. Jay grabbed her hair and held her head in his grip, and began to rock his hips back and forth, fucking her in the face. Beth held steady, her throat emitting a glugging, cacking sound.

"Donny," meanwhile, had moved around behind her, and pulled down the bottom of the swimsuit, to her mid-thighs. Beth showed no sign of fatigue or discomfort, just kept her mouth open and let her face get fucked, while Donny guided his cock to her pussy.

"Don't you fuck her in the ass while she's got my dick in her mouth," the fellow named Jay said, laughing.

"Don't you fuck her in the ass either way," the cameraman said, and there was a moment of seriousness, sort of outside of the fantastical world of the sex scene. "Her ass is mine."

There was a moan from Beth's throat, muffled by the cock stuffed in her mouth, as Donny shoved his decent-sized cock into her pussy. A spurt indicated that Beth was a more than willing participant in this venture.

Her body went back and forth between them in a ping-pong motion once they settled into a rhythm, her pussy sloshing loudly and the gagging sounds still cackling from her throat.

"Oh fuck, I'm gonna spill it," Jay groaned, and gripped her head, pushing her away from him. He was trying to tilt her face back and come on it, but he was already spurting all over the bed by the time he pulled out of her mouth.

"That's okay, that's okay," the cameraman said. "She'll lick it up. That'll still be good. She likes that, don't you, you little slut? Donny, push her head down there, get her to lick it up, shit, that's a good shot."

Greg felt like an actual knife had been jammed into his stomach, the pain was so bad, as Donny, who was kneeling on the bed, lifted a foot and swung it up, with his dick still in Beth's pussy, to push her face to the bed.

Beth turned, and the cameraman urged her to look at the camera and lick it all up. She complied, staring right at Greg, a foot grinding her head to the bed, as her tongue left her mouth and lapped at the cum.

"Slurp it," the cameraman told her. "Donny ease up on her a little, let her suck it up."

Donny released his foot from her head, and she turned to suck at the covers, making a soupy, wet sound as she sucked at Jay's cum.

"Get over here, man," the voice said, and the camera went wildly askew for a few moments. When things came back into focus and stopped moving, Donny was crossing in front of the camera, and Beth had her mouth open for his shiny, pussy-covered cock.

"Lick him off real nice," the camera-voice said, but now he was behind Beth.

"You gonna stick it in now, man? Because I don't want to get my dick bit off."

The man behind Beth was slowly removing his clothes. He had black hair, a muscled build, and it didn't take much for Greg to figure out that he was looking at the disrobing body of a younger Zach Pinker. Tattoos

covered his chest. He slapped Beth's ass, and the crack was loud enough to distort the sound. "She ain't gonna bite you," he said. "Are you, baby?"

Beth smiled and looked up at Donny, her tongue making crazy patterns on his dick. She answered with a slutty, untrustable laugh.

"You been a good girl, Liza? Jay, you like your blowjob?"

He had his cock out now, a thick, sizable slab of meat that he held in his hand, stroking. Greg felt sick when he realized that it was still coming to life, expanding, unrolling.

Jay, holding the camera now, chuckled. "Z'aight," he said.

Zach didn't seem to care about the answer. He was watching the back of Beth's head, his cock pulsing to life as she sucked earnestly on Donny's cock. She had taken him into her mouth and was diligently pumping on his dick.

Zach started to feed his now-hard cock into Beth's pussy. She paused her sucking, and moaned, but started back up again once the first four inches of his dick were inside of her.

Zach fucked her slowly and stared at her head as she sucked on Donny's cock. "Want her to swallow?" he said, without looking up, still sawing almost disinterestedly at her pussy.

"Uh...I'm gonna, I'm coming," Donny said hoarsely.

Zach pushed his dick in deep and leaned over Beth, placing his hand on the back of her head. He mashed her face into Donny's crotch and then gripped her hair, shaking her head fiercely, but very minutely, side to side. "Do your thing, baby, make it good."

Greg felt bile at the back of his throat now, but something even worse, something he didn't dare look at or admit to himself; his cock was rock-hard, and he could feel the sticky stain of precum on his boxers, maybe even to his pants. As he stared at the screen, his cock throbbing, his mouth fell open in shock as Beth - his wife, Beth - began to gulp at the cock in her mouth. The muscles of her throat were working up and down, massaging the dick inside of her.

"Oh, fuck, oh, what the fuck?... Oh *fuck!*" Donny hollered, almost helpless by the end of his exclamation. "What... the..." he exhaled, and then turned bright red as his body was racked with an orgasm. Zach's hand kept Beth's head from pulling back, but she didn't seem to need the pressure: she continued to roll the muscles of her throat over Donny's cock. Whoever was

holding the camera did the viewers a favor by zooming in on Beth's throat, on the tensing of her muscles as she massaged the cum from Donny's dick.

Donny, stunned, was staring down at her.

"What'd I tell you?" Zach said, releasing his fingers from Beth's hair. "I taught her that. She's good, isn't she?"

Donny's abdomen rolled and he panted, staring down at Beth's head. "*Fuck*," he whispered.

"That was a good girl, Liza," Zach growled, putting his hands back on Beth's hips. Donny collapsed, his flaccid cock slipping from Beth's mouth, a slimy, reptilian beast that flopped against his thigh with a splatter.

"I'm gonna let you come now," Zach told Beth. He grabbed her hips and began to fuck her hard. His thighs slapped against her ass, splattering sweat and pussy juices noisily.

Donny was still resting on his heels, his cock twitching against his thigh. "Get outta the shot, man," Jay whispered from behind the camera. For a moment the camera tipped. Donny left the scene, but not before Beth looked up at him and smiled whoreishly.

She was on her hands and knees, and she looked back at Zach, a mewl rumbling in her throat. She started to whimper, then whine, and then finally started screaming. Her muscles went rigid and she fell forward, her legs jerking. The sputtering sounds coming from her pussy became wetter, sloppier.

"Look at the camera," Zach told her. "Look over there at Jay,"

He was sawing slowly in and out of her, while Beth whimpered and her legs jerked occasionally. "No faking that," Jay commented.

Beth's eyes were glazed over, but a smile was on her lips. She looked at the camera while Zach moved slowly in her pussy. Occasionally she mewled weakly.

"You gonna take it for me now, baby?" Zach said, sliding his cock out of her pussy and realigning it in the crack of her ass. Greg could see what was coming, but he could scarcely process it.

"No, Beth...no," he whispered futilely. A drop of sweat dripped into his eyes and it stung, but he couldn't move to wipe it away, or take his eyes from the screen.

Beth nodded, smiling at the camera.

"What's next, huh, little girl?" Zach asked her.

"My ass," Beth said quietly, her mouth wide in a smile.

Zach slapped her ass. "That's right. Your ass. And who gets to fuck your ass?"

"You do," she said, her eyes drooping closed for a moment. Not the kind of droop of drowsiness or blocking something out, a slow blink of deep pleasure. When she opened them and stared at the camera, Greg felt like his heart had been torn out.

Then her mouth opened, slowly, nothing coming from it, and her eyes seemed to change, getting wider. Greg was so focused on this change of expression that he failed to understand immediately what it meant.

Zach's hips were sinking toward her ass, the space between them closing as the full, thick inches of his cock disappeared.

Into her ass.

Another wave of cold, startling nausea gripped Greg: this was a specific question, a specific discussion had been had about this very act, and his wife had, point-blank, told him she had never done it. She had scrunched up her nose, shook her head, claimed that there was no way to understand how women could even *like* that. Not that he had wanted to do it to her: he couldn't, he respected her too much.

But here it was, on film, in all of its digital glory: Beth lying with her ass in the air, and eight inches of fat, gnarly cock deep inside it.

She gasped when his balls pressed up tight against her, his cock completely sheathed. Zach started to fuck her.

"She *likes* it," either Jay or Donny commented, a note of amazement or humor, or both, in his voice.

"Fuck man, that is fucking hot."

Zach reached for Beth's hair and pulled her up to sit on his lap. She leaned back against him and he pulled her tits free of the swimsuit top she was still wearing, kneading her loose flesh. Beth put her hand to her head and pushed her hair from her face, her mouth open, her eyes rolling back in her head in ecstasy.

Greg was grateful that she wasn't looking, for that moment anyway, at the camera anymore. That was short-lived, because she tipped her head forward and looked directly at the camera, as Jay walked it around the bed and aimed at the full naked glory of the front of her body.

"Get a good shot of my dick going in," Zach said, his hands cupping Beth's breasts, mauling them with rough, manhandling motions. He leaned

back, taking her with him, as he parted his thighs and forced her legs open further.

He was looking at the camera but his lips were next to Beth's ear. What he was saying was unintelligible on the video, but might have been heard in real life.

It wasn't hard to guess at what he said, though, because he released her tits and leaned back on his elbows, leaving Beth riding atop his cock.

The cameraman, Jay, lowered himself at the foot of the bed to get the money shot as Beth began to bounce on top of Zach's lap, and the thick meat of his dick was slowly excreted and then rammed back inside of her by her own enthusiastic bouncing.

Zach was watching her from behind, his face slowly contorting to the expression of a man who is fucking the way he wants to fuck, getting every dirty thing he wants, commanding enthusiasm and filthy submission from a woman at his behest. "That's it. That's my little slut. Fuck that cock, show me how much you love it."

This went on for what seemed like far too long. Beth was panting as she bounced and bounced, working her body over Zach's cock like a machine. Her eyes were fevered and yet distant, looking nowhere now, just consumed, it would seem, by lust.

And then, just when Greg believed that the torture might end, that Zach would shudder and yell, and blast his seed into Beth's ass, Zach rose from his leisurely recline, and pushed Beth back onto her hands and knees.

She smiled at the camera, before turning to look back at Zach. It was the smile that tormented Greg the most: the carefree, hungry, whoreish smile of a porn actress. Except that it truly didn't seem to be *acting*.

Zach was looking at her face now, his jaw moving slightly beneath gritted teeth. The muscles of his abdomen tensed and it seemed sure that he was going to come.

"What d'ya think, boys. Should I fill up her ass, or do you want to see her swallow some more dick?"

Greg blinked and stared. Zach was grinning, fucking Beth slowly, and she was still turned back toward him, rutting her ass against his hips.

"Ass to mouth," someone said. The other voice made a hooting sound.

"Get her to turn around," Jay said, his voice loud next to the camera. "Show us that gape, baby."

Zach shoved Beth roughly, pushing her off his dick and leaning back again, his cock in one hand, the other elbow propping him up.

He had a sadistic, predatory expression on his face as he watched Beth push herself back up to her hands and knees after falling forward. "You heard them," Zach said. "Turn around, get your hands up on that ass, give them a show. And then get to work on my dick."

"Fuck," Jay commented. "Oh fuck, she's gonna do it."

Beth crawled around to face Zach, putting her ass in front of the camera. First one hand, then the other, moved to her cheeks, and she pulled them apart slowly to give an unobstructed view to the camera of the stretched gape of her anus. It was a clean, black hole almost an inch and a half wide, the rubbery pink sphincter stretched to a smooth line of pink at the edges. It pulsed closed, the dark pink, slimy flesh inside of her disappearing from view in quivering waves.

As this unfolded, Zach fed his cock to her mouth, and held her by the hair to force her up and down his dick, as she sucked and licked him clean, before bouncing her face on his dick much as her ass had worked on him just moments before.

Even when he came, and pushed her head deep into his groin as he looked up at the ceiling and groaned, spurting his cum into her throat, Beth never removed her hands from her ass.

There was a moment, as Zach panted with his eyes closed, his hand still cupping Beth's head like a basketball, when a strange sound could be heard. A sort of wet clicking.

What it was became obvious when ropes of creamy white appeared suddenly on Beth's ass, landing on her now tiny anus, over her butt cheeks, onto her lower back. Donny had jerked himself off on her after the display.

Zach's eyes opened, and he squinted, but seemed to decide that whatever Donny was doing had not crossed the line for him - for it was clear that in this trio of guys, Zach decided who fucked Beth, and how, and some of the things she would do were for him alone.

And then, the screen was blank. The video was over.

Greg stared at the screen. The erection he had had become painful long ago: had he looked down to find his dick split open like a boiled sausage, it would not have surprised him. His chest felt crushed, and his head felt hollowed out. He could make no sense of what he had just seen, and yet it couldn't be anything other than what it was.

He was frozen like that for a moment. Pain of all kinds was creeping out of his mind and his body.

And then, like a zombie, and to the astonishment of the parts of his mind that were capable of thought, he reached out to the laptop mouse pad, and opened the next file. The feeling he had when he started going down a dirty porn rabbit hole gripped him, but this was laced with an extra layer of pain and loathing: he was searching for the nastiest porn he could find, not releasing himself, but going deeper and deeper on the quest for something even more filthy - nothing new about that.

But this time, it was to see more of his wife. Or the woman his wife once was. Doing unspeakable, unimaginable things.

*

There seemed to be nothing that Liza Brown would not do, if Zach Pinker ordered her to do it. Some videos were tame, reprises of the double-cock sucking scene at the beginning of the first video. Beth kept her eyes on the camera at all times, as dick after dick filled her mouth and throat. It was not always Donny and Jay. There were others.

One video largely consisted of Beth's face, upside down, hanging over the edge of a bed. Her eyes remained on the camera even when male ass filled most of the screen above them, as someone throat fucked her, their balls slapping against her nose. Three guys took a turn at Beth's face in that scene, dumping their cum in her open mouth or shooting it out on her face as they withdrew.

In another scene, she was propped on a standard wooden chair, her hands gripping the base of the back of it, while a slew of men pulled a train on her. He stared at her body ping-ponging back and forth from dick to dick, lips gobbling cock to the base, pussy sloshing noisily as they counted aloud the number of loads of cum she had swallowed or had fucked into her.

Each time that he thought he was going to stop - maybe the urge to vomit gripped him, or a sudden fury that made him palm the laptop from its underside like he was going to throw it out the window - he found he could not. It went on and on, until the pain in his groin was so overwhelming that he fell onto the floor and leaned on the end, panting, staring at the screen, replaying the first video as he jerked off.

And then he was there, in a stale old bedroom in Walla Beach, an aging married man with cum on his hands, the pornographic moans and sticky thrusts cackling through the speakers of his laptop.

He slammed it shut.

He was dizzy as he stood up, kicking off his pants, walking to the bathroom, numbly removing his shirt. He stepped into the shower before turning on the water, and barely noticed that it was icy cold. He stood there, mouth open, head suddenly devoid of thoughts, heart battering against his chest.

He couldn't even retain a single image from what he had just seen. The images blurred together, layer upon layer, every intimate part of his wife splayed open, glistening, soggy with cum. Overlaid on this melange was the smile she wore in every video.

And that was the thing that would haunt him, he realized, far more than any other thing he had seen: the smile.

It had not seemed, in any way, forced.

He was in the shower in this state for quite some time. He would never know how long. It was a time of no thoughts, only a volcano of feelings. Arousal snuck into him again, but he was unable to think of what to do with it, so he leaned against the tile and stared into the drain with an erection for what could have been almost an hour.

At last, he snapped quite violently from his reverie when he heard the sound of a car from the real world. The crunching sound of gravel under tires broke through the cacophony of moans and sloppy slurps, Zach's commands and his wife's compliant, wet agreements.

She was home.

He slammed the water off, and the whole house shook from the hammer of water it delivered. There was no towel in the bathroom within reach, so he stumbled out, slipping and sliding, water pouring from him, and dashed into the bedroom. He wrapped the first piece of material he saw hastily around his waist without identifying it, and snatched the USB key from the laptop before shoving the computer under the bed. He saw a small puddle of water on the cover, but he didn't have time.

He stood up and looked around, panting, his plan evaporating from his head like early morning mist.

He had had a plan, hadn't he?

But it was gone.

He saw the envelope and he lunged for it, slipping on the pooled water at his feet, falling to one knee and badly wrenching something in his left leg and his back. He threw the USB key into the envelope and made for...

Where? What was he doing?

The screen door creaked, and the hiss of the ancient spring stopper traveled upstairs. He made a dash for the bedroom, spun around wildly, and the material he had wrapped himself in fell to the floor.

Curtains.

No time.

The screen door, having reached the point in the spring stopper that failed, slammed closed.

"Greg?"

He crammed the envelope behind the dresser. Hastily he swept up the puddles of water he'd left all over the floor with the curtains, which were made of a very non-absorbent material, so most of the water was still on the floor, just streaked everywhere.

"Up here," he yelled, panicked. "Uh, just..."

Beth was coming upstairs. He swept frantically and looked around at the same time, hoping to see an object or a sign from any sentient god who could help that would magically save him.

"What are you doing?" Beth asked, stepping into the room.

He was on his knees, naked, swiping at the floor with the curtains. His eyes traveled around desperately, and he saw his smart phone on the floor across the hallway in the small room where he kept the laptop.

Beth was looking at him strangely.

"God," he said, exhaling sharply, a trick he'd learned from all his time in trials. If he said something loudly, inappropriately, right at the beginning, and exhaled like that, it excised the willies.

"I... it's so stupid I don't even want to tell you," he said. His trick had worked. He was calm now. He stood up, pulling the curtains with him. "I'm expecting a call... I heard the phone..." he turned toward the bathroom. Always point at something people can look at - a visual aid, the guilty party, anything to take their eyes off of you. "There weren't any towels in the bathroom, I grabbed this, I slipped..." he shook his head. Clumsy of him.

Beth had not followed his hand to look at the bathroom. She was looking at him like he had two heads.

There was a long and awkward pause, before she stepped into the room and made a move to close the door. Greg had all kinds of weird ideas run through his head, but she was just taking a towel from the hook on the back of the door off. She tossed it at him.

"Okay. Well. Must have been an important call."

Greg held the towel up to his face to cover it as he lied, because he didn't like telling even a... what? Not even a white lie, just utter, nonsensical bullshit lying - to his wife. "That's what's funny," he said. "It really wasn't that important at all."

He rubbed his face.

"Why... were you taking a shower?" she asked.

Greg's stomach lurched and his brain felt suddenly as empty as a desert.

"You know what, don't even... I don't even want to know," she said dismissively, as he mumbled something about the heat.

When he put the towel on his chest and looked at the doorway, she was already descending the stairs. "I'm just glad you didn't throw your back out," she said. Greg's back spasmed freakishly at the suggestion, and he silently prayed he hadn't done that, either, just before remembering that none of this had ever happened.

What *had* happened is that he had discovered his wife was a porno-making slut.

His cock throbbed.

Beth looked back at him. She was smiling, teasing him. "I need your help carrying all this stuff in."

He made a sound that he hoped was enough like a laugh to fool her, and she continued down the stairs.

Her smile burned a hole through his heart.

CHAPTER 8

There was a certain amount of humor to Greg's antics upstairs when she had returned from the paint store, and if a cloud of problems didn't hang over their heads because of Greg's stupid, *stupid* trip to Teddy's, she might not have thought anything of it.

But Greg wasn't the kind of person to await an important phone call without mentioning it (God, at least twenty times) and then leave his phone in the other room and fall all over the place.

Wrapping himself up in a curtain? That was possibly the only thing that was weird enough to be true.

Something weird was happening, she just didn't know what. She actually didn't have any idea what.

She settled on the phone somehow being the source of the weirdness, which would later irritate her. Just because Greg had talked about a phone call didn't mean there actually *was* one.

He acted funny for the whole day, spacing out and staring at the walls for long periods of time. *Deeply* absorbed in his thoughts.

She tried her best to dismiss her observations. He was tired, he was stressed out about something at work, he had heard some unsettling details about a case: it could be anything.

But it seemed like so much more. Greg was a thinker, and he sometimes zoned out, and that was okay with her.

But after she found him kneeling on the floor with a nail between his teeth and a hammer suspended in the air, like a man in suspended animation - in exactly the same position she had seen him in ten minutes earlier, she was prompted to make a joke to rattle him, and hopefully get him to reassure her.

"Did you get a mistress or something?" she joked.

Greg jumped: the sound of her voice had actually startled him. Which was bad enough, because he had to be pretty submerged in his thoughts not to hear her walking through the same room in that creaky old house.

But it was worse than that, because when he looked over at her quickly, he looked more than startled.

He looked... guilty of something.

But it couldn't be that. Could it?

"I was *joking*," she said, more icily than she had intended to be.

"Ha, ha," he had replied. Then he had shaken himself and returned to working. "I'm just deep in thought," he said. "About all this... house stuff."

She had let this explanation slide. It had been a long two years, between this "estate" hassle, and the pandemic, and her business going broke, and the time they spent apart while Greg had to be in the city while she tried to fix things in Walla Beach. He could have plenty to think about. And she just didn't have him for the mistress-taking type (of course, how many women had said that?).

But then she overheard him in the bathroom, late, late at night, taking a shower with the claim that it was too hot. It *was* hot, and there was nothing wrong with taking a shower about it.

But she was sure, *sure*, that the slippery sounds and the heavy, muffled breathing, and the rhythmic, quiet squelches she heard when she stood by the door, eavesdropping on him, were the sounds of jacking off.

Why would he do *that*?

He hadn't even tried to put the moves on her. They might not have been having as much sex as they did before all of these stressful events, but Greg at least *tried*.

Didn't he?

It confused her. And then it made her angry. And the weirdness just seemed to pile up: he stared at her sometimes, lost in his thoughts. His expression was hard to read when he did this: he was radiating some unpleasant sentiment, but he seemed to want to be absorbed by it. More than once, she had sneaked a peek at him and saw his cock stirring to life or pressing hard against his jeans. So what did that mean? And why, if he was so aroused, would he not at least try to have sex with *her*?

So when an opportunity finally came to get him out of the house, she seized it, and then she hid his phone and sent him to the hardware store with hers. She hesitated for a moment before breaking into his phone: it was a breach of trust, and why didn't she just *ask him*? *Maybe* there was a sensible explanation for his behavior.

But the thing was - and this was the worst thing - she didn't feel like she could ask him. She imagined herself asking the question, forming the words, and then she imagined hearing the answer, and she knew she wouldn't believe it, no matter what he said.

So she broke into it, combing it for clues, but there was nothing suspicious on it at all.

She wasn't satisfied, but she also felt like a heel.

"Okay," she said to herself, sitting on the bed, phone in hand. "Okay. Just talk to him."

She set the phone on the bed. She daydreamed about putting the phone in his hand, telling him what she had done, and starting the conversation that way. He felt so distant from her, he was acting so strangely...

But she knew she wasn't going to do that. The idea of having another long, confusing relationship talk with Greg made her tired just thinking about it. She was tired of those discussions, and she was afraid of what would come out of them.

She needed an explanation for this phone being lost, she decided, looking around the room. The idea came to her because it had almost happened to her own phone: they were always setting their phones on the dresser, and then shoving things on top of it. It could easily have fallen behind there, and the dresser was where she found the phone. (There was, alas, no explanation for why they hadn't heard it ringing when Greg called it, but that would have to remain a mystery for him.)

She was never sure why she decided to do it the way she did it, instead of just actually pushing the phone off the dresser. But she didn't want to break it - that was a hassle they really didn't need - so she crouched down to stuff it back there.

And she would also never be sure why she paid any attention to the envelope at all. Maybe she saw "QUINN" written on it, or maybe she just had an itchy feeling in her spine.

Whatever it was, she pulled the manila envelope out from behind the dresser, and with wide eyes, read the handwriting on the front. And opened it. And shook out the USB key, and then stared at it in the palm of her hand.

The really bad feeling began there. She wasn't expecting to see what she saw - not at all. But she knew, as she looked at the USB key, and then dropped her eyes to the words on the envelope, and remembered Greg's crazy behavior over the past few days, and the weird shower/phone incident: she knew.

It was bad.

She went, in her mind, interestingly, given everything that had happened, first to some kind of bad thing Greg had done. Financial misconduct, an affair, bribery, something that could destroy their lives.

No sooner had she thought all of that than she felt immensely guilty. What kind of person had she become? Greg wasn't like that...

But he *was* acting weird.

And he *was* keeping a secret.

She dug out her laptop, which she rarely used for anything these days. The internet was so abysmally slow out here it was only possible to watch Netflix as a series of giant, lumpy megapixels shifting out of sync with the sound.

She put the USB stick into a laptop and then waited.

She was keeping secrets, too. And Greg really was better off not knowing about them.

What if this was the same situation in reverse?

But the envelope did say "Mr. *and Mrs.* Quinn."

So she had every right to see what it was.

After all, she was Mrs. Quinn.

She hesitated, only for a moment, after a single file folder appeared in the drive window.

Her eyes scanned the meaningless strings of numbers for each file, thinking still about some financial disaster that would come crashing down around them.

And then she saw that they were video files.

The tapes, she quickly reassured herself, grasping for some composure as her heart began racing, were destroyed.

She had destroyed them.

These were digital files.

She closed her eyes and clicked on one.

The sound made her eyes fly open: a male voice.

His voice.

Panting.

The slippery sounds of sex.

She stared at the screen for only a moment, then slammed the laptop shut. The sound of Zach's voice continued for a few moments.

She opened it and chewed on a nail – something she hadn't done for twenty years, hovering over the second video.

She clicked it.

The same.

She closed the window and stared at the blank screen. If she had been adrift in outer space, she could not have felt any more lost.

She sat like that for a long time. Then a slam of cold raw fury built up inside of her, and a sense of panic that made her stand up and pace around the room.

She had to do something, she had to do something about this, whatever it was.

She took the USB key out of the computer and looked at it, frantically, as if it would have any clues. She looked at the envelope again.

How had this happened? Where had this come from?

She couldn't make sense of any of it. Was it something that had been sent to her aunt and uncle, she wondered. But then she remembered that the addressee on the envelope was "Mr. And Mrs. Quinn."

Where had it come from? How had it gotten behind the dresser?

The *only* sensible explanation was that Greg had put it there, because she couldn't imagine any other way that an envelope like that could have gotten into the house. Addressed to Mr. and Mrs. Quinn.

She stood in the middle of the room, thinking of all the implications of what she'd just discovered. It had been discovered by Greg, and he had watched it already? Was it already too late to stop him from doing that?

And if he had watched it already, when had he done that?

It explained why he'd been acting funny, but he'd been acting funny for a long time.

When did this get here, and why hadn't he talked to her about it?

And most importantly, what was she going to do about it?

She looked at the envelope again, trying to figure out how many people knew her married last name. It all depended on what Greg had said at the bar, who he had met when he said he'd met Anna. It sounded like a lot of people were at the bar, probably the usual suspects. Her aunt and uncle, she supposed, had known that name somewhere in the back of their minds, but she doubted they recalled it at the grocery store or at church, which were the only places they went and therefore the only way she could imagine the name being shared with anyone else in town.

She heard a car pulling up to the house and looked out the window. It was Greg.

She looked down at the envelope in her hand. If this wasn't from Greg, or he hadn't discovered it yet, then she didn't want to show it to him or call his attention to the USB key.

But he had to have seen it... how else could it be there?

She slipped the USB key out of the envelope and put it in her pocket. Not sure, even to herself, what she was doing, she folded the envelope and replaced it behind the dresser.

She wasn't sure what she was doing: she wasn't thinking at all.

She stared at the dresser and listened to Greg's footsteps approaching.

She decided, quickly, and without much thought, to leave the envelope on the bed without the USB key in it. The idea was only half-formed even as she executed it; she went into the bathroom and locked the door, and by the time she had done that, she wanted to change her mind.

But Greg was already coming inside. And change her mind to what? There was no way of getting around this.

It had to be confronted.

She turned on the shower and stood under the water, listening. Her breath came in ragged inhalations, and she pressed a hand to her chest as if she felt pain, even though she didn't. Staring at the tiles and the water streaming down her bare skin, she felt like sobbing, but had no energy.

How had this happened? What did it mean? She had believed these tapes – for once upon a time, they had been tapes – had been destroyed. She was the one who had burned them. How had they gotten into digital form?

There was only one answer, and that was Zach. They were his tapes, and he would have been the one to make copies of them. But if he had done so, he had done so almost a decade ago. Why hold on to them, why send them to Greg? Why now?

What was she going to say to him?

She waited, listening, but the house was silent. The only thing she could think of was the envelope: that it was sitting on the bed, there for him to see. Once he saw it, then she would have to take it from there.

Maybe it was good. Maybe it was good that after all this time, not lying, necessarily, but keeping this secret, it was good that Greg would find out.

He called her name.

“Up here,” she said, less loudly than she had intended.

The hot water ran out suddenly, and the shock of the cool water that replaced it obliterated the hypnotic spell she had been under.

No. NO.

She wasn't ready for this. This wasn't the way she had wanted to tell Greg – if she had ever been forced to tell him at all.

She jumped out of the shower, almost sliding across the tiled floor. She had forgotten to turn off the water. Frantic, she looked around, not sure what to do first. She grabbed a towel and threw open the door without drying off. The water was still running.

She had planned to lunge for the bed, but she could see through the bedroom that Greg's head was in the stairway, rising, with him, to the second floor. He would see the room, and her, and the envelope, in a matter of seconds.

She stepped forward to snatch the envelope, but in her panicked state, she slipped on the puddle of water that had pooled beneath her feet in the brief moments she had paused to consider her options. Her foot went sideways, and she felt her whole upper body jerk to try and stop her fall.

She slipped anyway, and fell onto the carpet, tipping sideways and smashing into the door, which hit the spring-loaded stopper and then smacked back into her.

“Oh,” Greg said, coming even faster into the room. “Shit, honey. Are you okay?”

She jumped up, gathering the towel around her. She was snippy at first. “Fine,” she snapped.

He looked at her strangely, obviously a little hurt by her reaction. She noticed that his eyes wandered over her body, lingering on her bare breasts and her legs.

But then, almost as if the envelope had started alarming, his eyes shifted to the bed and the creased manila paper.

Beth could feel the blood drain from her face.

“What's that?” Greg said, staring at the envelope like it was a severed horse head.

She looked down at it and realized that her expression was letting on that she knew more about it than she might try to claim to. She attempted to muster the strength to change her expression, but it was too hard, and she gave up. A flame of hope glowed brighter inside her: maybe Greg didn't know what this was.

She studied his face as she answered, jabbering:

“Oh that. I found it behind the dresser,” she said, trying to sound as casual as a person who had found an envelope containing nothing might sound. What would I say, she wondered briefly, if that was actually the case?

But it didn’t matter: she could see by the way the color drained from Greg’s face that he had seen the contents of the envelope, that he had watched them. That he *knew*.

But they continued the ruse. Greg walked over to the envelope and held it up, then squeezed it and looked inside of it.

His feigned confusion was pathetic, she thought. Just as hers must be. They were both jittery and silent; clearly they both knew what was in there, but neither of them *wanted* this to be the case.

“What was in it?” Greg said, his voice a wooden whisper.

Judging from the seasick, panicked look on his face, she could see that Greg was really hoping for her not to have seen the contents. He looked over at the dresser, and then at her, and then walked to where she had found it and tried to peer into the crack, but without looking like that was what he was doing.

Beth knew, then, that he had also watched the USB key.

“Why didn’t you tell me about this?” Beth demanded, taking the envelope out of his hand. “When did you get it?”

Greg turned to her, and his eye narrowed. “It was on the porch,” he said, plainly.

He looked back at the dresser, and Beth knew he was looking for the USB key.

She pulled it out of her pocket, so when he turned around, she was holding it in her hand. He jumped, visibly.

She held it up for him.

If either one of them could have seen each other, they would have seen that they both looked scared. Though the things that they feared were probably quite different.

He looked at the USB key in her hand, and then a slow-burning anger began to consume his expression. “You want to tell me what that’s all about?” he said, his tone suddenly fierce.

“*You* want to tell *me* what this is all about?” she countered, suddenly angry herself. “How do you get something like this and not say anything to

me about it? Who left it here? Did it come with a... I don't know, note? What did you do with it? Did you open it? Did you watch it?"

"No," Greg said, and it wasn't clear what he was saying "no" to. "There was no note, no explanation, I don't know who put it here or how it got here or even when. All I know is that it's full of porn. Porn with you in it. You and your ex boyfriend. You and... lots of different guys... it..."

Beth's lower lip trembled. Even if she had known, for half an hour now, that he had seen it already, it hadn't been real until he said it. Now it was said, and there was no taking it back. Not for him, not for her. This was something she had been convinced she had put behind her and would never have to even admit to. Now Greg knew about it – and not only did he know about it, he knew about it in detail.

Beth had been ready for a fight, ready to solve problems. After all, she had done those things, and she had come to terms with it. That part didn't shock her, but as she looked at Greg's face, she saw what she had feared the most. Her husband had watched her, watched her do all of those things.

And now he was going to think differently of her.

"Greg," she said, softening her tone. Tears sprung up in her eyes from somewhere deep inside, and she couldn't stop them. "I wanted so many times to tell you about this part of my life, but I just... it was never a good time. I didn't really want to, I just wanted to put it all behind me."

Greg was silent.

"How many... of those did you watch?" she asked, not sure what difference the answer to that question might make.

Greg just shook his head. She wasn't sure if he couldn't answer, or if that was his answer.

"Why didn't you tell me about this?" he said, after a lengthy pause.

"There was never any reason to tell you about it," she snapped, regretting her tone. "It was over and done with, and I didn't think you needed to know."

Greg stood there for a moment, and she could see a mixture of hurt, and anger, and something else on his face. She didn't know which one was most prevalent, but it really didn't matter: she knew, deep down inside, that whatever he was feeling, he was justified.

"You lied to me," he said quietly. "You stood right in front of me and *lied* to me."

Beth opened her mouth, ready with a comeback. She ended up looking at the floor and shaking her head. Tears welled up in her eyes and she choked on a sob. "I know," she said, and her voice was warbled and froggy from fighting back tears.

She looked up at him. "I did, okay? I lied to you. I lied to you because I thought it would be in everyone's best interest. Really, truly, that's why."

Greg was looking at her in disbelief.

"Oh, *think* about it, Greg. Think for just a minute, turn the tables. What if you had done something like this in your past, and you regretted it, but you thought it was all covered up and no one would ever find out about it. What would you have done?"

"I would have told you," he said, with conviction and very quickly.

This made her lose it. She let out a howl and sat down on the bed. Was it true? It sounded like it was.

She didn't know how long she sat there, crying, before Greg came and sat down next to her. She wanted desperately for him to put an arm around her, to pull her close and tell her it was okay. But he didn't, and that made her grief even more profound.

"Greg," she sniffed. "I *am* sorry. I really thought this... I thought these were gone. I destroyed them, I did it myself, Zach was there and he... acted like he didn't have any copies, like... he was *mad* about it. Really, really, mad. So I really thought they were gone. I really thought I could put all of this behind me and never talk about it. It's been eating me up, all this time."

"I just don't understand," Greg said. He sounded stunned. He was looking blankly at the wall. "Why didn't you tell me *at all*?"

This made the waterworks dry up, replaced by a sudden, maniacal frustration. She sniffed loudly and looked at him as if he was crazy. "*This*. This right here. I didn't want you to look at me like this. I didn't have the tapes... what was I supposed to do? How could I have told you the... the... whole thing you know now? Sit there and tell you all the details? Come on, Greg." She rolled her eyes and wiped a tear from her cheek hastily.

He shook his head slowly. He almost seemed drugged. "I don't know."

They sat in silence for a few moments, and Beth's mind wandered immediately to a much more pressing problem. As often happened with

moments of emergency or panic, her vision tunneled and her thoughts sharpened.

“Look,” she said. “Nothing has changed. I am still me, and this was always in my past. What we need to do now is find a way... figure out what... what, why did someone put this here? Did it come with a note?”

Greg reacted slowly to this, still deep in thought.

“Greg,” she said, snapping her fingers in front of him. “What’s on the tapes can’t be changed. It’s something I did, I lied to you about it, we’ll probably end up seeing a marriage counselor. Okay? But get your head on straight. *That* isn’t the problem right now. The problem is that the tapes are in someone’s hands, and they sent copies to you, and so they must want something. So we have to deal with that. Okay? Was there a note? What else came with this?”

Greg shook himself. “No note. Someone just put it here. On the porch. ‘Mr. and Mrs. Quinn, that’s all.’”

“Well, it obviously means something,” she said, her tone nastier than she wanted to sound. “Why would someone put it here, with no note? What do you think they want?”

Greg’s eyes were on the envelope, which Beth was turning over and over in her hands, as if something else would fall out of it, or she would see some fiber or marking that would explain everything to her.

“When was it here?” she demanded. She looked at him. “Did this come after that night? The one when you got drunk and blabbed all over town that you have a political career you’re just *dying* for someone to ruin?”

Greg’s face turned red in a flash of anger and he snatched the envelope from Beth. “You know what, Beth? I don’t like your tone. You’re talking to me, *to me*, like I’m the one who sucked two dicks at once and let my ex-boyfriend film me getting tag-teamed by half the tourists in Walla Beach!”

This was fair, and she knew it. But she became defensive, and snarled at him. “I didn’t even know that -”

“Don’t give me that, Beth. You’re looking right at the camera in half these videos!”

“I told you not to go there!” Beth wailed. “I told you to keep your mouth shut. Why do you think I’ve been... hiding here, dressing like this? I did not want something like this to happen!”

“I don’t understand,” Greg said, almost as if he hadn’t heard her at all. “Why were you *doing this*? Why was he... what were you *doing*?”

He looked at her, and in his eyes she read a kind of hopefulness, which stabbed her painfully in the heart. She knew what he was going to say before he started talking, and she began to shake her head even before the words reached her ears. “Were you being coerced? Did he make you do this stuff...? I don’t know, was it, did he have something on you? What?”

Beth could see that Greg wanted her to say yes. He wanted very much for that to be the reason – some kind of blackmail, or manipulation, something that would mean she hadn’t been a willing participant and a shameless slut.

It would be so easy to just tell one more lie. Or even, to *not* tell it. All she would have to do now was move her head, nod, and start crying. And Greg would think what he wanted to think, and it would be a white lie with a good purpose: the purpose of protecting him from knowing about a side of her that would disappoint him, maybe even make him feel differently about her.

But in the end, he would want to know what that truth was. He was a prosecutor, there is no way he would never ask a single follow-up question. For a moment, she considered all the tales she could tell to make this not her fault or her own volition.

If she just started talking, the story would flow.

But she loved Greg. She wanted honesty between them, she wanted an honest marriage. The biggest lie had already been unearthed, and if that was the case, she wanted them all out. She wanted something different than all the passion, and lying, and raw red-hot emotion that had existed between her and Zach.

That relationship had been wild, intoxicating, dangerous, and seductive.

But it had also been madness. And it wasn’t what she wanted. She wanted Greg, and she wanted him to love her, and now she had to face the music and find out if he could love her in spite of this.

“What were you thinking?” Greg continued. “Why didn’t you tell me? What were you thinking would happen? How would I never find out about this? There are videos!”

He was getting worked up.

Beth shook her head. "I know, I know, and I'm sorry. I... really thought they had been destroyed. I burned them, I burned them with Zach, and he told me... I just never thought this would come back. Not like this. This is what I wanted to avoid."

"The truth?" Greg yelled, wryly.

"This," she said meekly. "This... you... judging me, not loving me, not, understanding..." Her voice trailed off. "I didn't mean for you to find out like this."

"You mean you didn't mean for me to find out *at all*," Greg said bitterly.

She looked at him, a flicker of anger in her face. "Can you blame me?"

They stared at each other. Beth saw anger in Greg's face, but also hurt. And she couldn't tell what proportions each was in, or how deep his anger ran.

Suddenly, she was gripped by a more pressing concern. It was the first thing she had felt, even above her own humiliation, or Greg's possible loss of respect for her. More important than any of that was that she desperately wanted for none of this to come back on him.

Her face became resolute.

"Look," she said, pulling herself together into a fine facsimile of calm. "I don't know what you want to do. I don't know if this means that anything has to change in our relationship. Because I don't think it does. I'm still the same person, nothing has changed, our marriage is still the same, everything is still the same. It's just something that was in my past, and it was supposed to stay there -"

"Yeah," Greg interrupted. "Except it didn't stay in your past, did it? Because somebody dropped this off on our doorstep, which means that somebody wanted us to have it."

"That's the part I can't figure out," Beth said, helplessly, sitting on the bed. "That's the part we need to figure out. There was no note, there was nothing?"

"No," Greg said, exasperated. "I told you. Nothing."

Beth sat for a moment, thinking, and Greg stared at her. He was angry, and she told herself that was his right. But it hurt, and at moments it infuriated her.

She would just need to solve this problem.

“Who did you talk to? At the bar?” she asked, after a thoughtful pause. “Who did you tell that you were planning to run for office?”

Greg sighed. “I mean, I told Anna, but I thought... I told her outside the bar, and I thought, maybe if she kept talking about some other topic, she would forget about it. I thought she did. She was really drunk.”

Beth scoffed at this, because calling Anna drunk was like calling air breathable, but then she shrugged apologetically at Greg. “Anna might not have forgotten. But... it just doesn’t make much sense. Could anyone else have overheard?”

“I said it outside, walking across the street to the store there, to the ATM.”

“And Zach was there?”

Greg frowned. “Zach was there. He was at the bar. He didn’t really...”

“Did you see any of these people, any of the people in these videos, at the bar?” she said, shaking the USB key in her hand.

“God. No. I mean, I don’t know. I didn’t... think to look around, I didn’t know this was going to happen.” He exhaled sharply. “What kind of question was that? Why would I look around the bar and try to commit people to memory, just in case any of them end up fucking my wife in a porno? Huh? Should I be doing that everywhere I go?”

Beth didn’t immediately answer, and after a beat, she realized there was no point in answering at all. The truth was, that maybe the answer, in Walla Beach at least, was "yes." And she didn’t want to say that aloud.

“I need you to tell me the truth,” she said, very seriously. “Was there anything in here, anything in these videos, anything in how this got here...anything that you’re hiding from me?”

Greg’s jaw fell open. “You know, you have a lot of nerve,” he said angrily. “Asking *me* if there’s something I’m not telling *you*. But no. There was nothing. No note, no demand, no one has called, or asked for anything.”

“Then what the hell is this *doing* here?” Beth wailed, exasperated, not with Greg but with the situation.

“I do know what blackmail looks like,” Greg said, defensively. “I think I would notice if -”

She held her hands up. “I wasn’t saying that like I don’t believe you. I just... I just... I don’t know what to do.”

Beth stared at the floor, crossed her arms, and thought. Greg was silent.

The only person she knew of who had these tapes – because they had been tapes, originally – was Zach. She was certain that the tapes had been destroyed, because she herself had burned them. Zach hadn't liked that very much, but he had seemed sufficiently devastated by her doing it that she had truly believed there were no copies.

She had stood up to think, and she sat back down again, forlorn. "He *must* have made copies," she said, her voice weak. It was an obvious conclusion, but one that she really hadn't worried about in all of these years. Because years had gone by, years and years, and there had never been any indication that a copy of *anything* existed – let alone so many of them.

"I destroyed these," she repeated, her eyes getting blurry with tears. She looked up to plead with Greg through her teary eyes. "I know that I did. I did it myself."

"Looks like you didn't," Greg said bitterly.

Her heart sank. There were a lot of things she could handle, but Greg being mad at her was not one of them. It was what had motivated her to keep this secret for so long – and she would have kept it to her grave, if this hadn't happened.

She stared at the floor again.

There was only one way this could have happened.

She didn't want to think about it, or what it implied.

But there was no other explanation.

That one way was Zach Pinker.

"I'm going to take care of this," Beth said, standing up. She sniffed and wiped away a tear from her left cheek.

"Wait, wait. Wait wait wait wait," Greg said, reaching for her, putting his hands on her shoulders. "What do you mean, you're going to take care of this?" Greg asked.

"I mean, that I'm going to take care of it," Beth said, stonily. "This is *my* past, and it's *my* problem. I don't know what's going on here, but I do know that the only person who could have done this... well, that somehow, somehow, no matter what happened, the root of this problem is Zach. He had to have made copies of those tapes, and he had to have lied to me about it. Because here they are. And so he's the only person I can think of who could have done this."

Greg was looking at her, his jaw slack.

“I’m going to get this sorted, Greg,” Beth told him. “I promise.”

He shook his head and put a hand out to stop her from walking out of the room. “Well, I’m... I’m going with you,” he said.

“I don’t know,” Beth said. “I don’t know if that’s a good idea.”

Greg looked at her and began to open his mouth. She put a hand on his chest and stopped him from talking with a sharp look. “I don’t know why he’s doing this. All I know is that he is, and that he wants something. It’s not going to do us any good to get you involved... I don’t want you involved. I don’t want this to affect you. It’s not... it’s not fair. I won’t let it happen.”

Greg seemed to crumple, even though he didn’t shrink away or sit down. His face was a mix of horror and disdain, and Beth could hardly look at him.

“This isn’t a good idea,” he said. Beth’s head was turned, and she was looking out the window, staring at the receding sunlight through the large scraggly cottonwood in the front yard.

When she turned back to him, he was still pleading with her with his eyes. He looked hurt, and confused, and it broke her heart.

But that was all for later: repairing that problem was not something that she could do quickly, or tonight.

Finding out what Zach Pinker was up to, on the other hand, was.

“Look,” she said. “I’m going to his business,” she said. “It’s daytime, there will be people there -”

“Business? What business?” Greg said.

She was already brushing past him.

“I will fix this,” she said, in a low voice.

He grabbed her hand, and she turned back toward him, a pained expression on her face. “Please. Greg,” she said. “Please let me fix this.”

He said nothing, and he shook his head, and he looked close to punching something, but his grip on her wrist relaxed, and she slipped through his fingers easily.

*

“Don’t fuck around,” she said. “I know it was you.”

“Oh-huh,” Zach said. He had, still, and always had, an enigmatic way of speaking. He betrayed nothing when he commented on something like this: not even the most skilled CIA agent, she believed, would have any idea if Zach was telling the truth or not, aware of what was happening with the tapes or not, whether he cared or did not. He was as blank as a clean slate, when he wanted to be, and he used that routine to his advantage all the time.

But she knew him better than that. Still waters, in his case, did run deep – and usually to the dark and devious.

She was infuriated. “I thought I destroyed all of those tapes,” she snapped. “You told me I had, and I believed it. So don’t give me this shit, Zach.”

Zach was quiet for a strangely long amount of time, with his hands folded over his stomach casually. “The tapes,” he repeated.

“Yes, the fucking tapes, Zach. The tapes. The tapes. You know what I’m talking about. I burned them, in a bonfire, at your house, right in front of you. And you threw a big fit and tried to fish them out of the fire. Nice touch, by the way. But there were copies, which you know, and which I now know, because you left them for my husband to find and watch. But that’s all background and I’m not here about any of that. What I want to know is what it is you fucking want!”

Zach raised his eyebrows. He was quiet for a moment.

“What is it that you even want?” she yelled, losing her patience. “What’s the point of this? Why would you do any of this?”

Zach’s mouth moved, but because of his wild beard, Beth couldn’t see in what direction. “What. Is it. That I want?” he said, chuckling.

“Listen to me Zach,” she said. “I love Greg. He means everything to me. I’ll do anything – *anything* – to make sure that this... this crap... doesn’t ruin his chances at a career that he’s worked really hard for. So you tell me, what you want me to do, and then, we’re going to work this out.”

Zach chuckled again. “What do I want you to do?” he mused, taking two fingers and stroking his beard.

“Well, for starters, let me ask you this, Liza Brown -”

“My name,” Beth declared, “is not Liza Brown. My name is Beth Quinn. And I know that I did a lot of crazy things with you back then, but I’m not like that anymore. So you tell me what it is that you want, and we’ll make a deal. And that will be that.”

There was a long and dangerous pause.

“Are you sure that you’re Beth Quinn?” he said.

Inwardly, Beth cursed at herself. His words, and his silky voice, made a shudder travel through her. She knew what the feeling meant, she knew what she felt deep down inside. But she tried to block it out. Tried not to let it materialize into an actual thought.

She could feel a familiar ache between her legs coming to life again. What was it that she wanted? Was she sure that she was Beth Quinn, and not Liza Brown?

If you had asked weeks ago, even a day ago, she would have said yes, that was true.

But now that she was standing here in Zach’s office, now that she had seen herself in the videos and seen Zach again.

And then a thought – a really, really bad thought – burst out of some seed that was buried inside of her. Zach had germinated it by asking her that question.

She would do anything to protect Greg: to save his career. She would do anything, make any sacrifice. But what if what Zach wanted was to have her again? Would a sexual relationship with her be enough to pay him off? If she struck that deal with him, would it be enough to pay him off? And the truth, deep deep down inside, was that she kind of wanted to.

She wanted to find an excuse, *a reason*, to cave in. To live dangerously again. To go back to Zach, not as a girlfriend, but as a fling.

He was still looking at her.

“I’ll tell you what, Liza. You come up to my party. Come to my house. And we’ll have a good, long talk about this. And I’ll let you know what it is that I want. And we’ll hammer out an agreement. How does that sound to you?”

Beth knew that what she should do was push all the papers off his desk, scream at him, throw something at his wall. She should tell him to fuck off, she should get out of there, she should go home and tell Greg what happened. There had to be some other way to solve this problem, there had to be some other way to get these videos from Zach.

She didn’t know what it was he would be asking for, but she could guess. She didn’t really believe that Zach was capable of blackmail; in other words, she didn’t really believe in the danger that he would somehow expose her, or Greg.

But Zach was unpredictable, and there was no telling what he would do. She didn't want to take the chance.

At least, these were the things she told herself.

And she knew that the reason she was telling herself these things was because, deep down inside, there was a part of her that wanted this very predicament. Sure, if there were a way, a magical way, to make all of this go away like it had never happened, she'd have jumped at it.

But if she was stuck, if there was nothing that could be done to make this all just disappear... if she *had* to do something Zach wanted her to do... the truth was, some craving she had thought long ago extinguished was now coming back to life inside of her. She could almost feel the control she exerted over herself slipping out of her fingers, feel the pull of Zach's power, of his dominance, of his ability to get her to do whatever he wanted.

And she liked it.

She glared at him.

"I guess this is what it's gonna take," she spat.

"Wear something nice," he said, without missing a beat. "Not these crappy old shorts you're wearing around town."

She exhaled. "Really?"

"Come tonight. Seven o'clock. Alone. And we'll hammer out the details," Zach responded. He was looking mildly disinterested now, as if he were scheduling a regular meeting.

She turned and stomped out of his office. She stormed through the landscaping business. Several employees waved at her, said hello and goodbye. It was a surreal scene: Zach was still quintessentially Zach – brooding, dark, dominating. But his landscaping business was brightly-lit and had the excessively cheerful feel of a well-run Walmart.

She got in her car and turned the ignition. She drove out backing over the gravel and spraying it everywhere.

The nerve of that man.

She hated him, she hated him more than anyone in the world. She hated him for putting her in this terrible position, She hated the power he held over her.

Didn't she? Didn't she hate him? Didn't she hate what she was going to have to do?

"There's no other way," she said aloud, rehearsing for Greg.

"There isn't any other way."

But was that true?

She could tell him the whole truth, or she could tell him only a part of the truth.

Which would be kinder?

Or, she could just ask him what he wanted her to do.

She knew, even as she turned the ideas over and over in her mind, that whatever she would tell Greg, she knew, right now, what it was she *really* wanted to do.

And every time she neared that thought, she pulled back away from it like it was a hot coal. She tried to ignore it, and circle around it, like it wasn't there. But it was.

CHAPTER 9

Beth was not gone for very long, to Greg's relief.

He had followed her, though he lost her on the county roads, but by then, it was obvious after heading over a single hill where she had been heading: a large landscaping company that took up scores of acres in the middle of the farmland that extended away from the coastal towns like another ocean.

To be honest, it wasn't what he had been expecting from the tattoo covered, sexually dominating, tough guy that was Zach Pinker.

He saw her storm in, and then he watched, breathlessly. He saw her storm out. He drove home, arriving shortly after she did, deciding not to follow her exact route.

She was coming out of the house as he pulled in. Her face was angry, confused, but showed a hopeful flicker of relief. At least she still cared about him, he thought.

"Where have you been?" she demanded, walking toward the car before it was even parked.

"I followed you," Greg said. "Did you really think that I wasn't going to do that?"

His wife's face looked suddenly ashen. Beth was rarely overcome with emotion, and it was startling. Greg got out of the car and came around the back to stand in front of her.

Beth wasted no time confessing. "I went to go see Zach. I need to talk to you."

Greg felt the uncomfortable sensation of mistrust he had felt in the first few years of marriage with his wife, because she really did have him wrapped around her little finger. He couldn't stand it if she looked sad, or hurt, or had a negative emotion of any kind. There was no limit to what he would do to stop her from crying, and he often wondered if she knew that – *really* knew it – and if she sometimes took advantage of his undying love for her. It was a dark fantasy that came to him in the dead of sleepless nights, and it surfaced now, in broad daylight.

He followed her into the kitchen with his heart racing. He was angry with her, there was no doubt about that. But there was a different kind of feeling below it. Almost excitement. Excitement that gathered and churned

mainly in his lower abdomen and groin, a sexual energy that wasn't purely sexual.

For a third time since he had arrived in Walla Beach, he felt like he was going to vomit.

He knew he should be mad at Beth. He knew that he should be shocked and horrified.

And he was.

He was all of those things.

But he couldn't help also feeling aroused, at whatever it was that Beth was going to tell him.

She was standing in the kitchen with her hands on the chair when he came in. She spun around.

"Look, what's in the past is in the past, and it can't be changed. But I'm sorry I never told you about it. The truth was – the truth is – it just wasn't something that I ever wanted to be part of our life."

"I don't understand," Greg said, and it felt good as he declared this, because if there was one thing that was true, it was that. "I don't understand what I saw in those videos." His voice sounded truly lost, almost childish.

"Look. That was a different me, and a different person. I've put it behind me. I hope you can understand and forgive me."

Beth's voice, and face, and posture, had taken on a clinical aspect that Greg had never seen before in her. She was being no-nonsense, which was nothing new, but she almost seemed to be reading a scripted apology from a piece of paper, as if they were someone else's words and not her own. She was dismissing these facts, her voice said, as if they didn't matter or weren't important.

That was scary. Fear throbbed in Greg's chest, sinking through him, mixing with the bizarre arousal in his groin. Again, he felt like he would vomit.

"Look," Beth continued, matter-of-factly. "What I need to talk to you about is Zach. I don't know why he's doing this. He wasn't very clear about it. But he wants something. And I think the only choice that I have is to..." And here she paused, if only for the briefest moment. "...give it to him." She tilted her chin and looked at him very seriously. "Do you understand what I'm saying?"

Greg's chest felt like someone had taken a blowtorch to it. He could taste bile at the back of his throat. He focused his energy on a single

thought: trying not to puke.

His hands were clammy.

"I *don't* understand what you're saying," he heard himself say. His mouth was dry. The voice he heard seemed to come from somewhere else, the words rattled around against his parched throat.

He *did* understand what she was saying. He did. And it was playing out in his mind: the wet slurping sounds of Zach's cock in his wife's mouth, the hungry way she swirled her tongue around his dick, her eyes floating above her stretched lips as she sucked on cock after cock.

He just didn't *want* to understand it.

"I think you understand what I'm saying perfectly well," Beth said, in her clinical voice. Greg's cock throbbed. The iciness of her tone, the authority with which he declared it, devoid of doubt – it was terrifying, and erotic. "And I don't see any other way out of this."

Greg felt dizzy. "I don't know what to say," he murmured. "I don't know what to think about any of this."

He was, subconsciously perhaps, moving closer and closer to Beth during this entire conversation. He only then noticed it, seeing that he was very close to her. Her breast brushed against his forearm as he moved a bit closer, and he could feel the hard nub of her nipple against his skin.

While a mixture of conflicting emotions whirled around inside of him, and he was unable to grasp a single one for more than a moment, there was a single, real, raw emotion that was clear in its intention and its intensity above all others. Whatever it was that he was feeling, however it would make him feel after doing it, whatever it *meant*: he wanted to fuck his wife.

The conversation - of words - ended there, immediately, and consensually. Greg moved closer to Beth, and she moved back from him, but not like she was trying to escape. She was walking herself into a wall, and in the miasma of body heat between them it was somehow communicated that that was her intention. So when her back ran into the wall, her lips fluttered with the tiniest change - who could say what it was? A smile? An invitation? Some microscopic movement that drew him in toward her, almost like each inhalation of hers wrapped itself around him and pulled him closer.

Every time that they had sex, Greg longed to know what the differences were, the details that made one episode different from another.

For him, there was nothing, really: he was always interested, always the same amount of interested, always conquering the same passion and quenching the same desires.

But Beth - and women in general, he found - were different shades and contours of interested. Sometimes he knew, even if he couldn't fathom why, that Beth was really just going through the motions, that her mind was somewhere else, that she wasn't clinging to his body and the feel of it as some kind of temporary completion of her ego and herself the way that he was. There were times when he resented her, resented that Beth didn't need to constantly validate herself, and her value to him, and she certainly didn't need to do it the same way that he did. He had given up long ago on the idea that she would ever want him the same way that he wanted her, had written that off as a difference between men and women.

But that didn't mean that he couldn't *sense* the difference, and he liked to turn it over in his mind, analyzing it, trying to find where it was in her secret, innermost core, and how it came through into her body - as heat, as a pulse or a quiver around his cock, as more of her tangy juices already secreted inside of her before he even entered her.

When he kissed her, she put her hand on the back of his neck and kissed him back so fiercely and hungrily that his lips crushed into his teeth. Her tongue darted inside his mouth, and then she pulled him away by the hair, teasing him, licking his slightly bloodied upper lip, a smile on her own lips. Her teeth sank gently into his lower lip, and she pulled on it, her eyes flashing with an intense hunger, and a strange, alluring control, tinged by something dark that made his chest feel cool and hollow.

They began tearing at their clothing, buttons actually clattering to the floor as they hurried to shed it all. Within seconds, their skin was soaked in sweat, and they slipped in each other's hands. Greg took handfuls of her shining, slippery breasts and brought her nipples - already hard, to his lips, biting gently on her knobby, fat nubs, moving his hands down and into the even wetter heat between her legs.

He slid down to his knees, and Beth pushed him, her hands on his head, her fingers pulling hard at his short hair until his scalp stung. He peeled her underwear away and pushed one leg up to the wall, following Beth's lead, to a position they had never been in before.

He looked up at her as he tilted his chin to run his tongue into the swollen, glistening pink of her pussy, her feathery, neatly trimmed landing

strip hovering above his nose, a small mound that framed the picture of her face as she looked down at him.

Her mouth was open, her lips forming something like a smile, an expression that would be burned into his memory forever - something manic in it, something hungrier than he had ever seen. Her lips were wet and so were her eyes, and her pussy pulsed when his eyes met hers, sending a burst of sweet, tangy nectar rolling down his chin.

Her fingers dug into his hair and pushed his face into her cunt, and as he found her clit and closed his lips around it, sought to lap at it with his tongue, she gasped and tipped her head back against the wall. He watched her, writhing in pleasure, her mouth open in ecstasy, her mind somewhere he could not know, as he lapped at her clit while she gripped his head and ground her mound against his face violently until she came.

When she did, her pussy turned to liquid around his lips and his jaw, and her body shuddered while she screamed in pleasure. For a moment she was tearing at his head, pushing him into her, and he couldn't have breathed.

But then her body went limp, and she let go of him, and slumped a little. He played with her clit with his tongue and her body jerked, she gripped his head and pushed him away. When their eyes met again, he sensed that he was back in control, and, simultaneously, that he wanted to be.

He stood up, and grasped her hair, licked her neck, kissed her mouth and let her lap up her own juices with her playful, teasing tongue. Then he turned her over and pushed her onto the kitchen table, and she played with her hair in this way she had never done before, pushing it up and over her head while she looked back at him. Her bottom jutted toward him, and for a brief moment he played with her ass, the tiny pucker that he had believed she'd never let anyone fuck. His fingers slipped in her juices over the rubbery hole, and the image of it gaping and spewing Zach Pinker's cum flashed through his mind.

But by then, he was going to come if he gave it another moment's thought, and he wanted to feel his wife's pussy around his cock. His dick was rock hard and almost hurt, drops of pearly precum beading at the tip.

Her ass moved in front of him, and she leaned on her elbows, tilting herself up for him to take. She flung her hair back and then met his eye, her mouth smiling, her whole body inviting him to fuck his cum into her.

Really, really inviting him. Wanting it, as much as he did.

He plunged into her, and she was so wet that for a moment he believed her pussy had somehow become looser, that maybe she had fucked Zach in that brief encounter at the landscaping business, and a wave of red-hot jealousy and pain rolled through him.

And that was why he fucked her the way that he did: hard, dirty, slamming deep inside of her without his usual concern that it was maybe too much, too rough, too hard. She squealed but drove herself into him, against him, adding to the force of it.

And while he had never, ever, just let himself go without attempting, at the very least, to make sure that she came first, he just hammered into her, and there was no stopping his orgasm as it seized his whole body.

But when he thrust in for the first explosive spurt, Beth was already catching up to him, and as he gripped her and pushed his hips deep inside her squelching pussy, she wriggled her way to her own second orgasm, her pussy throbbing around his cock like a sucking mouth.

And then he stood there, as Beth collapsed on the table, and they panted without talking for what seemed like an unusually long time.

And if it had ended there, that would have been one thing - something Greg would remember forever and maybe could have chalked up as a simple one-off. A passionate moment driven by high emotion.

But Beth pushed herself up from the table after a few minutes, and leaned back against him. He was still panting, and his cock slipped from her pussy, flopping against his thigh, as he brought his arm up around her.

And then, without looking back at him, she dropped her arm, and took his hand in hers, and led him, mystified and naked, upstairs, into the dark, where they lay down in the bed and made love in a slow, deliberate, tender way.

*

"Well," Beth said, after a long time. "I guess we better talk about that, whatever that was."

Greg had his forearm resting on his forehead, staring at the ceiling.

"I don't know," he said.

And he really didn't know. None of this made any sense to him.

The sex, on a physical level, had not been that much different than things that they normally did - especially the second time. But the

emotional intensity behind it was so much... deeper.

"Why was that so hot?" he said. He didn't even realize he had spoken aloud until Beth rolled over and propped herself up on her arm. She looked at him.

"What?" she asked. But she seemed to agree with him.

"I mean, it was for *me*," he said. "That's what I'm trying to figure out."

Beth rolled onto her back again. "Yeah."

There was a long silence.

"Look," she said. "I... I don't know what else to do. If you don't want me to do this, then I won't. But I think it's the only way to get Zach to give up those tapes, or sign a non-disclosure agreement. Or something... is there a way to do that?"

"Well, not in exchange for sex," Greg said. "We'll have to find a workaround."

What was he saying? He was going to get disbarred. He was going to pimp out his wife?

"Look," Beth said, turning onto her side again. "I know you don't have any reason to trust me. And I know you don't have any reason to trust what I say about Zach. But the thing that I can't understand...he's not the kind of person to break his word."

"But that's exactly what he did. By keeping those tapes around."

"Maybe this is fool's errand. Maybe we just accept this... I don't know what he'll do with it, though."

"Well, let me ask you: what is it you want to do?"

She closed her eyes and squeezed them tightly shut.

And that's when Greg knew. Maybe he hadn't known about his wife's past, but he knew her, and he could see it in her face. Whatever it was that Zach wanted her to do, she wanted to do it. That's why she had been masturbating the other night, that's why she'd been acting funny ever since she'd seen him.

She had tried to avoid him and he had to give her credit for that. He was the one who'd inadvertently opened this Pandora's box. Not Beth.

But now that it was here, now that this problem existed, he could see in her face and feel in his heart that there was something inside of Beth that wanted to do whatever Zach told her to do.

And if he looked deep enough into his own psyche, there was a part of him that wanted that as well.

Should he say that to her? Should he make her feel better? I mean, it was crazy. It was crazy to think, it was crazy to say, and in one way it wasn't what he wanted at all.

He knew, from just the brief encounters he'd had with Zach, that Zach was the kind of guy who gave women what they craved. And he could see, from those videos, that his wife loved it, or at least she had once upon a time, back before "Liza Brown" became "Beth Quinn." That wasn't the kind of thing you just turned off. She never did *anything* like that with him, she'd never asked or hinted that she wanted anything like what he had seen her do with Zach.

And he knew that the reason that she craved this encounter with Zach was because she couldn't ask him to do those things to her. Maybe she knew that he couldn't do them, maybe she just didn't want him to.

"Beth," he said. "I'm going to tell you something. I don't want you to take it the wrong way. But if this is what you want to do, if you want to do it, then... it's okay with me."

"It's not what I *want* to do!" she protested, but he could hear the false ring in her voice. "I mean, it's just something I *have* to do. I can't have Zach ruining your political career like this."

But even Beth was having a hard time selling this story, for all of her emphasis.

"What I'm trying to say," Greg said, and he felt like he had just jumped off a very tall building, and he already regretted that decision.

"What I'm trying to say is that I can see there's a part of you that wants to do this for another reason. And I don't know how to tell you this, because I can't even believe I feel this way – but there's a part of me that finds this... really hot. A part of me that wants to let you do it."

Now *this* took Beth by surprise.

She scooted back and tilted her head to the side. The look of surprise on her face was sincere. "You what?" she said.

"Look, I don't know how to say this, I don't know how to explain it. I... watched all of those videos. I watched them over and over. I was up all night long. I masturbated to them. I can't get them out of my mind. And I know that's... you know, not what... I'm *supposed* to feel or *supposed* to say. Okay? It sounds crazy to me when I even say it. But I think this sex

that we had, just now, that part of the reason it was so hot... was this. All of this.”

“It doesn’t make sense to me,” he continued. “But I think... I want you to do it. I think it turns me on.”

‘What?!’ Beth repeated.

“Look,” Greg felt like he had said the wrong thing. She seemed so repulsed by his suggestion.

But was she repulsed by the suggestion of her having sex with Zach, or was she repulsed by the suggestion that her husband wanted to be cuckolded?

“Look,” he said quickly, because his own mind held dark secrets and he had kept them away from Beth for a reason, for a long time. “Forget I said anything.”

The truth was that he had his own dark fantasies, that they had been something like this. But he didn’t linger on them, didn’t play them out in his own head that often – and he definitely didn’t confide them to anyone, especially Beth. They had only surfaced in his mind because of this crazy situation, and the reason he had shoved them down a hole was clear as day to him now: he had been afraid of exactly this. Of the look on Beth’s face, of her disdain, of her loss of respect for his manliness.

He wished he could take back what he had just said.

“No, no, please don’t be like that,” Beth said. “I’m just... I’m shocked, I just don’t know what to think about this.”

‘I knew this would happen,’ Greg said aloud. He looked up, afraid suddenly of what fresh new problems such a statement would cause.

“You knew what would happen?” she asked. Beth was confused. Some thought was burrowing inside of her brain, and she was frowning.

“This is what I didn’t want. I didn’t want to... see that look on your face.”

“What look on my face?” Beth said, truly sounding mystified.

“That look. That look that means you’ve lost respect for me,” Greg said bitterly. He held his hand to his forehead.

Beth leaned over him and pushed his hand out of the way. “Now it’s me who really, really doesn’t understand,” she said. “I don’t... I thought *you* had lost respect for *me*,” she explained. “What are you saying about *you*?”

Greg’s pulse quickened. This wasn’t a conversation he’d ever truly expected to be having with Beth, but suddenly it seemed right, like he might

be able to tell her this truth that was so deeply buried inside of him it hadn't even occurred to him as a coherent thought until moments ago.

But it was true. The single, most erotic thing he had ever seen in his life had been on those tapes. It wasn't because of what she had done – you could see that kind of thing in almost a million pornos. It was that it was *her* – his wife, and yet *not* his wife. He had liked the burn of it, the danger of it, the pain.

And the idea that she might do it again?

Explosive. His cock was even twitching back to life about it.

Greg had a hard time looking her in the eyes as he spoke, so he looked at the ceiling. His voice for some reason got caught in his chest and choked there, but he managed to speak. "I'm saying, I *want* you to do this," he said slowly. "It turns me on. I don't know how to explain it. And I don't – I never wanted to tell you, I never wanted you to think I was some kind of freak. I didn't even let myself think it. Not really."

Beth collapsed on her back and sighed. Greg was afraid to look over at her. He had no idea what her sigh could mean. He felt as exposed and vulnerable as if he was naked at a press conference, and all he could do was wait for her to respond.

"This... is..." Beth said, and she shook her head from side to side, lacking words to describe it. "That's *exactly* what I thought you would think of *me*, if you ever found out about any of this. That I was a freak. You know?" She turned to him and actually smiled, warmly. "We were both afraid of each other."

She turned back to face the ceiling suddenly, though, before Greg could speak.

"No," she said, resolutely. "No... this isn't a good idea. This is the kind of thing that you know, people say is going to work, or they think it's going to be hot. But it's not. Not in real life, just in theory."

Greg waited, just to be sure she was finished speaking.

"But it isn't just in theory," he said. "Those tapes are real."

She swiveled her head to face him. Her eyes were piercing, burning into him. His stomach twisted into knots again, and he felt like someone was stepping on his chest.

"But that was a long time ago," she said. He could hear in her voice the same gasping, serrated edges of his own panic, the same suffocating fear

that made it hard for him to talk. “That was Liza,” she whispered. “I don’t think that it would be the same if I did something like that now.”

“You’re afraid,” Greg said, like he was just having a revelation. “You’re afraid of that. Like me.”

Beth stared at him for a moment, her eyes unblinking. She jerked her head back to look up at the ceiling. Obviously, she was pondering his observation.

He got up on his arm now, excited. He was excited about the prospect now, of delving into these dark waters that both of them feared. “I was afraid to tell you this because I was afraid of how you would see me. And you’re afraid of it for the same reason. Maybe we have to... trust each other.”

Beth shifted her head and looked at him out of the side of her eyes. Her mouth broke into a slow, cautious smile, and then it disappeared. She shook her head again. “No,” she said. “No way. This is crazy, right?”

She had turned to him again, and pulled her shirt up to her chin like it was bedcovers. She was smiling, albeit somewhat warily.

“It’s crazy,” Greg agreed.

He leaned over to kiss her. “But I want to take a chance on it,” he whispered. “If you do.”

Beth’s eyes glittered with excitement, and then turned gray again. “We don’t have much of a choice,” she said.

Greg was aroused again, his cock throbbing painfully against his leg. He rolled over on top of Beth, whose eyes traveled down to his chest, as if she couldn’t believe the man who had climbed onto her was her husband. They hadn’t had sex twice in one day almost since they had first met.

The look of disbelief remained on her face as he spoke. “We have a choice,” he said, moving his hips from side to side to get the clothing and covers out of the way. He kissed her, and slipped his cock easily into the sodden, hot confines of her pussy. “But I want to try this. If you do.”

Beth’s pussy quivered around his cock, tightening its velvet strength around him.

“I want you to fuck Zach Pinker,” he said, and her pussy quivered again. He started to fuck her slowly. “I want you to give Zach Pinker whatever he wants.”

Truth, it is fair to say, can sometimes be a slippery beast to catch,

But the truth about how Beth felt about that idea was not possible for her to hide, because her body squeezed around him and an orgasm, quick as mercury, shook through her, even though she did her best to suppress it.

And that was just from the *thought* of giving Zach Pinker whatever he wanted.

*

Beth was glad when Greg offered to go to the grocery store, because she needed some time to think. Her pussy was sore, because she hadn't spent so much time in bed with Greg since the early days of their marriage. It wasn't sore the way Zach would make her sore – and just the thought of *that* made her flesh well up with liquid that pulsed from inside of her and trickled warm down her leg.

This couldn't be real. Greg couldn't possibly mean what he was saying.

She had no defenses against this, because it was the last thing she had ever expected to happen. It seemed almost too good to be true – in fact, it was the definition of too good to be true.

But if she let her mind go back to that moment, to Greg fucking her while he said, *I want you to give Zach Pinker whatever he wants*, her body came alive in ways she'd thought she'd lost a long time ago.

She'd accepted that she couldn't have that kind of high again.

And yet: here was Greg handing the opportunity to her on a silver platter.

Could it be real? Could she trust it?

Things like this were the stuff of bad movies. In real life, this always ended badly.

Right?

She leaned against the tile in the shower. Water snaked down her shoulders, over her chest, and between her legs. Her pussy was already aching again, her body feverish.

She wanted it. She wanted him. Zach. She wanted to give him whatever he wanted. She wanted to feel the hot thick girth of his cock, the pressure of his hand on the back of her head, the salty taste of his precum as it smeared forcefully against the back of her throat. She wanted her knees to burn, and her jaw to feel tired.

But she wanted more than that: she wanted to be used, to be fucked until she was a pool of liquid and could barely walk. She wanted to do all the dirty things that Zach could think of, and she had wanted to give herself permission to just think about it for a long time.

And now, Greg was giving her permission to do that, and more.

Her fingers had made their way to between her legs, and now they dipped into the hot honey that poured from inside of her. She found the hard nub of her clit and rubbed against it. She pressed hard against her body with her whole hand, and rocked her hips, while she thought of how it felt to bounce on Zach's lap, her hair wound in his hand, while he called her a whore and his cock throbbed between her legs, against the sore, raw flesh inside her cunt.

When she came, it was disorienting, and made her dizzy.

She sat down in the shower, staring at the subway tiles, and panted.

This was not a good idea.

But she was going to do it anyway.

*

Greg wondered if Beth was already acting, giving him a show. If she had somehow tapped into his fantasies, could read his mind when he jerked off in the shower, could see into the images and desires that he thought were locked safely in his mind.

Or if she was just doing what she was doing innocently, with no idea how hot it was.

Surely she had to know. Surely this woman – who was the same woman from the videos, the woman who had sucked on Zach's cock after it had been in her ass, who had licked a guy's balls with his whole dick still in her throat, who had licked cum from the bed, the floor, and off of her own face... surely she knew what she was doing, standing in front of the closet in her panties and thigh-high stockings, one leg crossed over the other, no bra.

Her hair was loose and skimmed the middle of her back. She occasionally swept it up with her hands and held it up over her head, her sculpted arms silhouetted in the light. Then she would sigh, and let it go, and the whole glorious mane would tumble down, hiding her long, smooth neck from view again.

The panties she had chosen were a lacy, black pair that were not a thong, but nestled, nonetheless, into the crack of her ass just a little. Swirls of silky embroidery pushed out of the cleft between her two round asscheeks, and the lace framed their plump beauty and the sudden narrowing of her waist to perfection. Her butt swelled out of the underwear, tapered to her long, lean legs, and her skin ran into another band of the same silky lace a few inches below the swell of her ass.

"He said, wear something nice. But... I don't know what kind of... "party"... this is," Beth was saying. She turned around to look at Greg, and her hair swung across her back. "I don't want to be overdressed."

Greg was unable to speak, so he was grateful when Beth turned and sighed at the clothes. "Ehhh," she mewled. "I guess it's irrelevant, I only have the one dress here. Or... I could wear..." she turned and looked around at the suitcases that she had opened and rummaged through, scattered all over the room. "I could cut off some shorts, make them even shorter," she said. She looked at Greg. "What do you think?"

"Uh," Greg said, finding his voice and then promptly losing it. "I don't..."

"Would you rather," she asked, batting her eyes, "Have me show up at your house wearing a dress? Or cutoff jeans and a tight shirt?"

Women. They honestly believed this sort of thing made a difference.

But which did he want to think about her wearing to Zach's house, to give him anything he wanted?

"What, uh... what would you wear... I don't know. Before?"

"You're right," Beth said decisively. "Shorts. Because I don't want him thinking that like, this is all kosher with you. He won't go for it if he thinks that."

Greg did not understand how any of those thoughts stemmed from the choice of outfit, or whether or not they were true. They didn't even make sense. He wanted to ask Beth what she meant by that, by wanting Zach to believe this wasn't cool with him, but he supposed that he knew the answer.

Beth would probably say that Zach wanted to feel like he was getting away with something, making Liza cheat on her husband.

Frankly, he didn't mind if that was the impression that Zach had. It was better for him, for his career, for the outcome of this whole convoluted nightmare/fantasy.

A thought ran through his head, hot on the heels of the preceding one: that was only true if Beth was true to him, as true as she said she was.

He would have to trust her, a vulnerability that flung itself around wetly in his chest.

As he pondered these possibilities, Beth had located a pair of scissors and performed surgery on a pair of her long jean cutoffs. She slid them on at that point and surveyed herself in the mirror as she turned around.

Greg sucked in his breath. The shorts, which had only moments ago been as figure-hugging as a burka, now tucked themselves into the crease of her thigh where her it met her torso, letting her exaggeratedly long legs dangle from them enticingly. As she turned, he noted that they allowed a sliver of her buttocks to peek through the tangle of frayed white threads she had tugged at to make them look more seasoned.

She was pulling a t-shirt – one of her old regular t-shirts, from her life in the city, just a plain black v-neck, but it clung to her body, something Greg hadn't seen for a while.

"There," she said, turning, looking at her own butt in the mirror as she did. Greg's eyes shifted to her expression, which had become absorbed in something elsewhere. She was looking at herself, but her thoughts were miles away from here, thinking not of how she looked, but how she *would* look.

To another man.

It was a ritual he had never really seen from this perspective. Sure, he assumed that Beth had looked at herself in a mirror before going out with him, but he had always wondered if she had been thinking as she did that: thinking of how he would look at her, thinking about the ways she would tantalize him.

He wondered this all his life, actually, about all women, and now, he had a voyeur's seat at the show.

His heart oscillated between cold and hot until he thought he might have a heart attack. Beth pushed her hair away from her face and looked at herself in the mirror again.

"You look hot," Greg said, squeaking through his dry throat.

Beth waved this away with very saccharine laughter, but not before she dropped her chin and met her own eyes in the mirror, basking in the compliment.

The only problem, of course, was that Greg couldn't be sure whose approval she was excited to have more.

"Okay," she said, turning to face him. "Showtime."

CHAPTER 10

The driveway to the house behind Zach's landscaping business was, notably, very beautifully landscaped. It was an odd thing to take note of, Beth realized, as she drove. It was even odder to her that Zach – the tattooed, devil-may-care, alpha-male of the slum that was Walla Beach, possessed an acumen for both business and something like landscaping. She would have put him down easily for mafia boss, professional poker player, or some other dangerous profession. Landscaping was... odd.

Probably, she thought, there was some kind of money laundering going on here.

The thought made her smile, and then just as quickly, put a knife of fear through her heart.

If there was one thing that she could say with certainty about this situation, it was that she didn't want anything to happen to Greg because of it. At least, nothing more than what he had already suffered. She dug her phone out of her purse and held it, wondering if she should call Greg and ask him if he wanted her to retreat. Because what if this whole thing was even shadier than it already seemed? What if Zach's plans were extensive, to blackmail them, and pull them into a web of intrigue and crime and money laundering...?

"You have officially watched," she said to her phone, turning the screen off with a decisive crunch of her thumb. "Breaking Bad too many times."

Her stomach did not seem to get this rational message, and it contracted uneasily as she stepped from the car, which she parked in an area off to the side of the space in front of the three-car garage that was paved with an expensive pebble and mortar pavement in multiple colors that formed a classy, swirled design.

Her fears of money laundering returned.

She walked toward the front door, taking in the immense house. Up close, it was even bigger than she had believed, and because it was set on a hill, it loomed over her. But even without that trick, it was a substantial mansion.

An enormous, screened-in porch wrapped around the house, and she noticed that the screening extended to the underside of the porch. She rang

the doorbell but couldn't hear it through the huge oak doors.

She waited. She rang again.

She pulled out her phone when she got no answer, and realized that she didn't have Zach's phone number. She looked up at the ceiling and shifted her feet impatiently. "God," she muttered.

This was just like Zach. He worked his power over you – or anyone – with little, tiny cuts like this. Little displays of aloofness, designed – and she knew him well enough to know he *did* design them – to make you hungry for his attention. Whether you wanted to be or not.

Annoyed at him, and at herself (because it was working, just a little, whether she wanted it to or not), she turned and walked, loudly, around the house in the screened-porch area.

On every side of the house, the screened-in porch had expensive patio furniture with plush pillows, neatly arranged and perfectly clean, as well as a jukebox, a small bar area with neon lights and rows of sparkling clean beer glasses hanging from the ceiling, and at the back, facing an immense and well-manicured yard with a huge swimming pool in what looked like real granite, there was a pool table and an air hockey machine.

She stopped to stare out into the back yard, which hadn't been visible, she realized, because it was surrounded by a natural fence of cedar hedge and a combination of other tastefully arranged bushes and shrubs. The pool was large and gorgeous, and what appeared to be a hot tub was raised at one end of it, a trickle of overflowing water spilling snaking down a wall of granite into the pool.

"Holy," she said under her breath.

Her next thought was that she should get the hell out of there.

She turned abruptly, and then shrieked, because standing in an open doorway that she hadn't noticed, was Zach. Calm. Completely at ease. The wolf-like hunger, as always, in his eyes. He was holding a bottle of wine and a corkscrew, and leaning against the door frame. She hadn't heard him at all.

She brought her hand to her chest. "Sorry," she said. "I... rang the doorbell. Phew, you scared me." She pushed her hair from her face and willed herself to stop blabbering. She sounded like her twenty-year-old self, and she hated it.

His eyes moved up and down her body, appraising, she supposed, her outfit.

“I don’t have anything other than jean shorts,” she explained.

Zach met her eyes. He was an expert in this: disarming her, making her uncomfortable. The helplessness she had always felt around him returned, and with it a throb of sexual hunger, and the bite of anger – anger at herself for being incapable of resisting him.

“Those ain’t the same ones I was complaining about,” Zach commented, stepping out of the house. He looked at her legs. “Still lookin’ good,” he said.

Then, to her surprise, he turned abruptly to her left, and walked to the bar. He stood behind it and slid two wine glasses from the ceiling rack, setting them down on the bar.

“Oh, none for... no thanks, not for me,” she said quickly, as he poured wine into the first glass.

Zach continued pouring, as she knew he would anyway. He set the wine bottle down and looked over at her. “It’s a good one,” he told her. “You should have a drink.”

She looked at the bottle, then the glass. She had walked slowly over to the bar. “Uh... no. Yeah. I need to, uh... drive -”

“I’ll get you home.”

“... and, uh... just, I just want to hash this out and go home, Zach.”

He picked up both glasses, and walked around the bar. He put one in her hand, which she’d raised on cue, and she closed her fingers around it. She felt, as she often did in Zach’s presence, like a puppet being pulled by strings.

He took a sip of his wine as he walked past her. “You’re here to find out what I want,” he said, as he brushed by her. His shoulder barely touched hers but it sent an electric thrill through her body. “I want you to have a glass of wine with me.”

She turned, furious, to face him, her cheeks hot with anger. But he wasn’t looking at her. He was facing the back yard, surveying his empire.

“Zach,” she began.

“You like the pool?” he asked.

Here it was. Zach’s one-two punch. A little dominant behavior, and then something like this, some kind of Gatsby-esque appeal to his softer side, some careless comment that would make her feel sorry for him.

She looked down at the wine. “Look, Zach. It’s nice, the house is nice... looks like you’re doing really well for yourself. But I’m not here on a

social call.”

He turned around and looked at her, with a grin that was deceptive on his face. It could have been sinister, and yet it might have also been amused and friendly. Combined with his words, it was disorienting. “You’re here,” he said steadily, “to do what I want. And I want you to have some wine and come take a look at my pool.”

He stepped backward upon uttering this last word, and pushed the door open, stepping easily onto a set of stone steps, as though he walked backward through that door staring a woman down every day of his life.

Beth lifted the wine to her lips and followed him.

He walked quickly, a spring in his step, with Beth following more hesitantly, looking around as she did. It *was* an impressive yard, and pool, and if she said so, it would make him pleased. “This is amazing,” she told him, as he sat down in a deck chair next to a table.

“So’d you tell hubby you’re here?” Zach asked, disregarding her comment. “Or is this a solo mission?”

She set her wine glass on the table and glared at him before she sat down, attempting to recapture her own resolve to show Zach he might be able to make her do a few things, but that she was a different person now, so it wouldn’t be for the same reasons as before.

It wouldn’t be because of his raw sexual energy, because he was an alpha-male prototype, because she couldn’t deny that she wanted him.

No. Now, she was Beth Quinn, and Beth Quinn was older, wiser, and more in control of herself.

“Does it matter?” she retorted icily.

“Heh,” Zach said. He appreciated the line. “Same old Liza.”

“If that’s what you want to think,” she said.

The grin on his face dissolved, as a breeze picked up and lifted her hair. It almost looked as if the wind had taken his humor with it. He made no reply.

She sipped her wine and looked out over the pool, disconcerted. His eyes had burned through her already, and her heart was pounding, her pussy aching, her body betraying her mind. “I need to get assurances,” she said, jumping into a speech she’d rehearsed, though not exactly for this moment.

It sounded canned and she knew he would hear that in her inflection. But she was already talking, so she kept going. “I need to see the tapes and get you to sign something, so I’ve got...”

Her voice trailed off because she had shifted her eyes back to him. A faint smile had returned to his lips. It was smug, and as she had felt so many times before, she could easily have punched him in the nose. But that would probably do nothing to him, and she knew she didn't have the guts.

"Now Liza, that's-"

"Beth," she corrected, more meekly than before.

"That's not why I invited you, Liza Brown. So it's rude."

She rolled her eyes. "Cut the shit, Zach."

He leaned forward on the table, sliding his hand toward her wine glass. His fingers went to the stem, pressing the narrow crystal between thumb and forefinger, erotically massaging the length of glass. His hand was nowhere near her body, but the sparse hair on her forearms rose and a shudder she did her best to hide snaked through her core. Once again, her pussy throbbed and got wetter by the second.

"Don't be like that," he said. "You came over here, to talk about what *I* want. Remember?"

She inhaled, as slowly as she possibly could, but her breath was shaky and her need for oxygen too great. It sounded like a little gasp.

"What do you want, Zach?" he prompted.

That was it: this was what he wanted her to say. Because he knew that if she said it, if he could make her repeat the words, then he had her back in his thrall. It was a speculation she would have bet her whole house on, and that's because she knew it was true.

She slid the wine glass her way, grasping the top of it, and then took a long swallow. She watched his hand slide back across the table, and another flare-up of anger worked its way through her as he leaned back and put his hands behind his head.

The muscles of his biceps were inked in full sleeves, but the solid tone of his arms was impossible to ignore, even nestled among the camouflage of his tattoos. A memory came to her, in the form of temperature and scent: the heat of those arms against her face, across her chest, under her palms, and the scent of his body while he fucked: animal, musky, somehow sweet.

Her breath was staggered, entering her body in jagged, stumbling inhales that made her chest rise sharply and at odd intervals. She wanted to tell him she hated him, or get up and leave, or do anything else but what he wanted, but her limbs would not respond.

“What *do* you want, Zach?” she managed to say.

“Not like that,” he said, almost before she finished her sentence.

“What do you want, Zach?”

A throaty, begging whore tone was what he wanted.

Her lips trembled.

His eyes bored into hers, liquefying her insides. She heard her own voice and felt her lips moving, and then realized that she was talking, giving him what he wanted, doing it exactly like he wanted her to.

“What do you want, Zach?”

The smile that formed on his lips was almost like a spasm, turning the corner of his mouth up for a moment before fading to the same, wolf-like stare.

He extended an arm toward the pool, leaving the other behind his head.

“Try my pool, Liza Brown,” he said. “I want you to try my pool and tell me if you like it.”

“I don’t,” she began, shaking her head at herself and looking at her lap. She didn’t have a swimsuit, is what she was going to say, but of course, Zach knew that. That’s why he wanted her to get in the pool.

She stood up without looking at him, sighing.

She pulled her shirt off and tossed it on the chair. Then she unbuttoned her jean shorts and let them drop to the ground. She stepped out of her sandals as she stepped out of the jean shorts.

She was glad that she was wearing what she was wearing, that the lingerie she’d chosen framed her body so perfectly. She watched Zach’s eyes walk all over her body.

When he stood up, she trembled, and she was angry that he seemed to like the effect he had on her. A grin slipped across his face and disappeared as he stepped toward her, around her, and lifted one strap of her bra with a finger, sliding from her collarbone to her shoulder blade. The back of his finger grazed her skin.

“This is a nice lingerie set,” he said. “I think you should take it off.”

He was already unhooking her bra, sliding the straps from her shoulders. The material slid down her arms, and she helped it along. Her nipples hardened in the air, but it was not from the cold. She glanced down at them, past them to her legs and the underwear that still remained.

Zach drew a finger down her spine, and she closed her eyes. There was no stopping the goosebumps that formed on her skin, no willing her pussy to stop heating up and spewing slick moisture into her panties. No way not to tremble, or to not respond. But she would sure as hell try.

Two hands now, hooking under her panties, pulling them down her hips, peeling them from her legs. As they folded over, turning inside out, and he pulled them down, the scent of her pussy reached even her nose.

She could feel Zach's breath against her skin as he traveled down her legs with the panties. Hot, caressing her buttocks and extending whispery tendrils of heated air into her crack, over her ass, the thought of which made her pulse and squeeze with the memory of his dick stretching her open. The moist miasma went between her legs, down her thighs, promising the heated, flesh of his tongue and never delivering.

He stood up behind her, swiped her hair to one side, and brought his lips close to her skin, hovering just above her shoulder.

Into her ear, he whispered: "That's better."

And then his fingers pressed into small of her back, and he prodded her gently forward, toward the steps into the pool.

She walked, without looking behind her, head ringing and blood pumping in her ears. She knew his eyes were on her, devouring her.

And here she was again.

Zach's puppet, his flesh doll, a slave to his every whim.

And though she wanted to be anything but, she was aroused to a screaming pitch.

*

The pulsing high that Greg was on remained with him for a few minutes after Beth's car disappeared behind the overgrowth at the edge of the yard. And then, like a fast tide rolling in, his doubts came for him, and he felt submerged and no longer buoyant.

He realized that he had no idea what to do with himself, something that he might have found comical under any other circumstances. Up until the moment she left, he was excited and thrilled, seeing only through the tunnel of his unexpected desires. Now, even if he hadn't experienced the terrifying sensation of having made a terrible mistake, he would still be left

on his own to wait. And uncharacteristically for Greg, he had no plan for this time at all.

He had often wondered about some of the people he had prosecuted, about the moments after they had committed some crime in the heat of the moment – because that was most people, really. Hardly anyone actually *planned* murders, or any crimes, for that matter. The only thing that still interested him, after so many years at that job, were those moments immediately after the deed had been committed, the minutes during which a person's choices came into focus, and the realization that their life had been irreversibly changed washed over them.

Was that him, now? Had he just let his wife walk out the door to do something that would alter their marriage forever?

He began by behaving irrationally, looking for things in cupboards and pacing around the house. For what? An answer to his riddle? A way out? Shaking, he settled on picking up his phone. He brought up Beth's number, then held the phone in his hand, staring at it, body humming with a sickening mixture of adrenaline, anxiety, and sexual excitement. Staring at the phone, in his mind he went through all the things that he could possibly do *now* to put a stop to what he had set in motion.

He could call Beth, but something about doing that so soon after they had agreed on this decision, right after she left the house, made him feel like a lunatic, and he didn't want to seem like a crazy, neurotic man. Strangely, it was Beth's impression of him, if he did so, that deterred him most strongly from calling. He could almost feel her disgust at his weakness.

No, if he did something it would have to be something else, something more manly, more decisive, if he did anything at all.

He thought about driving out to the landscaping company. He had already scouted it out, back in the theoretical stages of this mission. It hadn't been too hard to find. He had looked up landscaping companies on Google Maps, and from there it hadn't been rocket science to figure out that the only landscaping company in town, named Pinker Landscaping, belonged to Zach Pinker. He had even gone to street view to see what the property looked like, indulging in a fantasy that he might go there, and somehow spy on what would occur when his wife went to meet Zach. There, his fantasy had taken a realistic and dark turn, and he had found himself immersed for a long time in concocting a way to sneak up on the buildings, especially the

distant, gigantic mansion – almost undoubtedly Zach’s house, a large, ostentatious tribute to the man’s success that burned Greg from the inside out when he thought of his own, unfair, financial fortunes of late.

Or of his wife’s feelings about them. Surely Beth wasn’t inured to the appeal of wealth. It was an aspect of Zach Pinker that Greg found more unsettling than his fabled sexual prowess, perhaps because it seemed to have real potential for luring his wife away from him on a more permanent basis.

He had a momentary, fantastical thought: he could still do that. Try to sneak up there, watch them, be ready to jump in if things became too wild, too indecent, too *personal*.

But the fantasy deflated rapidly with only moments of practical consideration. He hadn’t been able to get a good look at what the approach to the house would be on Google Maps, and even if he had, what then? Nothing could be worse for his political ambitions than getting caught prowling around another man’s house, or even worse, standing in front of a window masturbating while his wife had sex with another man.

There was part of him that really, truly, believed Beth. A part of him that accepted her story: that this was a part of her past that she wanted to get rid of, put out of her mind forever. And that part of him wanted to protect her from whatever it was that would happen at Zach Pinker’s house.

There was another part of him that was angry with her for her lies.

And yet another part of him – the part that he suspected was truly stopping him from acting - that really wanted her to go and do this.

This was the part that he struggled with. It didn’t make any sense that *this* would turn him on, that he might actually *want* to climb fences and creep around someone else’s house not to stop his wife from having an affair - but instead, to watch it. The truth was that the reason he was obsessing about it now was not because he wanted it not to happen, but because he did.

He found himself upstairs, with no idea how he had gotten there, or how long he had been standing in the room, next to the bed. He sat down with the phone in his hand for a long time, his mind a blank. His mixed emotions were making him feel like puking. His stomach lurched to his throat and then back down to his groin, as though he were riding a roller coaster, a sensation made even more unbearable by the fact that he was

motionless in a stuffy room. He was aroused, but only partially. Nauseated, but only partially. Angry, but only partially.

He went downstairs and paced around, emulating the search he had done several nights ago for booze, looking in all the same places, finding all the same things. The discolored Jack Daniels bottle was still sitting on the shelf, where he had found it the other night, but tonight, he even took it off the shelf and sniffed it hopefully. It smelled like alcohol, but he still didn't trust it - not even in the fevered state he was in now.

Driving into town for some booze was an option, but it seemed a little too trashy and obsessive to him. He was busy telling himself a lie about how much control he had over himself and the actual act of driving to a liquor store to pour alcohol on his inferno of feelings was too real for him.

He also didn't trust himself not to do something stupid, like drive out to Pinker Landscaping and try to sneak up and have a look - just a look - at what his wife was doing in there.

He wasn't a Peeping Tom. He wasn't the kind of guy who would be found hiding in a closet, or sitting in a tree, dick in hand, panting while he watched other people. He wasn't the type to approach a house so he could watch two people doing something through the window.

That was criminal behavior. The kinds of stories that he'd heard all sorts of deviants coming through the courtroom telling. People who really, in a lot of ways seemed rather ordinary. People who couldn't explain their actions very well. And he had always wondered about that: what was it that so obsessed a person that they would do some of the crazy things that he heard about in court. And yet here he was, playing out that exact same scenario, unable to trust himself not to do something so very dumb.

At last, without really making a decision of any kind, he decided that the only rational thing to do was to go into town and buy himself a bottle of Jack Daniels that he could trust, and have a few drinks, and try to put all of these thoughts out of his mind. He should be savoring the thoughts that he liked, even if he didn't know why he liked them: the thought of Beth's pussy being split open by Zach's sizable dick, the idea that she would smile for Zach, now, like she had in those old videos, consumed by lust. Not sitting on a bed, immobilized by mistrust of his wife.

Or was it himself that he didn't trust.

He pondered the question only a moment before trotting purposefully down the stairs and snatching the keys from the table.

He started the car, a sense of singular purpose at the forefront of his mind. He told himself this convincing lie – that he was going to the liquor store, a sane man a little bit on edge who simply needed a stiff drink and was more than capable of calmly purchasing one.

He headed out to the main road and then turned right, pantomiming his intended voyage to the liquor store. His intentions to be a man, to not do anything crazy, to simply enjoy this mutual journey he had agreed to with his wife.

But even as he was turning right, his brain was recalculating his route, thinking ahead to where he could turn off the road he was on to go some long, meandering way to the landscaping company. He would tell himself at every intersection that he wasn't *actually* headed there yet, that he was still far away, that he would only let himself get so much closer before chickening out. And all the while he would turn and turn and turn around, until he found himself there. Faced with the very real decision of acting or not acting.

And he hated it, thinking about that. Thinking about himself, sitting in his car in the growing darkness, staring feverishly at the mansion on the hill, biting his knuckles and sweating. He hated the way he would be shaking with this same nervous energy, torn between stopping the very thing he had set in motion, and facing the very thing he feared the most.

And he hated, *hated*, what he already knew: that this trip would be a foregone conclusion. He would maybe arrive there, maybe stare at the house with longing, maybe feel terror and then a deep sadness, maybe he would feel wildly aroused. He would let a montage of images play out in his mind, he might even do something as perverted as jerking off. His heart would feel trampled, his ego beaten down, thinking about how he was letting Beth's pussy be desecrated by a man like Zach Pinker, a man who would manhandle and use his wife, tell her to do filthy things, and spew his cum inside of her after she did them all with that terrible, subservient smile on her face.

But in the end, he would turn his car around and come back home, because he knew himself and he knew what kind of man he was. He was a man who would not risk committing a misdemeanor to face something he wanted to see more than anything, and also wanted to excise from his life and his consciousness.

He drove closer and closer to the town, gripping the steering wheel in tension, almost the way he would subconsciously do so while driving in the worst kinds of weather. He didn't turn, and the town came closer and closer, and the anxiety just built up with it, until he felt ready to explode.

The roads on the outskirts of the town were cut into extremely large blocks, each one of them almost half a mile long. He was pretty much assured that he would somehow arrive at the greenhouse area if he turned right and headed west for a couple of these blocks and then came back the way he had come.

It was his last chance to turn back toward town and maintain the illusion, purely for himself, that he was headed there all along, and as he approached the intersection, he was so tense he was shaking again.

He turned right, away from town.

As he went down the road, it started to get dark with that late summer suddenness. Everything around him, as it does in the country, went from idyllic to disturbing.

The road that he had expected to intersect with another at the same steady distance of half a mile, continued on, with no turn-offs to the right. The only intersecting roads were tiny, overgrown, and headed south - or at least, that was what he believed. He cursed his vehicle's broken GPS and carried on, assuming that eventually, some road would have to appear and take him back in the direction he had wanted to go.

He pulled over to check his phone, angry with himself for not doing that several intersections ago.

The internet service was terrible where he was, and the darkness was filling in the sky much faster than the map he tried to conjure would load.

Greg had always lived in the city, and so the deepening, rural darkness was more unsettling to him than to the average person. He started up the car again, and continued along the road, in the same direction he was going, because the road had narrowed and steep ditches lined either side, and it occurred to him that if he encountered car trouble, he would be out in the middle of nowhere, and evidently with no phone service. The world seemed suddenly wild and inhospitable, like he had fallen off the edge of the earth.

Greg's urban upbringing, unfortunately, had also led him to believe that roads in the country would be laid out like the roads and streets of a city, in neat blocks that only detoured from straight lines when a natural

feature like a river forced them to deviate temporarily. But the roads of Turner County had been etched into the earth long ago and seemingly with little order; they twisted and turned and very soon he was unsure of the direction he was headed.

A new sense of panic was now replacing his panic about Beth. It came at first as a relief, but it only put Beth out of his mind for a few minutes. After a while, the two dangers – of being lost in Hicksville, and of losing his wife, merged and began to feed off of each other, until he was actually in a cold sweat.

At last, he arrived at an intersection - of sorts. He decided that his best bet was to go back the way that he came. He made a significant three-point turn, but as he passed through the intersection, he looked off to his left.

Unexpectedly, he saw what seemed like a tunnel with a great deal of light at the end of it. He wasn't sure why he did what he did next, because it was stupid, and dangerous, but he had a feeling about the bright lights at the end of that tunnel. Could they be the greenhouses? As Beth had described them, they were enormous, like an alien ship in the middle of the landscape.

Forgetting his fears of the roads and the ditches that lined them, he turned the car to get a better look at the road. The bright lights beckoned him from the end of a tunnel of tangled overgrowth. He could see streaks of darkness criss-crossing the road, undoubtedly fallen trees. A sign, twisted and half-knocked over, as though not just one but many cars had drunkenly swiped it, informed him that the road was “unassumed” and that he entered it at his own risk.

Still, the lights beckoned him, like sirens. They weren't that far away, really. He felt that he could walk there. He took out his phone, making another effort to determine where he was. There was still no signal, only the occasional flutter of a single bar as he moved it around in the cab.

In the middle of doing this, he realized how idiotic he was being. What was he thinking, even thinking about traipsing about in the middle of the night down a spooky, unassumed road, when no one knew he was here, and he had no phone signal?

But even as he put his car in reverse and pointed it back down the windy road that had gotten him lost, intending to (responsibly) go back the way he came, even as he cursed himself and felt small and crazy... he had to smile a little at himself. It had been a long, *long* time since he had felt the

lure of sexual desire like this - poisoning his mind, making him do stupid and irresponsible things. So long he had felt beyond it, out of its grasp completely.

And yet here he was, almost ready to hike, in the dark, toward a light at the end of a spooky road, for the mere promise that he might be closer to - not even necessarily see or participate in or upend, just be *closer* to - his wife, about to succumb to the prowess of another man. To have the fist of testosterone close around him again felt good in its own way, like an elixir of youth he had begun to feel he was leaving behind.

He drove back the way he had come, the road winding back the way it must have wound as he drove out here, but confusing him further. Adrift again, everything around him looking at once exactly the same, and completely unfamiliar, he started to doubt entirely his assessment of the direction he was headed. He arrived at yet another intersection and stopped the car, confounded.

To his recollection, since he had turned down this road to head in what he had believed to be a northerly direction, he was certain that he hadn't passed any intersections until he had arrived at the unassumed road and then turned around. But a dark road, similar to that unassumed road, led off to his left.

It was either the road he had come on, or not, and if he misjudged it, he might get hopelessly lost.

As he took out his phone and tried to get a map up, he imagined himself, driving around the country roads all night, afraid to stop, never finding a way out of the darkness.

After an excruciating few minutes, during which the panic of being lost managed to consume him - taking precedence over even his most carnal impulses - he decided to trust his memory, and turn left. The road he had taken here had been dark and narrow. Or so he believed.

About a quarter of a mile down the road, he realized that it was not the first road that had brought him here. It was too narrow to turn around, though, and backing up seemed almost impossible. So he continued on, as the road sloped downhill, and then, to his great chagrin, began to wind around as well.

He knew that this was how people got lost. He knew that his best bet must be to turn around and go back the way he came. The road began to go uphill, and he became hopeful that his phone would suddenly have better

reception. With one hand on the steering wheel and half his attention on the road, he held it out and tried yet again to conjure a complete map with his location on it.

He only noticed, at the last minute, a car coming in his direction, when the lights popped up at the top of the hill. He veered to the right and hit a large pothole, forcing him to brake at the crest of the hill just as the car bounced past him, dangerously close.

The map was slowly loading, and as he sat there staring at the screen, waiting for it, he realized he hadn't even taken a look around.

From the top of the hill where he had stopped, the road went steeply down a hill to a lot of dark, jungly vegetation. Beyond that, there was a swath of cleared land, with a large house and a well-lit set of buildings.

He glanced back at the map - still loading. The darkness yawned up at him, the potential of Zach's greenhouses being somewhere just beyond it beckoned him, and his frustration got the better of him. This road had to lead *somewhere*, after all: a car had just passed him.

Knowing better, but propelled forward by that promise of sexual excitement, however contorted and distant, he took his foot off the brake, and let the vehicle roll slowly down the hill. The darkness of the thick overgrowth swallowed him, and his headlights, almost immediately.

The imprudence of his choice - not just to continue down the road, but metaphorically, to travel into such dark territory with his wife - came closing in on him, as did the trees and undergrowth. But there was no way to turn around now, not even dangerously.

And so he continued.

At long last, the vegetation cleared a little, and his headlights glared upon a sort of clearing - the road widened and, it seemed, turned left. Directly in front of him, the road seemed to end in darkness in its purest form: something invisible seemed to throw his headlights back at him.

When he got very close, his lights caught on a distortion. He was losing it, he thought, braking. To his left, the road opened up into a rounded parking area of sorts. He stared out the windshield.

A heavy black chain link fence had been the cause of the distortion, and he marveled that no sign marked its existence. He surveyed the area to the left of him. Beer cans and cigarette butts, as well as a milieu of other trash, littered the edges of the area.

It was obvious that he had come upon one of those rural "spots" where teenagers congregated to drink, make out, smoke, fuck in the back of cars. But it was, blessedly, a good place to turn around.

Relieved, believing he would now be able to get himself home, he made a slow turn in the area and had every intention of driving from there to the next road, turning left, and somehow escaping this nightmarish trip.

But with the primal fear of being hopelessly lost diminished, the other fears, and emotions, came to the forefront of his mind and began to consume him.

He looked left, and parked. Like a zombie, he exited his vehicle and approached the black fence. Now that his headlights were pointed away from the darkness, they cast a glow that allowed his adjusting eyes to peer into the darkness beyond.

A large swath of black lawn rose up sharply from the fence. But it was manicured lawn, recently cut, wet with dew from the unusual chill that had descended after the sun went down. The scent of freshly mowed lawn pervaded the air.

At the top of the hill, he could see lights dotting the darkness that contrasted with the inky sky: a house. A large house. And peeking over the crest of this manicured lawn-hill, the hazy glow of bright lights somewhere below lit up the cooling humid air to create a sparse fog.

Just up at the top of that hill, he made out a car, gray-colored in the darkness. He knew it was Beth's car. He knew he was *there* – that somehow, in all of his bungled driving, he had arrived exactly where he had wanted to go. He knew that inside the house on the hill, his wife was there, doing what Zach asked her to do. Maybe she was enjoying it, maybe her eyes were rolling back in ecstasy and she was screaming in pleasure, as he stared at her vehicle in the dark. But he was here. And all that stood between him, and Zach, and his wife, was the black fence that was possible to climb.

...And then what? he thought, for perhaps the millionth time. Creep up the dark hill? Peek into all of the windows? Throw open the door, demand his wife back? Tell her to stop?

He pictured the scene, until he could almost feel himself running up the hill, feel his hands on the damp grass as he scrambled up the steepest part. He could almost feel the rushing blood and adrenaline as he stormed into another man's house, almost like it was really happening to him.

Would he go room to room, yelling her name? Find them in a large living room, Beth on the couch on her hands and knees, Zach Pinker behind her, buck-naked, his cock embedded deep in her ass? He would hear them before he got to that room, hear the same sounds that she'd made in some of those videos, echoing through this gigantic home as he searched desperately for her. She would squeal and pant and beg for more.

He was getting a hard on, with his fingers wrapped around the chain link fence, thinking about his wife with another man's cock inside of her.

He just wanted to see it. He wanted to see it with his own eyes, see that it was real. But what would happen, once he caught her? Unlike the videos, it wouldn't just stop. He wouldn't find himself alone in a room, his cum sticky on his hand still wrapped around his dick. There would be no laptop to slam shut and end the scene. Beth would still be there, and Zach's huge cock would leave its mark on her body. Cum would ooze from her stretched ass, mingling with her pussy juices. She would *smell* like him, her body would be tainted by him, her internal flesh would be stretched and rumpled, loose after his presence inside of her.

And if she saw him, what would she do? Would she look at Greg with those same eyes that he had seen in the videos - eyes that were wild with lust, searing with admonishment and hunger and satisfaction, eyes that didn't seem like her own - and then turn away from him, smiling, to grab Zach's cock and feed it to herself, cleaning his cock off, filling her mouth with his dirty cum and the taste of her ass and his dick?

He let the fantasy play out a little bit longer, but a sound up the road made him turn around quickly and snap from his reverie. Lights bounced among the trees; someone was coming down the road.

He realized, suddenly and clearly, where he was. What he was. He felt, suddenly like a small petty criminal, leaning against a chain-link fence with a hard cock, salivating to see his wife getting fucked by another man. Thinking of her pretty, pink flesh being pummeled by his gnarled cock, imagining in detail the destruction that would be left behind.

What the fuck was wrong with him?

He jumped into his car quickly, started it, and sped up the hill. The car that passed him was indeed full of teenagers; judging by the way the car was swerving they were probably drunk. Some of them leaned out the car window as they passed, hollering nonsense that seemed both encouraging and sinister.

He had to swerve to avoid hitting their vehicle. Another jolt of adrenaline hit him as he reached the crest of the hill. He felt even more like a pervert, alone at a makeout place, precum, staining his pants. He was grateful the kids in the car hadn't seen him by the fence, grateful they had come before he had taken his dick out and started masturbating - for he had been so close to doing that that he didn't like to even think about it.

He vowed to go back the way he came, to focus on that simple task. But before long the monotony of the dark roads, bleached gray by his headlights, coming at him much too quickly because he was driving much too fast, became a perfect screen upon which to project his visual fantasies. The image he had concocted in his own mind - a mashup of all the images he had ever seen, ever, not just the tape he had seen of Zach and his wife, but also all the porn he had ever watched and all the images he had stored in his head of his wife - wouldn't leave his mind or his field of vision. It was almost as if he could reach out and touch her, hear the slurping sound as a cock slopped from her mouth after finishing in her throat. He could almost smell sex in the car - maybe because of his own oozing precum, or perhaps it was a figment of his imagination. Maybe both.

He was so intently focused on this - thinking about, obsessing about it, that he must have driven right through the intersection he meant to turn on. He had no idea how much time had passed between his leaving the lot by the fence and realizing that he had been driving for too long.

Now he really was lost. And the road before him trailed away into the darkness, no turns and no lights in sight.

Throwing caution to the wind, the panic of dying in the backwoods outside of Walla Beach pushing out all of these other thoughts, he carefully executed a turn, the number of points of which he lost track of as the back of his neck heated up and panic ate away at his mind. While he was out here lost, his wife was with Zach, getting filled up with his cum.

Somehow, somehow, turning carefully, concentrating on the road, he emerged after half an hour onto a paved road. Ahead of him, orange lights were reflected in a cloudy sky. He had no idea where he was, but he drove toward the light gratefully, certain that at the very least he would arrive at a town and be able to use his phone to get himself home.

He was disoriented momentarily as he approached the town and saw the now-familiar icons of Walla Beach materialize in the darkness - on opposite sides of the road from what he would have expected. For a

moment his brain could not reconcile what he was seeing with the direction he had very much believed to be headed in, and his mind was even offering such odd solutions as having found a mirror image of the town somewhere down the road. But the huge neon sign with a palm tree and the nonsensical Walla Beach logo - "We beach you to it!" - stubbornly refused to adhere to his sense of where he was, until the whole world shifted and he had a full reckoning with how lost he had actually been. Somehow, he had overshot the greenhouses from the *opposite* direction, and arrived back here probably only through a sheer miracle.

The liquor store was on his left, and he turned into the parking lot carelessly, only narrowly avoiding a collision with an oncoming vehicle. He robotically purchased his Jack Daniels, and returned to the house after consulting Google Maps multiple times, and committing the turns in the road to memory.

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He had been gone a long time, he realized, when he looked at his phone upon arriving back at the house. Beth's car was still gone, and she had not called or texted him. The nightmare continued.

He poured himself a healthy glassful of Jack Daniels, into a plastic juice glass for children he found in the cupboards. Then he sat and stared at the door.

Midnight came and went, and time seemed to slow until it was barely moving. He poured himself more whiskey, and continued to stare emptily into the dark. His heart pounded as lights appeared through the dense thicket of trees, sparkling with promise, and then disappearing.

He began in his drunken state to get paranoid, wondering if he had sent his wife to go see a psychopath, and she was not, in fact, being ravaged by an alpha male, but murdered. This was a fantasy that, in combination with the booze, was not particularly hard to fuel, because he had worked on a number of gruesome murder cases in his time.

Now that he thought about it, those cases hadn't begun all that dissimilarly to this, in fact, so many of them had begun with an ex-boyfriend.

He thought about calling the police, but with the phone in his hand, he realized that he had no reason to be doing so: his wife wasn't missing.

She had gone to an ex-boyfriend's house and explicitly stated that she was going there to do whatever Zach wanted, in order to get tapes that would ruin both her reputation and his if they were to get out. What would he say to the police? "I know my wife is cuckolding me, and that's fine, but now that I ponder it drunk, I'm a little worried that the blackmailer might be out to kill her?"

He didn't think that seriously, if he pondered it enough. His worry was less about murder and more about the way Zach seemed to control his wife, the way he manhandled her, and the way she seemed to like it.

That was then, he reminded himself, as Beth had reminded him over and over again. She was different now: no longer Liza Brown but Beth Quinn, and she wanted different things. Sure, the sex itself would probably be mind-blowing as always, but it wouldn't suck her into Zach's web the way it had in the past.

Right?

"*Right?*" he repeated to himself, desperately. His voice seemed to echo around the kitchen. Had he spoken aloud?

As time ticked by, he decided to send a message. It took him a while to compose it, to capture the way he wanted Beth to see him, as confident and cool, but caring. After all, it was late.

Just checking on you. It's late. Let me know you're okay.

Once sent, the message ate away at his thoughts. There was no answer, and the blankness after his own message seemed to laugh at him from his screen. With a crushing sensation of cowardice in his chest, he called her, but she didn't answer. There was nothing left to do but sit in the kitchen, blurry-eyed with drink, and stare at the refrigerator. He couldn't concentrate on anything else, even if he had tried, which he didn't. He could only sit there, pour himself more booze, and replay, over and over again in his mind, the images and fantasies he had concocted.

At one point, the time unknown to him, he crept up to the bedroom, fear twisting in his chest like he was a burglar. He retrieved the illicit copies of the videos he had made to another USB key without telling Beth. He fished the key from a drawer where he had tucked it away, promising with each passing hour to destroy it, once and for all - after all, the only thing

worse than a damning video was a copy of a damning video, floating around out there to be discovered.

He held the key in his hands, full of self-loathing for having made the copy, wanting to destroy it, wanting it to no longer hold him in its grip. Wanting it to stop begging him to watch just *one more* video.

But one video always led to another. And then another. And then to re-watching one he found particularly appealing. It always ended the same way: his hand on his dick, wet with his own cum, a pounding in his head, and the video almost always still playing.

Those were the moments, while he was in that brief window of sexual disinterest following an orgasm, when he could see, he supposed, all of it clearly for what it was. At those times he felt pathetic and ashamed of what he had used to get off. And on the screen, still wild with lust and smiling, moaning and mewling and stretching and being pummeled by Zach's enormous cock, or two men at the same time, was his wife. Still going at it. Still consumed by the sexual fever that had gripped him only moments before, made him watch again and again.

Only her fever was never-ending, because it could be replayed, forever.

He watched a video anyway - choosing, for some inexplicable reason, the one he liked both least and best, in which Beth bounced atop some faceless male body, her eyes on the camera as it moved around the bed, capturing from every angle the plunging of cock into her pussy. Her tits bounced, and sweat beaded at the nape of her neck, running down her shoulders to her spine, and then streaming into the crack of her ass. The cameraman had taken special care to get in close, to film the rivulets of sweat as they streamed over her waxed, hairless skin, over the pucker of her anus, and down to the sticky, glistening cock that her pussy greedily consumed again and again and again.

It irked him - the full wax, that it was always perfect and fresh in every video. Her hair was different lengths, different colors even, and so the passage of time was evident and achronological - but a constant was her bare, fully waxed skin, something he had never known Beth to do, never seen on her before - and something which also afforded an unobstructed view into the crushing, battering, shredding actions of all the dicks that she let into her pretty pink pussy.

He paused while he watched this particular scene, a stomachache building to an excruciating pain from his balls to his chest, so that he wouldn't come until the scene completed, so that he wouldn't be spent and pathetic, cum growing cold on his hand, when the part he most despised and most liked took place.

After several minutes of the up-close shots of Beth's pussy bouncing on cock, the camera was paused, and then turned back on. It had been set down, presumably, on a dresser or a stand of some kind, so that Zach would be free for the next scene.

Beth was lying on top of the same guy, her face to his chest, her vacant face looking into the camera. In particular, this moment - with Beth covered in her own sweat, the glow of an orgasm that was never shown still flushing her face, her eyes looking but seeing nothing - was the part that stood out the most for Greg. She was lying there, limp and fucked-out, still rolling her hips a little against the man beneath her.

Zach stepped in from the right, but his voice came first. "Did you come, you little slut? Hmm? I didn't tell you that you could. That's a very bad girl, Liza."

"She's still hot for it," the other male observed.

Zach was behind Beth now, making himself comfortable on the bed, his hand wrapped around his thick dick, though there wasn't any need: it was pointed out in front of him, ready, enormous, twitching with his own desire.

"Oh, I know," Zach said, positioning himself between their legs, pushing them both apart so that there was room for him in a wide "v" to position himself and lean over Beth. He pushed her damp hair away from her face almost tenderly. "She can't ever get enough. But that's not the point, is it, Liza baby?"

Beth brought her hand to her lips absent-mindedly, her eyes still staring at the camera but as though it were miles away. She moved her head in a roll that looked like a "no," but said nothing. Instead, her mouth fell open and she gasped, because Zach's hand had dropped to her ass, and he was playing with it.

There was no view to what he was doing, just the tensing, coiled strength of his forearm contorting, the motion of his hand, the hints that he was plunging his fingers inside of her, clawing against her inner flesh, doing whatever he pleased and making her wild as he did so.

"So what does that mean, Liza? What do bad girls get?"

Beth was almost non-responsive. The guy underneath her lifted his head to look at what Zach was doing with moderate suspicion. Maybe he could feel Zach's fingers through Beth's flesh.

Shaking, Greg did what he had done nearly every time he had watched this video - every time after the first time, that is, because that time he had stared at the screen in paralyzed horror. But now, he reached forward, fingers hovering over the mousepad, poised to spring at just the right moment.

He caught it this time: it was difficult to do. But there was a flash, no more than a second, where Beth's unseeing eyes came to life, and though she didn't turn or change the direction of her gaze, it was apparent that she was back in the room again. And at that same moment, though it was very brief and very small, Beth's mouth also turned up in a smile.

Not just any smile, a smile of pleasure, a slutty, porn-star-grade smile.

Her thumb was nearly between her lips when she said, her eyes distant again: "Fucked in the ass."

Zach adjusted himself behind her, smiling cruelly, looking down at her as he patted her bottom playfully. "Fucked *hard* in the ass, baby."

Another smile flitted across Beth's lips, and this time Greg tried but failed to pause it at the right moment. It flashed across her face, though, of this he was certain. But Beth said nothing, which made Zach demand, in a low voice: "Say it, baby. I like to hear it."

"Bad girls get fucked hard in the ass," she said.

This caused quite a sensation in the man she was lying on, and his own hips began to move. There was no window into the details of his cock moving within Beth's pussy and Greg, as he inevitably did, found himself willing the camera to move, to close in on that scene, as if there were any physical way to view the specific thing he wanted to see: penetration, slippery fluids, engorged flesh being pounded to a pulp by the faceless man's relentless pounding.

Instead, the camera remained where it was, Beth's face limp against the man's chest, sliding in the sweat that shone on her skin and his, mouth open, lips curled upward just the tiniest bit. And her eyes, wide and vacant, windows into the vast, gaping lust that consumed her as Zach's cock disappeared into her ass.

Zach made good on his promise to fuck her hard in the ass, the slaps of his thighs against her skin marking the violent thrusts that drove him deep inside of her. For a few minutes – minutes that stretched on for what Greg perceived as lifetimes – Beth lay inertly on the other man's chest, absorbing Zach's abuse without noise or action.

But after a while, she became aroused again, and began to pant. Her biceps hardened and her fingers drove deep into the man's flesh. Guttural moans and squeals, more animal-like than human, began to spill from her mouth, which fell open wider and wider.

She tried to lift her head, and Zach pushed her back down, his forearm tensed with a serious grip on her hair.

"I'm going to come," Beth said – whether it was a complaint or a narrative, Greg couldn't tell. "Oh, oh, oh my -"

But whatever Beth was going to say, it was strangled in her throat, and her eyes squeezed shut and she screamed and her body jerked with another fresh orgasm. The man below her finished off inside of her, yelling loudly.

Zach seemed to find all of this amusing, and with Beth pinned below him, his arm still holding her face to the man's chest, he slowed his fucking, staring down at his cock as he sawed in and out of Beth's ass at a leisurely pace.

The sounds that Beth made were incomprehensible. The twitching of her limbs ceased, and her eyes opened to look into the camera. And that was what she was doing, features contorted in what could be agony or the heights of pleasure, while Zach hammered his cum into her.

Greg stared at the screen as the video ended, with Zach withdrawing from his wife's ass with a filthy slurp, and, cock swinging between his thighs, walking toward the camera just before the screen went blank.

Ordinarily, he masturbated to this one, and when he finished somewhere in the middle, he forced himself to sit and watch the final minutes, the pain of what he was seeing working an uncomfortable ache into his cock, like he was still stroking himself, long after he came.

But this time, he stared at the screen without touching himself until the video ended, and for a long time, he was so entranced by his own imagination – this very scene could be, for all he knew, happening right now – that he didn't even realize it was over.

And still, no word from Beth.

CHAPTER 11

The first thing to enter her stream of consciousness when she woke up were the green numbers of a digital clock: 3:12.

For a moment, the preceding events did not come to her, only the confusion of that number, and what was displaying it. There were a few terrifying, free-falling moments when she thought she had taken an afternoon nap that had gone too long and was now confused.

And then, in waves, it all came to her. Fear gripped her, and a slimier, greasier feeling came quickly on its heels: guilt.

She could feel Zach's arm next to her body, touching her skin. She knew from experience that he was lying on his stomach, face to the left, and that he was asleep to the world. The fact that she knew this without looking at him almost filled her with more guilt than the other memories chasing it.

She sat up, and his arm slid from on top of her body.

She crept out of bed, her heart pounding. Three am. Three am. No calls to Greg, no explanation of where she was or what had happened.

She hadn't had very much to drink, she thought, digging into her purse for her phone. She glanced at the missed calls, the text message notifications, saw the time stamps next to them, from hours and hours ago, and the cold knife of guilt twisted further inside of her, making her clutch her stomach.

She would sort it out later. She assured herself that her purse contents were inside, and then tiptoed out to the porch and into the chilled night air, looking for her clothes.

Her shorts and underwear were where she had left them, but the bra had gone missing somehow, and she could only find one shoe. Wanting desperately to get home, to sort things with Greg, and above all, to *not* see Zach, she took the single shoe and hurried around, pulling on the shorts and underwear, putting the shirt on as she walked.

The shoe she did find, thankfully, was for her right foot, allowing her to drive the car a little more safely.

As she crept to her car, she saw a figure in an upstairs window, which had to be Zach, but she pretended not to see him, and imagined he didn't care, either.

She drove away as quickly as she could, and once on the road, she fished into her bag for her phone. The road was black, and she was driving fast, and there were deer here like anywhere else rural, but she had to check the time stamps of Greg's calls and texts again. Still driving, she looked between the spooky, headlight-lit darkness and the phone, her foot poised to brake if the metallic pupils of any animal appeared in the dark.

She realized, as she did this, that she was still probably drunk. She hadn't had much, but she had had more than she should have. She felt incredibly out of control as she held the wheel with two hands, the phone squeezed between her thumb and forefinger. She realized that she was crying by the time she reached her first turn.

But she didn't know what sort of crying it was.

What was she going to say to Greg? It wasn't as if he didn't know what she was going there to do. And he had told her that she should do it. What had she been expecting to happen? What had she thought that Zach, of all people, was going to do?

She supposed that she had known that it was going to be something like what had actually happened, but while she had been imagining it, preparing for it, and planning how she would tell Greg about it, she had envisioned a short story. He poured me some wine, we had sex, and that was that.

She had promised to tell the truth, and to tell him everything. But now that it had happened, she wasn't sure: was it really what Greg wanted to hear?

She had gone into the pool, like Zach asked her to. And already then, she had begun to feel that all-too-familiar feeling, of Zach controlling her, telling her what to do. For as much as she wanted to deny it, it was a feeling that she craved.

It wasn't something that she wanted in her relationship - it wasn't what she wanted from Greg.

It was intoxicating, like eating a decadent dessert. She didn't want to replace her whole diet with it, but it was delicious while it was happening.

He had come up behind her in the pool: she had never looked back to see him approach. She felt his pecs and his cock, hard against the small of her back. The eroticism of that sensation - feeling the shape of his cock against her back - almost turned that part of her body into a zone as erogenous as her inner thighs or the bottoms of her feet.

He just kind of stood there, with his dick throbbing against her, and they both stopped in the middle of the pool.

"So what do you think?" Zach said. "Do you like it?"

From there, without saying anything, she swam to the far side of the pool where the water poured in from the hot tub. Or at least that was where she had been headed.

Zach, with his quick reflexes and controlled, calm athleticism, had reached out and caught her right foot as she floated away. He pulled her back, turning her as he dragged her through the water.

From there, it had been as simple as just locking together two pieces of a puzzle. He pulled her as she floated on her back, her right leg now on the left side of his body, her spread legs headed toward his large cock.

And then he just pulled her onto him. There was no foreplay, no asking for permission, no negotiating, not even the tiniest bit of awkward positioning. He just sank right into her wet pussy. She wasn't used to his size, she hadn't been with anybody but Greg for a long time. The salt water of the pool had washed away the moisture gushing from the outside of her pussy, so as he passed through her outer lips and the beginning of her wet hole, there was a rubbery friction and a bite similar to losing her virginity as his thick cock worked its way into her cunt.

But as soon as he penetrated her, just an inch or so, his cock met up with all the hot liquid she had been gushing since she had seen him, and he slid right in.

It was as if no time had passed between the last time he had fucked her and that moment. The full feeling of his cock being so deep inside of her, bumping up against her cervix, igniting the tiniest bit of discomfort buried deep inside of her, completely stretching her open. She felt his soft balls as she met up with his pelvis, and then, as if no time had passed at all between them, her legs wrapped around him, and she reached up to hold onto his shoulders. His hands went to her hips.

The entire time, he was staring at her with that animal, hypnotic stare that only Zach possessed. It was the sort of all-powerful gaze that would make her do anything.

And that's just what she did.

He seized her hips and she held onto his shoulders. Her lips were parted, and she realized that she had gasped as he had entered her, not from pain, but from the surprise of remembering him so well. At the surprise that

a craving she hadn't thought about in years had been ignited, a craving that she truly believed had flamed out and died. To discover that it had only been suppressed, and had still been burning like a hot coal, and was now being breathed upon and fanned into flames.

When Zach fucked her, it wasn't anything like any other man she had ever fucked.

He simply took what he wanted, and the way that he did it reduced her to nothing more than a toy, and an object, and she knew that. She knew that he looked at her as something to be possessed and controlled, as more of a pussy attached to a woman and not the other way around. She knew it, she knew she was possessed - it wasn't her, it was the animal within her - and so when she was being fucked by him, obeying his commands, she was just her primal self. Just her body, just sensations and urges and desire, in a black hole. She was disconnected from everything else.

It was a high, a drug - and a bad drug - and she knew that. But now that she was getting her first taste of it in almost a decade, as he jerked her body up and down his cock and burned into her eyes with that powerful stare, she forgot everything that she had ever known and the only thing that she could think about was the way that he felt inside of her. The power, the control in his eyes, was all that she could see.

It was always like that with him.

He made her come, and when she did, the first time that night, after such a long time of not having that kind of release, it was as if she had been building up a desire inside of her for all these years, and it exploded like a bomb. It shook her from head to toe, her feet thrashed around in the water, and she threw her head back. Her hands slipped off his shoulders, and she would have fallen backward - and probably drowned in her ecstasy, had Zach not grabbed her and pulled her back toward him by her biceps. She yelled loudly and shook and screamed.

But Zach wasn't finished with her. He let her come, let the orgasm shake through her body until all of her muscles were weak and she could barely feel anything. The only sensation that remained was the hard full feeling of his cock in her pussy. It ached, and she was sore, but the orgasm had gripped her so completely that her muscles felt like jelly, and so she was limp like a rag doll as Zach pushed off, walking with his cock still inside her, over to the side of the pool. As he did, his dick shifted in her

pussy, pressing out to the left and the right, touching even more places than she had thought possible, making her mewl.

When they reached the edge of the pool, she was limp in his arms as he pushed her up and turned her around, draping her over the side of the pool. Then he nudged her legs open and entered her from behind.

As she lay there, limp, her eyes wide in disbelief, the last electric shocks of her orgasm flickering through her body like heat lightning, he slowly fucked her already-sore pussy until he came.

But that was just the beginning of Zach's plans for her, and she knew it.

It had always been like this with him. He had a power to turn her into a rag doll, take his pleasure from her, and in doing so, wind her up just a little bit so she would be hungry again for more in no time at all. As she lay there panting on the ground at the side of the pool, she could see everything that was going to happen that evening as clear as day. Not exactly what Zach would do to her - he was a creative, filthy-minded man whose depravity had only had time to marinate - but she could see that she would be there doing whatever he wanted for however long he wanted to do it.

She might think that she wanted to leave, but her body wouldn't let her.

He withdrew from inside her and she felt the emptiness in her pussy in a way that it reached out through all of her body and almost caused her pain. It wasn't much different than what addicts described as withdrawals, but it came from there. It radiated out to her limbs, and started to consume her before she even pushed herself up and back down into the pool.

Zach was already floating to the end of the pool where the steps were. He walked out, calmly, self-satisfied, and did not look back at her. She hadn't noticed the bench that he walked up to, or the two towels that he had already placed there.

It irked her that he had known all along the outcome of this evening, that he had had no doubt that the events of the evening would play out exactly as he wanted, that she would do exactly what he said, and that he had known all along that he would need those two towels.

She hated, too, that he walked into the house without saying anything, that he didn't look back. He didn't have to, and he knew it. They both did.

And while she very much wanted to get into her clothes and go home, just to show him that he didn't have the power he thought he did, she knew she wasn't going to.

She was going to do the very thing that she ended up doing, and wait a moment, think of leaving, but in the end, she was going to emerge from the pool, take the towel, and follow him into the house. Where he would tell her what he would do to her next, or what she was going to do to him. She could almost taste his bitter cum in the back of her throat, feel the pulpy battered soreness of her pussy after he had his way with her, over and over again.

When she stepped out of the pool the night air felt cooler than she had expected. She shivered. And then, she followed Zach inside.

How would she even tell Greg that part of the story, and tell the whole truth as she had promised? What could she leave out, what should she leave out? Because she didn't want to be this person, she didn't want to be an addict, to lose herself in fucking this guy who was, other than his sexual prowess, nothing and nobody compared to Greg.

And that was why, as she drove home from Zach's to her aunt's house, detail after detail of all the sordid things she had done - and the sheer number of times she had done them - surfacing in her mind, painting a picture of the night, that was why her eyes were wet with tears.

Because there was always a chance that if she told Greg all of these dark things, and all these truths, that he wouldn't respect her or love her anymore.

And even if that were true - even if she had thought of Greg for a single moment after arriving at Zach's house - there would have been nothing she could have done to stop herself or resist Zach's control over her.

Did Greg want to hear *that* truth? Surely he didn't?

The lights were on in the house when she pulled in to the driveway. She noted that the other car had been moved, and was now parked at an odd angle and deep into some overgrowth. She braked hard and jumped out of her car, expecting to see Greg slumped over the steering wheel. But he wasn't, and as she surveyed the nose of the car in the bushes, it appeared to have rolled slowly into them.

She hurried into the house, furious with a flare-up of anger, assuming he had driven drunk.

As she moved, she noticed the soreness that permeated her entire body, the dull ache deep between her legs, the rawness of her ass, the loose tenderness of her pussy. And, when she moved her jaw, the tired ache of it. A bitter saltiness occasionally surfaced in the back of her throat.

She had left her single shoe in the car, and walked awkwardly on the dirt driveway peppered with sharp rocks, remnants of gravel poured once, twenty years ago, and never maintained. She put her hands to her head and tried to smooth her hair, wiped her mouth, looked back at the car with a longing to get in and use the mirror to assess herself.

But there was no hiding what she had done.

She stepped into the kitchen, and there he was. His eyes were rimmed with a sleepless redness, and a half-finished bottle of Jack Daniels was on the table. His gaze was directed at her own eyes, as if he had been staring for hours at that spot on the door, waiting for her to come back.

A deep, cold fright seized her, so convincing was his expression in making her feel like she was getting caught. A tremor passed through her, and it truly felt like her heart ceased beating in her chest while the blood in her body, with nothing else to move it, drained slowly to her legs, degrees cooler in an instant.

For a moment, she was poised to begin crying and tell Greg she was sorry. Guilt wormed its way into her body, and she wanted to take everything back. Everything. Everything she had done in the past, but especially this evening.

“You said... you wouldn’t...” she began. He hadn’t really said anything that he wouldn’t do, so she couldn’t finish the sentence. She had only wanted him not to. Not to get jealous, not to get angry, not to be sad. Not to see her for who she really was, not to understand the power that Zach held over her.

“It’s four o’clock in the morning,” Greg said. He was drunk, his words slurred, and they had the irrational, angry tone of a man who has poured alcohol onto some injury of the heart, turning it into a font of aimless, neutered rage.

Tears welled up in Beth’s eyes. The hopelessness of the situation before her threatened to swallow her up. “I fell asleep,” she said quietly. Because that, at least, was the truth.

“I sent you messages,” Greg said, and she could not tell for the life of her if his tone was angry or sad, or which one she preferred. “I called

you. I thought about calling the police.”

The mention of police made her head turn toward the driveway. “Did you drive drunk?” she asked. Her tone was accusatory, a feeling that gripped her suddenly, though she couldn’t be sure if it was defensive or genuine. Aside from its obvious inherent dangers, Greg would be disbarred for a drunk-driving conviction, and his political aspirations almost certainly diminished. The idea that he had risked doing something that stupid when she was out there trying to get her past erased *for him* made her momentarily incensed.

Greg didn’t answer. He looked at her, eyes narrowing, some aspect of her question clearly getting under his skin.

“That’s a really stupid thing to do,” she continued. “It’s so *stupid*. If you got caught, then everything I did tonight would be... would be pointless!”

“I didn’t drive drunk,” Greg retorted calmly, lifting a glass to his lips and tipping it toward his mouth. It was empty, so he set it down and reached for the bottle. As he unscrewed it, she could see that her words were just then making their way through his brain, and he screwed up his face and set the bottle down hard. “And what the hell are you doing, accusing me of...? You’re the one who... it’s four in the fucking morning, Beth. You didn’t *think* to fucking check your phone?”

Beth’s arms, which she had been holding up almost like she expected him to charge her, went limp at her sides. What did he want? The real answer?

He was looking at her like he did. Challenging her, daring her to say it.

She pushed the wood door closed, more than anything because it filled time, it gave her something to do while she thought of what to say.

“Well? Beth?”

“There wasn’t any time,” she said quietly, looking at the floor.

She raised her eyes to meet his.

Greg didn’t look away as he reached for the whiskey bottle and unscrewed it, what would best be described as a harrumph leaving his lips. “Because you were fucking Zach the entire time,” he muttered.

Beth didn’t answer. She didn’t have an answer, it wasn’t even a question.

Greg looked at her for a long time, staring through the silence, until he finally seemed to accept that her silence was a confirmation.

“How many times?” he said, his eyes moving to the glass in his hand.

There was an answer to this question, and Beth knew what it was. But she didn’t want to say it aloud. Maybe some of them didn’t count as individual fucks. Maybe sucking Zach’s cock didn’t count.

Greg saw her calculating and the disdain in his eyes tore a hole in her heart.

“I don’t... a lot... it’s not...” she stammered.

“Too many to count?” Greg demanded.

Beth’s mouth fell open, and she slowly rolled her head from side to side. “You said -”

“How many loads of cum, Beth, did Zach fuck into you?”

“You said you wanted me to do this,” she retorted, and even though her insides were slippery with liverish guilt, she was getting angry at the way Greg was talking to her. “You knew what I was going there to do, you _.”

“And you said, you would tell me everything that happened. So, tell me. Tell me what you did from... eight o’clock until now, Beth. And then tell me why you thought it was a good idea not to call me or check your phone. God!” He yelled this word, suddenly angry, and emphasized it with a smashing of his very tight fist on the table, making the liquid in the glass spit up a single, large droplet and the bottle itself sway like a drunk on the tabletop. “What did you think I would be thinking, Beth? It’s so... it’s so... disrespectful!”

“I know,” she said, hurriedly. Tears formed in her eyes. It was true, and it was awful, and if he kept getting mad about it, or she continued to deny it, he would eventually end up at the thought she didn’t want him to have, thinking of the true fact she didn’t want to occur to him: she hadn’t called because she hadn’t thought to, and she hadn’t thought to because she hadn’t thought about him, at all, until three-thirty am.

“How many times did you fuck him?”

“Four – five,” she whispered.

Greg looked shocked: it was a shocking number. His shock was replaced by a flash of anger streaking through disbelief. “Heh,” he scoffed. “Which is it?”

Her heart plunged, but she was committed to the truth. That had been the rule. “Five,” she said quietly, and her eyes squinted, like she was expecting something to be thrown at her.

He was looking blankly at the cupboards in the kitchen, his arm draped on the table, the glass of whiskey in his fingertips, being spun very slowly as they walked along the outside of it. This was where his gaze had landed when she spoke, and he seemed momentarily absorbed in some other thought.

But his eyes snapped back to meet hers, and there was something completely different in them now. But she was wary of it: it looked like lust, almost like the look in Zach’s eyes. It was discomfiting, because it stirred in her the same kind of blinding arousal that Zach could ignite. Her sore pussy throbbed.

“Did he fuck you in the ass?”

Her lips, pursed after she admitted the number of times, fell apart, and she exhaled as she nodded, as imperceptibly as she could. The phantom sensation of Zach’s cock, slippery with her own cum and the first load he had fucked into her pussy, splitting her open from behind, filling her ass, moved around inside of her.

Did you keep this ass just for me? Zach had asked her. And without waiting for an answer: *Good girl. I knew you would.*

The memory of this exchange caused a tremor to shake her hand, a twitch to flutter through her cheek.

Greg stood up, shoving the chair behind him. It tipped, and teetered for a moment, before falling back into place. His eyes moved up and down her body, stopping at places where she knew she looked particularly used. She was suddenly acutely aware of the tautness of the dried cum on her neck, the heady scent of it on her breasts and chest, where Zach had dumped a load and knelt over her, rubbing it in with his fingertips like it was massage oil.

She must have been a sight: her lips felt puffy and raw, the bitter taste wandered through her mouth again as though cued from backstage. Her pussy pulsed and a hot, thick liquid oozed onto her thigh. She wanted to run upstairs and take a shower, and the words were poised to leave her mouth, if only she could make it work.

But Greg was walking toward her, and he didn’t seem to care about any of that. He, like Zach had so many times that evening, was holding her

in place with his gaze, and if there had been any doubt about what kind of heat burned behind his eyes, it disappeared when she took a darting glance at his pants, which did nothing to hide his erection.

It was hard to believe, strange to believe – and thinking about it disoriented her for a moment, so terrifically that she had to put a hand out to steady herself so that she wouldn't fall over. He really was turned on by it.

Now he was close to her – close enough to smell what she smelled on herself: the scent of sex, not average and ordinary sex, but the kind of extensive, fluid-heavy, twisted and all-encompassing sex that she and Zach had performed, five times.

"I'll go take a shower," she suggested, weakly. Greg was coming toward her, his eyes hardened and hungry, and she was almost mortified to feel her sore pussy throbbing, her own excitement pouring into her already sodden channel. Her thoughts were a wild flip-book between Zach and Greg, so lightning fast she wasn't even sure who she was thinking about, who she was craving in that moment.

"No," Greg said, just before he put his hand to the back of her head, gripping her by the hair, and pulled her toward him to kiss her.

It was a wet, ferocious, kiss, in which he devoured her lips and drove his tongue into her mouth, exploring her, reclaiming her as his own, not letting her breathe. She went limp, stunned by Greg's aggressiveness. Not that he was never, ever like this... but given that she could still taste Zach in her mouth, and feel his semen slippery on her thighs, dried on her skin... didn't Greg care?

No.

His fingers gripped her jean shorts at the hip, wiggling around, seeking her underwear. When they didn't find them, Greg released her mouth and moved his head back to look her in the eye.

"I lost them," she said, her voice quiet and filled with the tone of an apology.

Greg didn't answer, just pulled her shorts down with a fierce jerk of both hands. He let them fall, his eyes still on hers. He moved his right hand over her ass, into the crack, where his fingers slipped in the viscous smear of sweat and cum that had accumulated there. His left hand moved down her front, between her legs, and he spread his fingers to push her legs slightly apart.

She gasped as his fingers gingerly worked their way down to her ass, finding the still-slightly-gaping eyelet and tracing the pads of his fingertips over it, following the outline of her sphincter. His eyes were hawk-like as he searched hers while he did this, glinting as she shuddered, warm when her body pressed against his.

He drew his left hand through her soaked pussy lips, pressing against her swollen, hard clit as he did so. His touch sent an electric jolt through her, and she gasped. This deterred him from traveling further, and he slipped down again, then pinched her clit between his thumb and pointer finger.

“Take your shirt off,” he said, just before pinching her clit. The flesh was so distended, so turgid again, that it did not slip in his grasp, but instead jolted her again. She put her arms to the sides of her shirt and began to tug, while Greg shifted his hands so she could get out of it.

With his hand still massaging her pussy, making a sloppy wet sound as he did, he leaned back to survey her body. She knew that her nipples were bright red, maybe even bearing a slight discoloration in the shape of Zach’s front teeth. He liked to bite. Hard. And he had, plucking a string that connected her cunt and her tits.

She tried to read Greg’s expression, but his fingers were the only thing she could think about at that point: massaging, cupping her pussy, slick with moisture.

She had put her hands back, palms flat to the wall, and returned them there after taking off her shirt, more out of shock than anything else. She went to move them now, reach for his cock, but he nudged them back with his forearm as he pushed his weight against her, pinning her to the wall. His right hand went back to her ass, playing with her quivering hole again.

“Does it hurt?” he asked, dipping the very tip of his finger inside of her. “Tell the truth.”

Her lips fell apart, and she was suddenly dizzy, enough that she had to let her eyes fall, like she was sleepy. Greg ground his body against hers, squeezing his breath out, pinning her to the wall so that she couldn’t have moved or stopped his exploration of her body if she had wanted to.

Her eyes fluttered open, meeting his.

She didn’t want to. She didn’t want him to stop. He had reignited the ache that Zach had left her with, and now the soreness was being stroked into an excruciatingly pleasurable sensation, and the heat in the core of her

body that she had been sure was exhausted was somehow flickering to life again. She felt sweat trickle from the nape of her neck down her back, cold on her spine until it was absorbed by Greg's forearm.

"It does... it doesn't... it's..." she said, in a breathless whisper. He squeezed her clit again and her eyelids fell closed as her mouth emitted a silenced scream in a puff of air.

"Did you suck his cock?"

She nodded, squinting. Greg had slipped two fingers into her pussy, and he was fucking her with his hand, making her want him inside of her, filling her up. She heard herself mewl.

Greg was staring at her, a look of disbelieving pleasure on his face. Her pussy was pulsing around his fingers, the liquids spewing from inside of her, down her thighs, all over his hand. And he looked pleased with it, pleased with the fact that she was a raving, out-of-control slut.

Was it real? It seemed like it was.

"I want you to come for me," Greg said, leaning his forehead against hers. He was looking down, watching her heaving chest and her distended nipples bouncing with her breath. Watching his hand as it plunged in her pussy, then out.

Greg never said anything like that. That was something Zach would say, a command, a demand, something that made her blood boil.

She reached for his pants, trying to free him from them. She could feel his erection, the damp stain of precum, and in the back of her mind she thought about how that had never happened with Greg, not that she knew of.

But he drove his fingers deep inside of her pussy and pushed his body back against hers, trapping her hand. "Come for me. And then I'm going to fuck you."

She rolled her head in pleased agony against the wall. "I'm too sore," she whined, not because it was necessarily true, or because she wanted him to stop. It just escaped her mouth, like so many other things she said while fucking. But it made Greg's cock pulse against her abdomen, so she mewled and said it again.

Greg's fingers became slow and gentle, which was almost more agonizing, because she had just been about to go over the edge. She moved her thighs apart further and braced herself against the wall again, sweaty palms on the cool plaster.

Greg finger-fucked her gently to orgasm, staring at her as he did. She moved her head a lot, because it was, in its own way, pure torture: Greg's every stroke reactivated flesh that had already been turned to a pulp by Zach. It was a soreness that could barely be distinguished from the ache of longing, but so intense that it felt like a completely new feeling.

She heard herself as she panted and tossed her head, and whinnied like a horse. "I can't," she complained. "I can't... take... any more... don't stop..." she was saying. She heard herself but couldn't believe it was her own voice, her own sloshing pussy, her own mewling.

Greg was staring at her with an almost clinical intent as he fucked her with his fingers, never altering his rhythm, never giving in to her conflicting pleas to stop or to not stop, never going faster or harder, even when she tipped her head forward and her knees went weak, and her lips moved over his earlobe as she whispered hoarsely, "I'm coming, oh, God, I'm so close..."

When she came, it overtook her entire body, and her mind went to pieces – high-pitched, rapid buzzing invaded her ears, and a black, tingling starriness crept toward her whole field of vision from seemingly the back of her head, which felt cold. All of her muscles, though, seized up, until her thighs hurt and her mouth was filled with flesh. She had, she realized, clamped down on Greg's shoulder.

And between her legs, she gushed all of the cum from her own body, and the numerous loads that Zach had pummeled into her, all of it pouring over Greg's hand, pressed tightly between their bodies.

He continued to fuck her with his fingers even as she orgasmed, even as she screamed and then went limp but moaned in an overstimulated agony. Her legs were jerking, she was limp like a rag doll against him, and he was pretty much holding her up against the wall by her pussy, but he didn't stop. She couldn't articulate a single word, let alone a plea, and so she just let her head fall to his shoulder.

It was only when she began to come back to life again, her arousal re-stimulated, another fire burning inside of her, that he slowly pulled his fingers from inside of her. He stepped back, and she started to slide down the wall. It was a strange experience, because she wasn't aware that her knees had given out until she was sitting on the floor.

Greg was looking down at her, and at last removing his jeans and boxers. His cock sprang from his jeans, erect and dripping with precum.

She wanted to get on her knees and pull it inside of her mouth, but she was drained of all energy, and could barely lift her hand up toward his dick.

She wondered what she looked like to him, crumpled on the floor, covered in cum, weak from so many orgasms, her body oozing loads of cum. But there was no lying for his cock: it was reddened from its extreme turgidity.

He got down on the floor and pushed her down to a lying position, before spreading her legs apart and surveying all the havoc that Zach had wrought on her body. She watched his eyes, which seemed more obsessed than they ever had before as they looked her over.

Maybe it made no sense. But as Greg looked her up and down, his fingers smearing the juices pouring from her pussy all over her abdomen, then up to her nipples, where he made enticing circles with their mixed cum on her areolae, she could see only the same kind of hunger that Zach showed.

And then, after caressing her body and smearing it with cum, like he was fingerpainting, he entered her. She squeezed his cock, a final orgasm building, unbelievably, inside of her.

She wrapped her legs around him and dug her heels into the small of his back, driving him against her. She wondered if she felt loose around him: he was smaller than Zach, but his cock felt familiar as he started to fuck her- a familiarity that aroused her, even if it neglected the parts, deep inside, that Zach had reminded her existed. Those ached, wanting that same hard attention to touch their bruised flesh and make it quiver sorely.

Greg yelled loudly when he came, and he thrust deep inside of her.

She was only maybe halfway there, to an orgasm that was one too many, but she dug her heels deep into his back and ground against him, digging her nails into his shoulder. "Don't stop," she seethed. She knew her eyes were wild when she looked at him, that she was wild – feverish with desire, grinding against him like an animal. She had already come so many times, she didn't know why she wanted this again.

It was a hunger, and she couldn't stop herself: she needed it.

Her teeth were gritted as she pushed Greg back into her pussy with her feet with each thrust. "Oh, I'm so close," she whined. "Don't stop, don't stop, keep going, don't stop until I come again," she mewled ferociously.

After that, it was a bit of a blur. It went on for a while, with her teetering on the edge for a long time. Greg's face was contorted by the same

overstimulated pain that she had felt earlier as he continued to fuck her, but his cock was fully hard again when the orgasm gripped her and made her yell.

And then, for the first time ever in her life – even with Zach – she blacked out for a moment, the heights of her orgasm scarily too intense to even endure.

She was vaguely aware of Greg slapping her lightly on the cheek, saying he was worried about her. She smiled for him, told him she was fine, and then he helped her to get up, and then *picked* her up to carry her upstairs.

By then, the sun was peeking out from the horizon. She was so tired she was falling asleep before Greg even got into bed with her, saying something about a shower... a thought she never finished.

CHAPTER 12

Beth fell asleep almost as soon as he laid her in the bed, murmuring something incoherent. He kissed her forehead, and told her he loved her, hoping she would open her eyes and tell him she loved him, too. He wanted to have sex again, and he would have tried, except that she looked so peaceful lying on the pillow. When he touched her face, and put his lips to her mouth, she didn't stir.

He stared at her for a while, wanting more, but finally abandoned any hope of waking her, and went into the shower, where he jerked off, the only thought in his head the soggy warmth of her pussy, and the ripple of discomfort that went through her as he stroked her sore insides.

He gasped loudly when he came, and almost inhaled a gallon of water, because he had been leaning over, the showerhead spilling onto his face and neck, and possibly holding his breath until he climaxed.

He lay down next to Beth, pulling the duvet over her to keep her warm. Exhaustion finally claimed him, too, even as dark thoughts began to surface in his mind, and questions, all of the questions he had for her.

He wanted all of the details from that evening, some way to extract from Beth the exact sounds and smells and feelings she had experienced.

He knew he couldn't have them. Not like he wanted.

There was a note of sadness, the kind that comes with the belief that something you've been waiting for has come and gone, as he fell asleep.

One thing that was not on his mind was the tapes, videos, bribery, whatever you wanted to call it.

That was a thought that would only surface when, some hours later, the heat and his hangover woke him.

Beth was still sleeping, her face angelic, her thoughts unclouded.

He left her after kissing her forehead again, hoping she would open her eyes, hoping he could have her again. When she continued to sleep, he went downstairs for something to drink.

Then he made her breakfast and took it upstairs on a tray.

Beth looked sheepish as she pushed herself up to a sitting position. She was staring at the breakfast tray and smiling. Then she looked at him

guiltily. “Wow,” she said. “Thank... you...” She frowned. “I can’t believe those guys had a breakfast tray.”

He set the tray on her lap and watched her push her hair from her face. The scent of sex was strong in the bedroom, sharp and pungent, and it knifed him pleasantly to think that there were three bodies that had contributed to the aroma.

A pang of guilt and apprehension went through him: it was so *wrong* to think something like that, to take pleasure in it.

Beth drank the orange juice and coffee like she hadn’t had anything to drink in years. “Oh, man,” she said. “I’m so thirsty. Can you... get me some more?”

He obliged, and when he came back she was munching distractedly on a piece of toast. He brought the whole container of juice with him, and Beth downed one tiny glass after another, like she had just run a marathon.

He raised his eyebrows when she finally stopped, panting prettily, a tiny drop of orange juice on her upper lip. He leaned in and licked it off, then kissed her. “That’s a lot of juice,” he said.

He was pleased that Beth’s face flushed momentarily. She picked up the toast and finished it, then covered her mouth. “I’m eating like an animal,” she said, some food still in her mouth. This was unusual for Beth, who was normally a model of table manners. “Sorry,” she added, reaching for a piece of bacon.

He watched her devour her food, something about it arousing as hell – maybe the raw energy she must have expended to become so ravenous and dehydrated. Another throb of guilt ballooned in his chest, but it faded.

“So,” he said, after removing the tray. He wanted to propose sex again, but Beth didn’t seem to be in the mood any longer. She fell back against the pillow, her eyes a little distant. His cock throbbed: she seemed very content, very happy with what had happened... maybe...

“What do you want to do today?” he said, picking up her hand and bringing her fingers to his lips. Her eyes shifted lazily to his and he absorbed their contented love. Sure, she had gone and done this thing – because she *had to* – but now she was here, looking at him like that, and the only thing that seemed to have happened was that they had great sex and she needed a pretty good shower. “Celebrate?”

Which he was happy to help her with, he thought placidly.

It was the last pleasant thought he had for a while.

Beth was smiling, a long vacant stare in her eyes, but one that turned up the corners of her mouth. She was peaceful and content.

And then, apropos of nothing, her eyes turned very dark, and something crept into her mind and made her whole body stiffen.

She turned her chin to look at Greg, her eyes widening, fear behind them.

Greg's heart leaped to his throat, and he felt his world spinning out of control.

There was something wrong, something lurking within all of this seemingly good fortune, something that was terrible.

"What?" Greg managed to say, after they looked at each other for a long moment. He shifted on the bed. "Beth. What's wrong?"

Beth looked too stunned to speak. For a brief second he wondered if maybe the ceiling was about to cave in on him, or a man with a gun was standing in the doorway with it pointed at him, and his brain was just moving faster through time, for these, the final seconds of his life.

"Beth?" he said, when the world didn't immediately end. He even looked behind him, the illusion was so real.

Beth closed her eyes and squeezed his hand tightly. "Oh God," she said quietly.

"Beth, you're freaking me out, what is it?" Greg demanded.

Her grip grew almost painful, and her eyes flew open to look at him pleadingly, then filled with tears that she sent streaming down her cheeks when she snapped her eyelids closed again.

"I didn't get the tapes," she whispered.

Greg's first reaction was relief: this wasn't any of the things he had feared most leaving her mouth, even if he hadn't had time to figure out what those were. The tapes, the tapes... he took a moment to even register what she was talking about.

His mouth fell open. "Oh," he said simply. He wasn't sure what that was supposed to mean, so he tried to think of something else to say, but coming up with nothing, he snapped his jaw closed.

Beth opened her eyes, and a fat teardrop swelled up and spilled from the middle of her eyelid onto her cheek. She blinked it away. "Oh, God. Greg. I... I didn't get them, I..."

"Forgot them," Greg said quietly. "That's..."

It was okay. They could get them. They could just...

But Beth was still looking at him, and she had started squeezing his hand again so tightly it hurt. Her mouth fell open. She made an “ah” sound, shook her head again, and then went silent. “I...”

“It’s okay,” he said. “We’ll just... I mean... you talked to him about them, so... you can just...” But as he was talking, his mind was working much faster than he was speaking on what it was that she was saying. Not just her words, but the inescapable expression of horror, of having screwed something up very badly... the look of guilt... on her face.

She was shaking her head, very minutely, and tears were welling up in her eyes again.

His heart plunged to his feet. “Beth...”

She looked down. Another tear splashed off her cheek. “Please don’t read anything into this, I just... I don’t know... I didn’t even... get a chance to...”

She trailed off, and the silence in the room was deafening. A fan squeaked downstairs, and a bird screeched outside.

“You didn’t get them,” Greg said slowly, as she shook her head. “Did you... talk to him about them?”

The head-shaking stopped, and Beth’s body went tense. A sniffle was the only response he got.

“Oh Greg,” she said looking up. “I’m...”

"So you didn't even *discuss* the tapes with him."

Greg said this as a statement, not a question, because he already knew the answer. The answer was evidenced in Beth's eyes, tears building up slowly, threatening to spill over. She shook her head slowly, regret evident in her face.

"That's what all of this was for," Greg said numbly, in disbelief. "That's why we did this."

"I know," Beth said quickly, her voice cracking. "I know, and that's what I *wanted* to do, it's what I intended to do. I swear. But this was what I was afraid of. And I don't know how to explain myself. I just... it's just Zach, it's what happens with him..."

"You were there until three o'clock in the morning!" Greg erupted, standing up. "You're trying to tell me you didn't have a single moment to talk to him about that? About the whole reason you were *supposedly* there?"

Beth looked for a moment like she was ready to defend herself but deflated visibly as soon as she began. She almost looked crumpled, and

then just shook her head in resignation. "I... am just going to tell you the truth," she said. "I *didn't*. I didn't think about it. At all, all that time. I stopped thinking about everything, everything except Zach, okay? I *like* being his fuck toy, I *like* him telling me what to do. I *like* sex with him." She looked up at Greg, and the truth was brimming in her eyes. "But I don't *love* him. If I was thinking straight, I would of course always choose you, and us, and... all of that. It's just not something I can control. That's... the appeal, honey. That he's overpowering, that he's like... an animal, or a drug, or... something. I forgot what I was there for, I forgot... I just... *forgot*. And then I fell asleep, and I woke up at three o'clock, and I realized what had happened... what I'd done. That it was real and that I had... I don't know, Greg! I just wanted to get home, to get home to you, I knew it was late, I knew you'd be worried... I knew you'd be thinking..."

At this point a sob - a terrible, choking, sound that she obviously had no control over, gripped her, and she wasn't able to talk for a minute. "I knew you'd be thinking, what you're thinking right now. And so I just... it's like I wanted to un-do it, I just wanted to get out of there, that's why I ... don't have my shoe... I just... left. I wanted to get home to you, I wanted to... fix things." She sniffed. "I'm sorry. I'm so sorry."

She sniffed, and then took a deep breath, shedding some of her discomposure. "But I *know*, Greg. I know Zach, I know how his mind works. He's going to give them back. This isn't... he doesn't bully people into doing things, that's not how..."

She left her sentence unfinished, but Greg didn't need her to tell him: Zach got people to do things through some other kind of manipulation, the kind of control that he had exerted over Beth when she was Liza. The kind of power that made a girl like Beth be a whore like Liza.

However briefly, this thought gave him some succor: Beth *would* understand Zach better than anyone. But the moment of relief evaporated quickly as he gave it some thought.

"The thing is, Beth... that doesn't explain any of this at all. If he doesn't bully people in that way, like you say... then what's with the tapes at all?"

Beth's eyes grew wide. Greg knew, when she folded her arms defensively, that he had touched a nerve. She was searching for an explanation, her eyes moved beneath her downcast eyelids, like she was

searching the ground for the piece of the puzzle that would make it all add up.

"He doesn't seem to be in a big hurry to give them back, Beth," Greg said, turning the knife.

Beth said nothing, her eyes still moving frantically. It wasn't adding up for *her*: Greg could see that much. But he wasn't angry with her, and now he felt sorry for her - he could see that she was struggling with the realization that she had been duped, that she had been sure of something and now having to question it.

And she felt guilty, he could tell that the sentiment of guilt was real.

This, in turn, was fueling his own guilt - the guilt of being turned on by his wife sleeping with Zach, the perverted desire to see it, to taste it, to feel it. He could liberate her from her guilt if he just explained that, if only he told her exactly how he felt.

Beth shook her head decisively, very suddenly, almost like she had heard his thoughts and wanted to cut them off. "I'll talk to him about it," she said stonily. "That will be the end of it. He just... he just *isn't* like this. I know you can't... understand that or, I don't know, trust me about that, but he just isn't... like this. It just isn't how he operates."

Beth sounded so sure of herself. It irked Greg on some level: he didn't like his wife *knowing* another man this well, *believing* in him like she was. He found himself shouting back, in spite of his true feelings, trying to convince her that he was right about Zach.

"But it *is* how he operates, Beth!" His own voice was filled with conviction.

Beth looked surprised, even a little wounded. He tried to soften the blow. "I'm sorry Beth, but it just seems like... you're telling me one thing, and then everything is panning out differently."

Beth looked up at him, meeting him squarely in the eyes, her own brimming with tears. "I know what it looks like, Greg. I know. But it just... it isn't like him, he isn't... deceptive..."

"Not deceptive?" Greg scoffed.

"I wasn't finished!" Beth said. "Not this way. He's not deceptive in this way. He doesn't... get a thrill from *making* people do things. That isn't him. He gets his rocks off by... I don't know, convincing you, hypnotizing you, making you think the whole thing is your idea... or no, not even that.

Making you *believe* the whole thing is your idea. Making you *have* the idea..." her voice crumbled away, like loose rock falling off a cliff.

Greg was already shaking his head.

"It's like... how he just dropped them off, Greg. That's what you said, right? No note, no demand?"

"Sure," Greg said sullenly. "That's just a smart criminal, Beth. The first rule of everything criminal is don't write anything down."

Beth covered her face with both hands and shook her head. Greg knew she was doubting herself, and he felt bad. But she *was* delusional if she thought Zach wasn't taking her on a ride. All evidence pointed in that direction. And for some reason he really wanted to drive the point home.

"I need to get those tapes," she said, desperately. "I *know* I can get them. I know Zach, and I know that this is... he would have given them to me, if I had just asked. I just didn't. And that was... you know, his plan. The fun he wanted to have. But I *know* him, I really do. You have to trust me. I can get them back."

"Beth, what if you're wrong? And this just keeps going on and on? What then?"

This stopped them both cold, and the silence was awkward. The idea that Zach would just keep going on and on, always demanding more, an ever-escalating gauntlet of debauchery hovered in the air between them. Greg didn't know what Beth thought about that, but he could guess from her contorted expression - which likely mirrored his own - that it wasn't a cut-and-dry horror to her any more than it was to him.

He was conflicted, and this was the most troubling thing of all: he was making an argument he didn't really want to make, trying to get an outcome that, if he told the truth, he didn't really want.

The truth?

That was something *he* didn't want to reveal.

And he didn't know how to say that to her.

But Beth, astute as always, had already picked up on this. She had, like she so often did, heard the hesitation in his voice, and her eyes became sharp and hawk-like.

"So... what *do* you want me to do?" she asked. And then, almost as if he had started arguing with her, she went on a rant. "I did this, I did this for *you*, even though I knew this would happen, that this would get out of control. That *I* would get out of control. That's why I didn't want to... I

didn't want to do this, but I did it for you. God, Greg. I just want to make it right. I'm sorry I screwed up, I'm sorry I blew it last time. I really, really... I thought it wouldn't be like that, that I'd be... *stronger*, not get sucked in. I'm sorry I did. I'm sorry. I don't know what's wrong with me. Okay?" She was pleading with him now. "But I can fix this. I know I can. I don't know how you can trust me, but if you do... I really can."

Two competing forces were inside of Greg. He wanted to believe her and show her that he trusted her. But he also - well, this was big also - really wanted her to have to go back to Zach again, to lose control again.

Only this time, he didn't want to be left at home, he wanted to be there.

And to tell Beth *that* would mean revealing this secret about his personality, that, up until they had come to Walla Beach, he had been successfully suppressing, even to himself. Now that he thought about it, of course, he knew it had always been deep down inside of him, lurking somewhere. A fantasy that he had played out while jerking off or in private musings, the kind of unfocused scenes that any guy uses to masturbate. The fantasies didn't rise to consciousness outside of those times.

The videos had just been a real, physical manifestation of his darkest fantasies, and they made him sick, but they turned him on, and he couldn't keep them out of his mind.

Explaining the truth to Beth - that this turned him on, that he enjoyed the videos so much that he had made copies of them himself - he would have to tell her all of that.

And, of course, nothing had changed about the very real fact that they did need those tapes back if they were going to safeguard his political fortunes.

"Beth," he said, his mouth taking a leap that his mind was scrambling to catch up with. "I don't know how to say this, I don't know how to tell you this. But... there's a part of me that wants you to do this, a part of me that's really turned on by it. And so, I don't know, I don't... we could think of another way out of this... but..."

A lightning-quick part of his mind was thinking, at that moment, ahead of his words. That part of his brain thought quickly, and the thought was there, in his mind, fully coherent, emerging as an idea and blossoming, and he couldn't think for the life of him why it hadn't occurred to him until now.

There was, in the end, an easy way out of this.

A sort of easy way out of this.

Kind of a gamble, actually.

But it would probably work.

But he needed to know something, and if he asked Beth that question, she would know what he was thinking. And then, there would be no reason not to try *this* plan, this coming Saturday - this plan that might make his dark fantasy a reality.

He hadn't said any of this out loud, it had all just materialized in his mind, a fully-formed idea.

Beth was still looking at him, waiting.

What had he said to her last?

"It turns you on," she repeated, dumbfounded. For a moment there was a silence, and Greg wished he could snatch back what he had said. His stomach was falling through his feet.

"I just don't understand that," Beth said. "I don't... understand what that means."

"Look, I don't understand it either," Greg said reflexively, feeling a need to defend himself. "I don't understand it at all."

"Me either," she said bitterly, and it stung for a brief moment, until Greg realized that maybe she was talking about herself.

And maybe that was what they needed to say out loud: the things they didn't understand about themselves. Beth had her secrets, and she had been forced to reveal them. He had his secrets. But who was better positioned to understand secrets - sexual, buried secrets that you hid because you thought the other person would think you were so wrong, and messed up, to have them?

"I think a lot of these problems have happened because we haven't told each other the truth," Greg said slowly. "Maybe it doesn't need to be a problem. You say that you went there to get the tapes, but then you forgot them -"

"I'm sorry, Greg, I -"

"I'm not trying to... listen, please just hear me out," Greg interrupted. "I'm not saying that's bad, I'm trying to say... I'm trying to make you see that, you have secrets, I have secrets. We have things we want to do, and we never admitted those things to each other because they seem... you know... wrong. But what if... what if I can understand your secret, and you can

understand mine, and if we're both getting something we actually want, then... you know... what's the problem? Right?"

Beth was trying to look wounded but not doing a very good job. Her lip trembled. He could see that he had hit the nail on the head. After all, that was his job: to watch people when he made arguments, to see them land and take shape in their minds, to see someone becoming convinced. So it was almost like a professional instinct to pounce on her at that time.

"Look," he said, reaching for her hand, which she let him take. "I think you know, in your heart, that this is something you actually want to do. And... so what, so what if you do? If I do too? Then why don't we look at this as an opportunity, for both of us to get something we want, but something we never admitted to wanting?"

He could hear himself, and some part of him wished he could get himself to stop talking. The right thing to do would be to tell Beth now, tell her that he had a pretty surefire way of getting those tapes back without her having to resort to going back to Zach as his sexual plaything.

But he couldn't force himself to say it.

Beth was looking at him strangely now, and he could see that he had snagged her. He could see that she was leaning toward wanting to agree with him - and that was all it took. She might put up a fight now, ask an obscure question, bargain about morality.

But she would be doing that for show, because she felt obligated to.

Not because she wasn't inclined to agree.

And once again, because he had the sensation that he was getting what he wanted but that it might not be the best idea, he felt his stomach flying around again.

It was out of his hands now, he told himself.

Beth would decide.

It seemed like he was waiting a really long time for her to answer. Excruciatingly long.

"But isn't that just so... so wrong, Greg?" she said at last. "I feel like it's wrong. I feel like I shouldn't be saying this to you or feeling these things or doing them..."

"But you want to," Greg said. "You clearly want to. And I'm trying to tell you that I feel the same way. I don't *want* to be feeling this way, I feel like it's wrong, I feel like it's really twisted. But..." he sighed. "I don't know.

Maybe two people can agree to do something like this, if they both want the same thing. Maybe it doesn't matter."

You can always tell her, and yourself, that you thought of this other idea too late, Greg's devilish anti-conscience offered helpfully, as a final pang of guilt swelled in his chest.

Beth thought about this for a minute, and he could tell that he was winning her over. All that remained was to go in for the kill: the real thing that he wanted, the real condition of her doing this. And that was going to be hard. But it was just a matter of saying it the right way now.

He still had her hand in his, and he squeezed it, and pulled her toward him. "We still don't know if he's going to give us the tapes," she repeated.

"I'm going with you," he said.

That would have been the moment, the opening, the last place where it would have been easy to turn around.

And he had let it pass, and so he was forging ahead. His heart raced. This *was* wrong, but not for the reasons Beth thought it was.

She looked alarmed for a moment, and then he could see that a realization was slowly moving into her expression: she was getting it, starting to understand. Not only that he *wanted* her to do this, but that he wanted to *watch*. He was salivating for it. She was beginning to understand that it was more than an idle fantasy, more like a fetish.

"Greg, I don't..." she began.

"You don't know what?" he asked. "I mean, I don't know, I don't know if that's really what I want, Beth. I was never able to really articulate it to myself. I never would have said anything to you about it. Just like you never said anything to me about... you know. Your past. Zach. The things you like about Zach, about sex with Zach. You can't hide what I see in those tapes, Beth. You can't deny that you get caught up in it, that you like it. But you wouldn't have told me about it, and I wouldn't have told you about myself. Unless we had come here, right?"

"So maybe this is more like... an opportunity. A hall pass for us. A chance to do something we never would have, otherwise. You can tell yourself it's something you *have* to do, and I can tell myself it's something you *have* to do. And even if we regret it all, we get the tapes back, and we can tell ourselves it's what we *had* to do."

"That..." she said, after a while. "Seems a little too pat."

His heart fell.

"Doesn't it?" she added, sending his hopes soaring again.

She *wanted* him to say no.

It was done: the jury was sold. All he had to do now was knock it down.

"Maybe it seems that way," he said. He squeezed her hand. "Please, Beth. Let's trust each other."

Beth looked, if anything, mistrustful. But mistrustful like a street dog, sniffing at food in a stranger's hand.

She was going to go for it, in the end.

"We don't have a choice," he added.

A thread of guilt in his chest flared white-hot, searing him from the inside out.

Pretend you didn't think of it, he told himself.

Perhaps if things had been different, if Beth had delayed a little more, he might have changed the course of their adventure then and there. He was about to open his mouth and tell her his alternative plan.

But Beth spoke first.

"Okay," she said. "All right." And then, after a moment and a heavy sigh: "I'm in."

Just like that, her phone chirped loudly from downstairs.

She took a shower, while Greg went to wash the dishes but threw them in the sink in anger, breaking one, and paced in the yard.

Beth came out of the house, dressed in a baggy t-shirt and jean shorts, her face a little horrified, holding the phone in her hand. She held it out to him, a text message from a number she hadn't programmed into her phone on the screen.

That was fun.

Come over Saturday for more

CHAPTER 13

Beth's thumb hovered over the screen for only a moment, her stomach twisting with anxiety. This was almost like standing on the edge of a bridge and thinking about bungee jumping.

She believed Greg, and she believed that he wanted this, maybe it was because secretly she wanted it too, and because she had held the secret in her heart for so long - the secret of enjoying the kind of submissive, all-encompassing raunchy sex that she enjoyed with Zach, and she had been hiding that from Greg throughout their entire marriage.

The thing was, she didn't want Greg to do those things with her - she knew that. It wasn't even that she didn't want that, it was just that she didn't believe that he could do it, and it wouldn't be believable, even if he tried to pretend. So when he admitted to her that this was something he wanted, it was easier to believe than she would have thought possible.

"If you're having second thoughts," Greg said, next to her on the bed, "Then don't do it."

She looked over at him. "Are *you* having second thoughts?"

This made him laugh. "I mean, of course I am. But... Beth, I just can't think it through again and again. We decided what to do, nothing has changed. Anyway, we can leave this all behind as soon as we sell this house."

"If we get the tapes from Zach," she said.

"We're *going* to get the tapes from Zach," Greg said, his voice steely with a level of confidence that she rarely saw in him. He had so much confidence, and so much more than she thought was possible, that she knew there was something else behind that confidence that he hadn't included in his plan as he had told it to her.

It worried her.

"You don't know how Zach is," she said cautiously. "I mean, I want to stand up to him, but somehow I just can't."

"Listen," Greg said. "I know we can pull this off, and I have a backup plan if we can't. Just do it," and then he reached out and gently pushed her thumb down on the screen.

Beth inhaled sharply.

It was done; the message was sent, and there was nothing to do but see how Zach responded.

*I'll come over on Saturday, but I'm bringing Greg.
I need to talk to you about our agreement.*

She had written the words exactly as Greg had dictated them. There could be no reference to tapes in the text messages, if it was possible to avoid. Plausible deniability was always the name of the game.

They waited. Nothing came back for several minutes, which probably wasn't that odd, but the time passed slowly and it felt like an eternity.

"What if he's not okay with this?" she said, after a lengthy wait.
"What then?"

"I have a backup plan," Greg repeated. "I just... I prefer that we work it out like this."

The backup plan, the backup plan. He kept mentioning it, and she kept accepting the answer, not wanting or willing to pry into it for some reason. She knew the reason for herself: she liked the idea of the hall pass, liked the idea of "having" to go through with something that she wanted to be able, simultaneously, to claim to Greg that she didn't *really* want to do.

So she stayed quiet, and didn't ask about Plan B. Greg must have his reasons for not going there, to that idea, and maybe he wasn't sharing them because he, like her, wanted to indulge in something that they both knew they shouldn't.

Just then, the chirp-chirp of a new message came through, and they both jerked their eyes toward the phone.

Zach had lived up to everyone's expectations, and beyond.

The more the merrier

"Well," she said. "I guess that's that."

CHAPTER 14

"Well," Greg said, parking the car at the bottom of the driveway leading up the hill to Zach's enormous house. There were already a number of cars parked in the parking area close to the house and several parked along the driveway, even a few on the yard. It gave the place an ambiance of a rich high schooler's keg party, thrown while the parents vacationed in the Caribbean. "We're here." He looked over at Beth, who was staring out the windshield with another foreign expression on her face.

He couldn't quite tell if it was dismay or disbelief, but her cheeks were flushed with nervous excitement.

He himself didn't know what to make of the scene. For some reason, he had been expecting something more intimate. In a way, he was relieved that this appeared to be just a party, because he hadn't wanted to contend with facing Zach's cool personality by himself. At the same time, the presence of so many people had a vaguely sinister air about it.

Beth stared for a few minutes, and so Greg said, "You know that we absolutely don't have to do this, if you're getting cold feet."

Beth seemed to snap out of her reverie. "No," she said, but she sounded distracted, like maybe she wasn't even answering Greg or his statement, but thinking of something else entirely.

"No. We have to get this done," she answered.

"Why do you think there's so many people here?" he asked.

"I don't know," she answered. He could see that she was thinking; her eyes surveyed the cars that were parked in the driveway, as if she was trying to identify who was there and make sense of things. "No, we have to do this, we have to get it done and over with. Maybe it's better if there are more people here."

Greg watched as a car passed theirs, driving rapidly up the driveway and then pulling over and parking on the steep slope of the lawn. A couple got out of the car. They seemed to be dressed for a semi-respectable dinner party. The woman was wearing a very sexy black dress and the man, like Greg, was dressed in a nice shirt and jeans. For a moment, the scene seemed almost normal; an average party of thirty-somethings that would be tame and not involve keg stands or jackass antics, nor anything sexual at all. A lot of the sinister ambiance and the bad vibes he had been getting evaporated.

After all, Beth seemed to know what she was doing, and she had remained steadfast in her belief - maybe better phrased as her "conviction" - that getting the tapes from Zach would be a very simple matter.

They had set up the rules so that whatever happened, whatever Zach was expecting in exchange for the tapes, it was okay to go there, as long as Greg was able to watch. That was a hard rule. Also, that, no matter what happened, she needed to confront Zach about the tapes.

The conversation setting up the rules had been much easier and much more transactional than Greg would have expected. And Beth repeatedly stated that she knew that Zach would give the tapes back. So it was really only a question of whether or not they wanted to proceed.

Now that they had shown up and there were a lot of very normal looking people, at what would seem to be a very normal party, Greg was starting to doubt both Beth's assessment of Zach and even Zach's motives. He himself was no longer sure that this was going to work out as planned.

He asked one more time, "Are you sure you want to do this?"

Beth looked over at him, and she seemed annoyed. "Why do you keep asking me that?" she snapped. "Are you sure you still want to do this?"

"Well, I mean, it just... this isn't what I expected."

Beth faced the windshield again and looked up at the house, narrowing her eyes. Her teeth emerged to bite subconsciously on her lower lip, a habit he was certain she didn't realize that she had. It always left a tiny bit of lipstick, if she was wearing it, on her teeth.

"I don't understand what this party is," she said, "but it doesn't change anything. For me." She put her hand on the door handle.

Flummoxed, and not appeased by her assessment, Greg scrambled to say something.

"You have lipstick on your tooth," he heard himself babble.

"What?" said Beth.

"Lipstick. On your tooth."

Beth's mouth closed, and he saw her tongue move beneath the surface of her flesh. She impatiently snapped the sun visor down to look at her teeth in the mirror, and, satisfied, snapped it back up. She pulled the door handle and stepped out of the car.

The dress Beth had bought was glorious, even though it was very unlike anything that she ordinarily wore back home, and completely unlike anything she had been wearing in Walla Beach. It wasn't her style, but it

suited her body. A very short, very low-cut dress that clung to her curves and even though it was made of an expensive hand-crocheted material, it had a quality of whoreishness about it. Probably because it dipped low on her chest to reveal the soft dent of her breasts, allowing skin to peek through almost everywhere - slivers of her abdomen, her ribcage, the plump round of her ass, peered through the fabric, tempting to anyone who caught a glimpse of them. Because she hadn't worn a bra, the faint outline of her nipples could be seen beneath the bumpy crochet if he knew where to look, and Greg did.

Zach had also sent a request that he had read to Beth aloud: *go commando*.

It had made her roll her eyes and snort derisively, almost as if she was saying "as if," and yet he knew that she had put them on, and then looked at herself in the mirror and caught his eye in the reflection. Then, she had silently hiked up her dress, baring inch after inch of smooth skin, and peeled her underwear away from her freshly trimmed and shaved snatch, before letting the panties slide to her knees and then shaking them down to the floor as she smoothed the crocheted dress - and all of its holes - over a mere foot or so of her thighs. They hadn't said anything to each other about that, but the memory of it - of her look, in the mirror - was seared into Greg's vision and floated, transparent, over every image he saw. It had been similar to the expression that he had seen so many times in the videos - a look meant for Zach, he remembered, each time, and his cock stiffened as his heart filled with a cool, stinging pain.

He took a deep breath, trying his best not to get too aroused, so that he could at least walk into the party with some dignity.

When he didn't get out of the car, Beth turned her head and looked back at him. He supposed that he knew at the time that that moment was his final option for an out, but the way her lips, slightly parted, formed a faint, sultry snarl, almost guaranteed that there was no way he could say no to the possibilities in front of him. And from what he could tell, Beth didn't want to, either.

She waited for him to get out, and extended her arm with a crooked elbow for him to take. He did so, and it felt a little odd, because they never walked around with arms linked anymore. But once her arm was linked with his and he could feel her warm, soft skin and the knots of her crocheted dress rubbing up against him through the material of his clothing,

it inflated his ego. Beth's hair was down, and her skin glowed with a lotion containing faint glittery substances, adding to the vaguely seedy notes of her appearance.

As he walked up the driveway with his arm linked in hers, he felt an unreal sense of pride that this woman was on his arm, and excitement about sharing her. The approach along the driveway seemed longer than it should have been, and an eerie quiet fell over the whole place, so all they could hear for a few moments was their feet crunching on the gravel and the chatter of dusktime birds in the trees of the forest Greg had driven through.

As they approached the house, the size of the party seemed to grow disproportionate to the number of cars there. Splashing could be heard from the backyard. Fairly tame music was playing, and beneath the sound, the crack of billiard balls smashing into each other. It pretty much sounded like a sports bar on a Sunday afternoon.

He watched Beth suspiciously as she trotted up the steps to the porch and, without knocking or hesitating, opened the screen door to the porch. He didn't like the familiarity of it, the way it seemed like she belonged at this house. It unsettled him, such a small thing, and he once again felt himself going on another wild turn in his mind. The innocuousness of the party seemed to morph around him, and he cast a suspicious eye over everything as he followed Beth into the porch.

They turned the corner, and he saw the expanse of Zach Pinker's wealth. If this had all been made from the landscaping business, he was in the wrong field. He surveyed the full bar and the billiard table.

No one seemed to notice them at first, and he couldn't get a read of whether or not Beth recognized any of the people there. For a second, he felt again as if he had misread everything, and they were out of place with their plan and their expectations. It seemed like an ordinary party.

But this lasted just seconds, and as Beth walked ahead of him, all the male eyes began to swivel in their sockets and focus on her lithe body as she strutted confidently down the porch. Greg recognized, in their double-takes, the expression of having seen a very attractive woman walk by.

That's when he began to hear the murmurs. In his memory, it would come as a lot of whispers, but in fact, a lot of people said it out loud. More than one male voice said, "Liza," and he even distinctly hear someone say, "Dude, I think I just saw Liza Brown."

By the time they reached the end of the stretch of the porch, the ambiance had changed drastically. Everyone was still sitting where they had been, but there was a static electricity in the air, created by Beth, and now everyone was abuzz with the rumor of Liza Brown being there.

But Greg's thoughts about this were quickly cut short because at that moment Zach himself walked out of his house onto the back porch. A splash came from the pool area on the heels of a woman's playful screaming.

He looked much like he had in the bar when Greg had first seen him, only now he wore a trendy and expensive-looking button-up shirt that emphasized his working man's physique - big on biceps, enormous chest. He seemed to have even more tattoos than before.

When he saw Zach, Greg's blood ran absolutely cold. He tapped into his hard-won skills, acquired from facing off with so many criminals who looked as tough as Zach but also really did want to kill him. He calmed himself down.

Zach's eyes went immediately to Beth, and he tipped his head back and jutted his chin a little. A tough guy's gesture for raw sexual approval. His gaze wandered from Beth's face, down her body and in the minute movements of his pupils, Greg could see the shape of Beth's body being drawn in the air. Zach lingered for a long time on the swell of her breasts, and then moved down, marking the faint curve of her navel. He lingered obscenely on the center between her legs. From there, his gaze snapped unexpectedly to Greg, who was watching him.

If there was one thing Greg had learned from his encounters with tough guys like Zach, it was not to look away. But it was hard; the moment was long and painful, and Greg's insides were moving in every imaginable direction.

It was long enough that Beth turned to look back at Greg in the middle of the stare-down, and then, perhaps unconsciously or perhaps graciously, she turned around fully and stepped between them. "This is my husband Greg," she said, and she tipped her head forward a little bit, seemingly questioning Greg with her eyes. "This is Zach," she said quietly, and then stepped out of the way.

There was something false in the dismissive way that she introduced Zach, almost like she was trying to act colder toward Zach than Greg knew she actually felt. But it was endearing, and so even though anyone could see

that it had come across quite awkwardly and Zach was laughing behind his stoic facade. Greg knew - or at least hoped - that she was signaling to him that she was on his side, not Zach's. Or at least wanted to be.

Zach gave him a wolfish grin and extended his hand with a sharp jab forward. It was an aggressive way to shake hands, but Greg had been expecting it, so he went wide and slapped into Zach's hand, prepared for an overzealous, crushing handshake.

But Zach wasn't that type of guy, which was almost more frightening. He shook his hand firmly but did not try to make a point with it, and said, "What's up, man?" with a sort of thuggish level of confrontation.

Greg heard himself say, "What's up?"

Zach didn't seem to care that much about Greg, or his presence there. It didn't seem to be an act. If this was some kind of face-off to Greg - as it was - it seemed to be truly meaningless to Zach, which almost made him a more formidable opponent.

"Did you bring your suit this time?" Zach said, turning his attention suddenly and fully back on Beth.

Beth was now looking at Zach and shook her head very quickly. "You didn't tell me to bring one," she said. It was clear that she regretted having said this, having just caught on that Zach was making a bit of a joke, a reference to the evening they had spent together.

This made Zach smile, in his smug and devious way.

Greg could already see what Beth was talking about when she had said that Zach was hypnotic. Whatever he was projecting - dominance, alpha-maleness - it was working on Beth, and the changes in her behavior were subtle, but Greg could see them all. The way she was leaning in, almost like Zach held in her in a slow-moving tractor beam, and there was no way to fight it.

His eyes were so busy moving from Zach's face to his wife's that he was surprised when Zach's mouth formed a grin, and then the man's eyes shifted back to meet Greg's. Greg dropped his gaze, and saw that Zach had reached out, pushed his hand under Beth's skirt, and had smiled because his fingertips had discovered, in their exploration, that there was nothing between them and the neat landing strip of light-colored hair, the moist petals of her pussy, and whatever else he wanted to touch.

When Greg looked back up at him, Zach was grinning still, and looking right at Greg.

A wave of nausea rolled through his stomach.

They didn't have any time to react to this, or think about it, because at that moment, Zach seemed to lose interest, unbelievably, in continuing his journey up Beth's skirt. He withdrew his hand and flung it behind him, turning simultaneously toward the house. "All the booze everybody brought is in there, there's the bar. Make yourselves at home."

"Zach, I -" Beth began.

"Make yourselves at home," Zach repeated, looking at her with his icy, wolf-like stare, that was somehow as cold as tundra but simultaneously simmering. He then strode confidently out the porch door, toward the pool, reaching back behind his head to grab his shirt and pull it off as he did. Greg stared at the jaguar-like muscles rolling beneath the numerous tattoos on his back and felt another punch in the gut. He puffed up his cheeks and exhaled as Beth turned around to him, looking apologetic.

She opened her mouth, but Greg cut her off.

"Don't overthink it," he said.

He himself hadn't really thought it out before he said that, and he didn't really know what was going on at this party or what Zach wanted, other than to fuck his wife again, and there was a tangible sense of danger lurking everywhere. But it excited him, and he didn't want to abandon it, whatever the possibilities actually were.

"Just let it play out," he said. He tipped his forehead toward hers. "Remember? We're up for whatever happens. It's a hall pass." He reached for her arm, planning to take her inside. "Let's go get some drinks," he was saying.

But his voice was drowned out by another loud male voice. "Oh my fucking God. It *is* her. It *is* you. I told you guys, it's Liza fucking Brown."

A large guy, built like a refrigerator, the mid-thirties manifestation of a high school linebacker who now sold used cars, was hustling toward them from inside.

The guy stopped in the doorway and looked Beth up and down with a lascivious look that had none of the sophistication that Zach's did. "It is her," he continued to declare. "It *is* you."

"It's me," Beth said.

The conviviality ended there, frostily, as the two looked at each other. The guy grunted, "Well, hey," he said. "Can't tell you how good it is to see *you* here."

Almost as abruptly as he had come to the door, he turned around and stomped back in, telling anyone who would listen: "Guys, *Liza Brown* is here."

Another wave of excruciating discomfort washed over Greg as he saw the reaction to this news ripple through the party inside, which, he noticed at that moment, was overwhelmingly male. Faces moved to peer out from behind conversation partners who blocked their view. Watching their expressions, Greg detected something that unsettled him further: it was sexual hungriness, but it had the quality to it that men had when they knew they had locked something in.

He closed his eyes, blinking slowly, trying to clear it out of his mind. He was seeing things that weren't there, making fantasies and nightmares out of a very banal party.

But the worst and most discomfiting aspect of it was that he couldn't define to himself what was making him uncomfortable: was it the fact that maybe his most twisted fantasies were pure figments of his imagination, or was it that there was a real possibility of them happening... and that, if that was the case, that it excited him as much as he feared it?

He looked to Beth almost nervously, and she sort of shook her head, as if by way of explanation. Whatever had happened there wasn't important. She tried to grin, but it only darkened the scene more for Greg. "It's just some guy from high school," she said, shrugging. "Don't worry about it. Go with the flow, right?"

Greg wasn't sure if this last comment was a dig of some sort at him, and he found himself once again looking at the woman he had married and that he'd thought he knew so well, in a new light. There was something shimmering underneath the facade of Beth as he had known her. The thing that he had seen in the videos, the thing that was so alluring and terrifying to him when she met his eyes in the mirror and took off her underwear. It was, he sensed, the thing that caught Zach's gaze the way that it did. It was intoxicating, arousing, irresistible... a promise, in a way, of wet, sloppy, filthy acts that girls as pretty as Beth simply didn't do. But - and maybe because it was all those things, not only to him but apparently to all these

other men as well - it was also terrifying. Something about it was darker than he ever thought Beth could be.

He felt it as it rolled over him, like an unfathomably large wave: this was all very real, and he had seen its realness with his own eyes. He had tasted the bitter saltiness of Zach's cum in his wife's mouth, seen her stretched and polluted pussy. His wife had been a slut in a former life - and not just any slut, a performing, creative, submissive, dirty one.

And he had given her a green light to be that again.

And she was going to do it.

He stared as his wife shrugged, turned her back on Zach, who had cannonballed into the pool - naked, as Greg would later find out - and went into the house saying, "I'm going to have a drink."

CHAPTER 15

Beth had done a lot of sexually outrageous things when she was younger with Zach. There were the videos, which she couldn't really even say why she had made. It had been reckless and stupid, like so many other things people did when they were young, but she *had* had the presence of mind to destroy the tapes.

It was the country, though, and back then there hadn't been much to do. The internet (thankfully) was still a disjointed place for nerds and a few *avant-gard* boomers who had AOL mail.

What that meant in a town like Walla Beach, circa 2000-2002, was that there were a lot of house parties, most of which became, after a certain point in the evening, wild, and sometimes weird.

But that was then, and this was now, and no one was in their twenties at this party, and the internet existed. So when she saw signs of the laid-back, boringly adult party turning into a different kind of beast, she ignored them at first.

There were a few people there who knew her, and she suspected, by the looks they gave her, that they at a minimum had heard the rumors about her, and possibly were guys she had slept with. She didn't remember them in any kind of specific way: nearly everything that she had done with all of those guys, multiple partners, for the videos - it had all been because of Zach, directed and controlled by him.

She knew she should feel *something* when she saw these guys: guilt, remorse, embarrassment. But the truth was that she didn't. She had whittled away everything superfluous in this adventure, to the one thing that actually mattered: getting the copies of the tapes back, so that her past could really be buried. Her sentiments had been buried a long time ago.

She went into the kitchen and examined her drink options. Like at any grown-up house party, people had mostly brought bottles of cheap wine, and none of them looked particularly appealing.

"There's a bar," a guy walking into the kitchen told her.

He was not someone she had ever seen before, she was sure of it. And he didn't seem to recognize her, even though Dan Thede had loudly announced her arrival to everyone he bumped into.

Beth looked over at him and he smiled back at her, and something in his smile gave her the first inkling that the party was different than a plain old house party. It wasn't so much that he was being openly flirtatious: Beth got that all the time. It was something else. There was no caution in it. Not his smile, or the way he swung himself around the corner of the island, still smiling self-assuredly, and cozied up to her. "I go for mixed drinks," he told her, and this, too, seemed a little off.

Then he leaned on the counter, looked her up and down - no pretense whatsoever - and smiled again. And then, to her astonishment, he lifted his hand, the back of it to her arm, and stroked her bicep. "I also have MDMA," he told her.

He didn't continue to stroke her, and the interaction was strange enough - too forward for a guy like him - that Beth dismissed this as a guy who had a weird personality, and had probably ingested his own supply. Drugs had always been another thing in good supply in Walla Beach. Again, because of the boredom. She was surprised that they were here at this party, but then, old habits die hard.

"I'm Rick," he said, plowing ahead. He was waiting for her answer, like he expected it, like he went up to women and talked to them like this all the time.

She hesitated, only because she hadn't given the actual logistics of a house party much thought before coming there. Sure, Zach had *said* it was a party, and had tried to get her to come to one the week before, but she hadn't honestly expected this many people, this big of a party. Or to meet someone she didn't know already. And so, she hadn't thought of how she would introduce herself.

But he was waiting, and the pressure was building.

She thought of Greg's hall pass, and before she could get too much thinking in, she was already talking. "Liza," she said.

"Hope to see you later, Liza," Rick told her, and touched her arm again. "Come to me if you need anything."

So that was a little weird, but Beth dismissed it. And a few other signs that blipped only momentarily on her radar: a couple making out intensely on a couch in Zach's enormous living room, with like ten people still in there with them, and one couple watching them distractedly. Another guy she vaguely recognized popped out of a cluster of people to smile at her. "I can't believe you're actually here," he said. And then she thought him

say something like "legendary," but this, too, evaporated without her thinking about it much.

Perhaps because she had been expecting something more intimate - maybe even wanting it - she was trying so hard to reorient herself to her first impressions (a regular old house party) that she ignored the things she saw.

Greg was at the bar, looking mildly uncomfortable - Beth could tell because he was backing away from the woman he was talking to, hinging, as he did, a little at the waist, which she was sure he had no idea was a habit of his when overly flirtatious women moved in on him. She slowed her pace, pausing with her wine to look out the window into the pool - where there were a lot of people splashing around all of the sudden, and in the hot tub, in spite of the weather, and the... Beth squinted, a chilling sense of realization creeping to the front of her head -

"Liza Brown. Ha!" a voice said, behind her, at the same time as an insistent finger jabbed into the soft hollow of her shoulder blade.

Anna.

Beth gritted her teeth and turned toward Anna, smiling fakely and pleasantly. "Anna," she said, with subdued and forced cheer.

The images from the pool had flown from her mind, and the sight of Anna - older, but in no significant way changed - gave her a strange rush of adrenaline. There was no real reason why: Anna wasn't a mortal enemy, or even that bad of a person. She was just nuts and unpredictable, and Beth had always sensed a kind of petty danger lurking around inside of her. Anna was likely to freak out on you in much the same way as cats sometimes did: purring peacefully one moment while you pet them, and then digging razor-sharp claws through your clothing, leaving a minor scratch and confusion behind as she hissed and ran away.

"I'm still here," Anna said, as if Beth had lobbed an insult at her. Anna's eyes went up and down Beth's dress. "I got that same dress," she said icily, and then lifted a cigarette to her lips. "Good thing I didn't wear it tonight."

She cackled, and then the cackle faded away as she turned her eyes upward in a cartoonish imitation of having a thought. "Although..." she said, mysteriously.

And then she looked back at Beth. "Girl, you look *good*." Her voice was suddenly cheerful, seemingly authentically so. Classic Anna. So, some

things never changed.

"Thanks, Anna," she said. "You too."

Anna snorted at this, and Beth caught a whiff of a changing mood, so she changed the subject, hoping that the tried-and-true method of shifting the winds on Anna still worked to prevent her from starting some kind of screaming match. "So, what's the deal with this place?" she said, dropping into the Southern, beachy, girlish drawl that had once been her way of communicating.

By "this place," she had intended "Zach's house," and she had a follow-up question, but Anna had lifted her cigarette to her lips and was sucking on it, one eye half-closed to keep out the smoke. She was squinting, a sign that she was thinking, and not usually a great one. Anna really unnerved Beth, with her mood shifts and feverish temper, always at a boil. Back then, she had seemed capable of almost anything, and she didn't seem to have changed much in the past decade or so.

"Right?" Anna said, veering into a mood Beth hadn't seen coming. Anna swung her head toward the pool, and swayed a little, cluing Beth in to the level of her intoxication. "He actually puts, like, an ad out on some website or something." Anna turned toward Beth, her eyes twinkling with either menace or mischief, and said in a loud, hoarse whisper: "There are people from *Carroll County* here." Then she shrieked again. "Maryland!"

Beth had no idea what any of that meant, but she couldn't stop herself from casting her eyes around as quickly as she could, as if she could glean some sense of what Anna was saying by doing so. Her gaze dragged a little as she surveyed the pool, and so when she looked back at Anna, the image was just processing, just as the *drip-drip-drip* of realization was coalescing into a thought.

Anna leaned toward her, swaying a little again. She was stacked on heels so high that she towered - ridiculously - over Beth, and a quick look at the floor confirmed that her shoes were, in fact, the kind sold to strippers at a store in White Beach that catered to them and drag queens. They were clear plastic with flecks of glitter in them.

Same old Anna.

When she breathed into Beth's ear, Beth caught an intense whiff of alcohol. "Everyone is like, flipped the fuck out that you're here." She smiled and leaned back. Her smile was saccharine, and Beth saw something dangerous in it. "But hey, that's okay. I had my day in the sun. And now

you're here. All I ask, is that you leave me *this* guy..." Anna grabbed Beth by the shoulders and spun her toward the pool, jabbing her right hand and her cigarette toward the pool. A long chain of ash crumbled and fell to the floor, which seemed obscene in this fancy porch where no one else was smoking.

Anna's lips were on her ear next, vaguely erotic but mostly frightening. "The guy with the pit bull tats. He's from, like, Charleston or something." Anna spun her back around by digging her fingers into Beth's shoulder blade again.

Her face looked almost demonic, but the expression melted away comically. She lifted her hands and spaced them about a foot apart, pointer fingers toward the ceiling.

His dick is this big, she mouthed, smiling widely at the end, tucking her left hand into her armpit to tug on the black tube-top she had plastered to her torso.

"I know that'll be hard for you," Anna said coldly, her mood suddenly changed again. Her face was serious, and her eyes searched Beth's.

There was something obsessed in her look, like she knew specifically what she was digging for inside of Beth. When she - seemingly - didn't find it, and Beth stared at her, mouth slightly agape, Anna smiled again. "But you have Zach, after all. And this *whooooooooo!!!!llllleeee* party." Anna lifted her arm and waved around the porch.

And then, as so happened with drunks like Anna, the slate of her mind seemed to wipe itself clean, and she blinked, looking confused. "Everybody is *so glad* you're here," she repeated. And then she stared at Beth, as if there was something Beth was supposed to say.

But her eyes moved past Beth, over her shoulder, to the bar. "Hey, it's him," she yelled. "Hey you! Guy from the bar!" Anna's eyes shifted back to Beth. "Your *hubby*. What's his name?"

Beth hesitated, knocked off her feet, still trying to process what was happening. You had to really untangle Anna's thoughts when she was drunk, but if you went through the effort, it all usually made some kind of sense in the end. And Beth was already having a bad feeling about it somehow.

But Anna's mood, ever quicksilver, had already changed. She gripped Beth's arm ferociously and put her face very close to hers, smiling in what seemed like genuine excitement. "I didn't think he was the type, you

know, to come along. I told Zach." She lifted her chin and yelled at a passerby. "I *told* Zach!"

Beth put her arm out to touch Anna gently and ask her what it was that she had told Zach, to try and pry into the jumble of hangers that was Anna's mind, but a male voice piped up from near the door to the house: "Come over here and tell me what you told him, darlin."

And Anna, smiling, her eyes set suddenly on new prey, slinked away.

Beth turned to Greg, who, along with his companion at the bar, had frozen in place for the whole conversation.

Beth pointed with the hand holding the wine glass. "Anna," she said, no particular meaning implied.

The woman who had been talking to Greg, and making him back up, brightened and then bit into her lower lip, looking Beth up and down, before shifting her gaze back to Greg - without letting go of her lip. "So you're her," she said, looking at Greg but evidently speaking to Beth. She gave her head of chestnut hair a shake as she put her hand on Greg's chest and started to walk her fingers up.

It was then that the pool image resurfaced, and Beth's mouth dropped open a little further, as the woman walked her fingers up Greg's chest to his mouth, where she placed one pad on his lower lip and pulled it slightly open.

Greg was standing stiff as a board, probably dumbstruck.

But Beth knew by then, and she needed to do something. She wanted to look back out at the pool, and confirm what she thought was true, but she didn't want to leave Greg alone with this woman, because she could see he had no idea what was going on. So she froze, while the woman's hands drew back down Greg's chest, and her knees bent slightly, and she started to lower herself to the floor...

"*Honey*," Beth hissed, which elicited a sharp look from the woman, who also stopped getting to her knees. Beth reached for his arm and turned to the woman apologetically. "I'm sorry, he... he's not quite... he isn't..."

The woman, who had been getting a bit ruffled, became instantly *not*. "Oh, shoot, okay. Gotcha." Then she picked up her drink and looked set to take off. "It's early, and so, no problem, and I don't know how they do things here, but I think you're supposed to wear a white shirt if you're, you know, just watching." She looked over at Beth, and her eyes lit up with

interest. "*You're* not, though." She stepped close to Beth as she spun away sexily. "I like to get some guys in first but come look for me later."

With a wistful glance back at Greg, who was visibly pale, she trotted away.

Beth rushed over to the bar.

"What the fuck is going on h-" Greg began, more confused than anything.

"This is a... you know, like a sex party," Beth hissed, setting her drink on the bar. She put her hand to her head. "I can't believe I didn't -"

"What do you mean, 'sex party?'" Greg said, looking past her to the windows to the pool.

Beth waved her hand behind her in that general direction. "I should have *known*," she said, as Greg's eyes went wide. Then she looked over at him, shaking her head. "Let's get out of here," she suggested, assuming Greg wouldn't want to be anywhere near all of this, more because of the possibilities of damage to his reputation than anything.

"What?" Greg said, still staring out at the pool. He seemed amazed.

"Let's go," Beth said, putting her hand on his arm. "We'll figure out another time to do this."

Greg was frozen in place, staring out the window.

Beth turned to see what he was staring at, and saw the pool first, where a man was pounding himself into an attractive blond woman, whose bare tits were bouncing with each thrust. He had her by the hair, with her face turned toward the patio, mouth open in sexual ecstasy.

But Beth's gaze fell next to the couch facing the windows, where a man sat with his arms slung over the back of it, a sleek head of brown hair bobbing in his lap while he watched the show.

"You can't stay here," Beth said, the enthusiasm waning from her voice. Her eyes had found Zach in the pool, his arms draped over the wall that separated the hot tub from it. Dusk had fallen, and the lights were on, but she could still see the blue of his eyes, and it was pointed right at her. The water shimmered and shifted over the part of his body still immersed in the pool: his hips, the erect and enormous cock between his legs, the blackish gray tattoo that crept from his torso into his inner thigh, like a trail to his cock. He was looking right at her.

Her resolve was weakening, but she could still access the thinking part of her mind: Greg should not be here.

"She said there are no phones," Greg said, and Beth whipped her head to look at him. "It's a rule, she made me give mine to the bartender. I didn't understand what the hell she was talking about." Greg was talking like an accident victim, in a strange, monotone voice. "I thought it was like, some way to get the party going."

Beth looked behind the bar, where there was no bartender. Her eyes went immediately to a set of slats with numbers on them, slender phones resting in each one.

"What?" she said.

Greg was looking at Zach. He shifted his gaze to Beth after she stared at him for a while. She had time to register that he had an intense erection before looking up to his face. "Did you tell anybody my name?"

She shook her head, but more out of confusion than anything else.

Greg shrugged, and she realized what he meant by that question.

"*Zach* knows your name," she said, but she wasn't being very resistant. She was saying what she had to say, doing the right thing, trying to get Greg out of there, but she was doing so with less desire than she could have. She was keenly aware of Zach's stare from the other end of the pool, feeling it like the sun on her face. Her cheeks were flushed, and her pussy throbbed with the ache that only Zach, only a situation like this, could give to her.

Greg was different, too. He seemed, unnervingly, in control of himself. So *sure* of something. "Zach isn't going to ever want to say, or hear, my name, after this," he said.

Beth blinked and pulled her head back, surprised. "Oh," she said. "Oh, okay. *What?*"

Greg looked over at her, and then reached out his hand and pulled her by the hem of her dress, toward him, which was strange by itself, and surprised her so much that he had his finger between the sodden petals of her pussy before she even realized what he was doing.

His eyes flickered with something - knowledge, agreement, lust? Who could say - when he discovered the truth that she could not hide: her pussy was wet, throbbing, swollen with excitement. "We said hall pass," he told her, pulling her toward him by slipping two fingers inside of her and curling them to pull her closer. He stroked the root of her clit as he did this, and her arm twitched as she tried to repress the pleasurable shudder it gave her.

This was madness.

Not a good idea at all. There were reputations... and careers... and things might never...

"All the same rules," he said, his lips very close to hers. His eyes were burning into hers, and her own almost stung with overwhelming, nameless emotion that had no other exit but to form water and threaten to turn to tears. "Just, you know. Keep my name out of the papers."

"This is a terrible idea," she whispered, her lips quivering, like her pussy.

Greg curled his fingers again. "Yes," he said. "Probably. But we're here..."

He held her eyes locked on to his, though they wandered a little - to his lips, back to his eyes, as he finger-fucked her, standing up, right there in the middle of the room. She cast a furtive glance around only once and saw that only one person was looking right at them.

And then she remembered Zach, outside, arms slung over the pool, and the fact that he was watching her, and Greg, and maybe could even see what was going on.

She said nothing, just gave in to the scandalous sensation of her husband fingering her in public, in front of Zach, like this - semi-private, semi-exhibitionist.

Her eyes fell closed as an orgasm overtook her, quickly. But she opened them in time to see Greg's: looking over her shoulder, out to the pool.

At Zach.

Her body shook and she bit into Greg's shoulder as her orgasm screamed into a new and different category.

She pushed away from him to look at his face when it was over, her hand down to his cock, which throbbed against her out-turned palm. "This could get wild," she cautioned, in a whisper still warped by the rippling echoes of her orgasm.

Greg caught her hand with his as he pulled out of her pussy, taking it away from his dick.

He put his finger in his mouth and licked her pussy juices from it.

"I'm in."

CHAPTER 16

It was all a very bad idea, and Greg knew that, somewhere in the back of his mind. He wasn't the kind of guy who made particularly rash decisions, especially not about sex: not an adrenaline junkie, not a raging alpha male or a serial womanizer. He had made his fair share of bad decisions as a teenager and a young adult, but his frontal cortex had eventually connected to the rest of his brain and he had managed to find and marry a very hot woman whom he loved. The really bad decisions were mostly a thing of the past.

There was no shortage of scandals in his line of work, and most of them were sexual in some way or another. Every time the news broke about one of them, Greg would scratch his head and wonder how some of these guys could be so *stupid*.

He could almost hear his replacement saying it to himself, in what was formerly his office: How could Greg Quinn have possibly been so fucking stupid as to go to a sex party in Bofuck Nowhere? With his wife? And not - and this is the kicker - even get some tail?

Or any tail, Greg amended, because he was going to do this very stupid thing, and the only reason he was doing it - at least at that moment - was because he simply couldn't stop himself. When Beth turned around and started walking toward the door to the pool area, slinking along sexily, the focus of his entire life and universe narrowed down to this one, obsessive thing: his wife, who was about to fulfill his fantasies. That was, very suddenly and very completely, *all* he could think about.

She turned at the doorway to look at him, and as her body and head rotated, he had a brief moment of doubt, a flicker of relief: she was going to look back to give him one last out, one last chance to stop this very stupid thing from taking place. And he thought to himself that he should take it. This was madness, a very enormous risk for... what? He could play his intended bluff on Zach at any moment, allowing him to circumvent this entire, sexual scene, and make sure nothing happened here in the heat of the moment that could upend his career and all of his ambitions.

He was ripe for being talked out of it in that slow-moving moment before Beth was fully turned toward him.

But Beth, when she looked back, no longer looked like *his* Beth Quinn. Oh sure, she had her silky chestnut hair and her big, stunning, green eyes. The same features and coltish legs. But she did not *look* the same as she smiled at him, her eyes glinting with a raw, and foreign, sexual energy.

She was, he could see, no longer Beth Quinn; now, she was definitely Liza Brown. And Liza Brown did not do final checks, or think about consequences, or give anyone an “out.” Liza Brown did what Beth did at that moment: she smiled devilishly, burned the air with her simmering eyes, poured molten heat into his dick from afar, and then shifted her gaze to her real prey: the naked, the well-hung, the hypnotizing Zach Pinker.

All around him, the party had begun to get more "sexy" than "party:" blowjobs were being given, people were pairing up and taking off their clothes. He himself could truly see none of this; he saw only Beth. And really, only Beth's legs - because they seemed to have grown even longer, be even smoother, and they were so appealing dangling from that skimpy dress that he really couldn't focus on anything else - as she stalked out of the porch and down the steps.

Zach's eyes, which were piercing blue but also contrasted deeply with his dark hair, followed her the way big cats follow prey. Nothing could have taken his stare away from Beth's body as she walked to the edge of the pool.

She stood there for a moment, exchanging god-knows-what look with Zach, before lifting her arms to her shoulders, hooking her fingers under the straps of her dress, and slowly peeling it away from her body.

People in the pool stopped what they were doing to stare, and Greg was vaguely aware of a commotion on the porch. Beth peeled the dress away slowly, inch after inch of her smooth, creamy back, and the enticing, lithe, musculature of it that was oddly sexy, even if backs weren't a feature that Greg, or anyone he knew, thought of as particularly sexual. The dress continued to roll down, and Beth's small, rounded buttocks peeked out, her legs obscured momentarily by the dress as it fell to her feet.

She shook out her hair, which shimmered and swayed enticingly at her shoulder line. It was a spectacular view from the back, and she held several men in complete thrall even though they were decidedly engaged with someone else already. Greg heard a fratty, "Oh, hell yeah!" from

somewhere, and did not need to look for himself to confirm that it was someone, somewhere, watching his wife undress.

His wife.

She stepped slowly into the pool, the shimmering aqua color snatching away her long legs inch by inch, until all that remained above water was her sculpted back and her swaying curtain of sleek brown hair.

She walked through the shallow water toward Zach, from whom the performance had elicited a smug smile.

“Smug” didn’t exactly do it justice as a descriptor. The expression on Zach’s face was layered with the kind of confidence that Greg knew he himself would never have, and didn’t necessarily want, but which nonetheless fascinated him. Zach was watching Beth with the confidence of a man who knew that a woman like Beth would do *anything* sexual for him that he asked of her.

Greg’s eyes drifted back to his wife, pondering what, exactly, Beth might be feeling in this moment. Because it was all fine and good to have laid down rules and promises about what you would do in this situation, and he *believed* in Beth. But it was a completely different ball of wax when it went from theoretical pillow talk, or even something that occurred in the past, to a real-time thing that was happening before his very eyes.

He was so mesmerized by this dance of hot, feral courtship between Zach and Beth that he just stood there and stared, until Beth was within inches of Zach’s body, blocking the view of what was happening between them.

It was then that Greg looked down at his hand and saw that he had somehow picked up a beer, which he abandoned for Beth’s wine, for reasons he didn’t spend too much time thinking about. He surveyed the increasingly steamy room, wondering what to do only briefly, before he concluded that absolutely no one was looking at him or wondering what *he* was doing. It was an oddly public kind of voyeurism, and he felt strangely at ease with it, almost as if he weren’t actually there.

So he walked outside to the pool area and headed for a deck chair at the far end, where he supposed he would have a good view of whatever was about to take place.

“You coming in?” a woman in the hot tub called to him, when he reached the far end of the deck. Greg tore his eyes away from Zach and Beth briefly, to see a moderately attractive blond woman and a tangle of

naked flesh winding around her like serpents – most of it muscled, male. Greg shook his head dismissively and took his gaze back to his wife and Zach.

The moving water distorted what they were doing beneath it, but Zach's tanned and much larger limbs were now tangled up with Beth's, and moving, and Beth's featured were now blank, looking only inward, at some personal pleasure that she did not need the outside world for. Zach was staring at her face, his lips moving, his words causing tiny twitches throughout Beth's body. Or maybe it was his hand, which Zach could now discern was between her legs, brutishly thrusting. He wondered how many fingers Zach had inside Beth, if the orgasm that he himself had given her had made her pussy wet enough to outlast her brief trip across the pool, so that Zach would at least be aware that someone had gotten there before him.

If he had said those words aloud, the timing could not have been more perfect; suddenly, as though Zach and Beth were reading his thoughts, feeling his desires, Zach leaned in to whisper something in Beth's ear that made her turn her head slightly in Greg's direction, lower her chin and smile, and then lift her eyes to meet his, the wicked, wicked smile of Liza Brown on her lips.

A violent jolt traveled through Greg, and his stiff cock throbbed mercilessly, painfully. Beth's lips looked darker out here in the pool, her eyes were sharp and yet somehow distant. Her face looked like a very slightly altered version of Beth, but what lay behind her gaze was something Greg had never seen in her eyes before.

She bobbed in the water, up and then down, wrapping her legs around Zach, and they moved over to the edge of the pool, just feet away from Greg's chair. Then Beth turned, still wearing her sex-infused smile, and rested her arms on the pool's edge, jutting out her ass, propped on her elbows so that her biceps squeezed her breasts together into two plump spheres of creamy flesh, her nipples swinging freely below them.

Zach positioned himself behind her, and Beth lifted her eyes to look right at Greg. He saw them widen as her mouth opened as, behind her, Zach was sinking into her. Greg guessed, from Beth's mild preliminary reaction, that Zach's thick cock was in her pussy, stretching her out, filling her up.

Right there, in front of his eyes.

Zach gathered Beth's hair in his fist and pulled on it, tipping her head back. Beth's eyes remained on Greg's, but they weren't really seeing

him. When Zach began to fuck her, it was with only a few slow strokes that made Beth's eyes flutter almost closed, and her mouth open slightly to emit a high-pitched mewl. Greg looked from her face to Zach's, and weathered the hard, cold shock that it gave him to see Zach staring directly at him, the smug smile twitching beneath his beard.

He pulled a little harder on Beth's hair, and began to fuck her harder, thrusting deep and rapidly, the water around them rolling into higher and higher waves, splashing over the side. Wet slaps cut through Zach's low grunts and Beth's gasping moans. Her nipples swung wildly now, hard caramel candies that grazed the stone patio with every thrust.

"Ah, ah, ah!" Beth began to scream. "Oh, oh God!" Her face contorted, her eyes squeezed shut, and she emitted a shrill sound that cut off as though someone had flipped a switch at the peak of her orgasm. Her mouth wide open, she tipped her head forward, and Zach let her, but still held her hair in his hand and continued to pound into her.

Zach's cold blue eyes were fixed on Greg, but Greg was staring at his wife, wondering if maybe Zach was too much for her, if maybe he was hurting her. When he dared to look at Zach, to get some kind of read on him, Zach's eyes had dropped to Beth's body, and he let go of her hair and put his arms on her hips, looking down to see his cock sawing in and out of her.

He came with a loud grunt, driving deep into her and making Beth squeal. Her fingers clawed at the stone and she leaned over until her chest was against it. Three violent thrusts and Zach had emptied his load, in violent spurts that made him groan, into her cunt.

Zach slapped Beth's ass, the sort of gesture that was so smooth and natural that Greg could see he had done at least dozens of times before. Maybe last week. Maybe he would do it again.

With a smug grin, looking at Greg, Zach reached forward and caught Beth's slumped body by the throat, his callous-covered and thick fingers positioned on Beth's delicate jaw and around her slender throat. He pulled her roughly back, so that she was leaning against his back, pressed to him by his pressureless chokehold.

Again, his lips moved, close to Beth's ear. His eyes stayed on Greg's, and Beth's lips, tempted by whatever Zach was whispering into her ear, formed first a smile, and then a soundless, "Okay."

And then Zach stepped back, presumably with his cock slipping out of Beth. He was grinning now. For a moment it seemed like he would keep backing up, wander away, and leave Beth there with Greg. Disappointment and relief started to scratch at Greg for the briefest of seconds: he indulged in the imagery of him helping Beth out of the pool, of them collecting her dress, and going home, with no further abuse of her body. It wasn't what he wanted, and yet it was. A heartsick, sex-steeped pang ballooned in his chest.

And then Beth smiled at him, a hint of apology somewhere in the microscopic movements of her features. Her arm drifted behind her, and Greg realized, as she turned, that Zach held her hand and was pulling her away from him, taking possession of her.

He watched, frozen, until they were halfway down the length of the pool, hand in hand, through the coupled and multi-partnered people in the water, who were fewer than when they had come out.

Greg didn't know what to do, and the absurdity of his situation struck him suddenly, almost making him laugh: this was one party that he was wholly incapable of navigating, one set of social rules that he not only had *not* mastered, but which he knew nothing about.

Beth and Zach reached the end of the pool and began to emerge, water rolling down their sculpted bodies: Beth's legs, as long as Zach's, looked like the legs of a colt, and his, each like the trunk of a tree.

The beer in his hand had tipped slowly as he forgot about it, and now beer poured freely onto the stone patio.

Not knowing what else to do, his cock painfully hard, he rose up and walked, unsteady with heart-palpitating fear and the intoxicating high of having watched his wife take a pounding from Zach while looking right at him.

All he knew was that he wanted more.

Zach wanted more, and so did Greg.

And Beth? Well, she was walking freely of her own accord, toward whatever else Zach had planned for her.

*

He was slowed by a couple who bumped into him as they made their way into the house from the porch, mouths locked together, the man's cock

freed from his pants and held firmly by the woman. They released each other in a loud, wet smack and looked at him.

“Want in?” she offered, with genuine hospitality.

“I’m... just watching,” Greg managed to say, his throat dry. He could see Beth’s naked body entering the kitchen, where decidedly more flesh was on display than just half an hour before, and it was all he could think about.

The couple paid him no mind, locked up again, and started to stumble into the house.

He followed at a safe distance, noting that the air had the faint aroma of tangy, sweet pussy juice that had not been there before. Everywhere he looked – very briefly, furtively – people were hooking up, with the exception of a trio wedged in the corner of the kitchen, who seemed to have been derailed by an intense discussion.

His eyes flew back to Beth, who was now accepting a drink from a clothed man who was devouring her with his eyes. The fluttery, receptive smile that Beth gave him stabbed Greg in the heart, a searing and yet erotic pain spreading throughout his body. Who *was* this woman, standing naked with a glass of wine in her hand, drawing a strange man into her gaze, close to her naked flesh, and with a smile so out of character?

Beth turned her head toward Zach, as though to better hear him. Zach was standing behind her with a marker cap between his teeth. Greg’s heart plummeted as he saw a look of worry permeate the veneer of Beth’s happily slutty smile, just before she looked up and around, seeking Greg. When she met his eyes, she looked afraid, and momentarily again Greg entertained the idea of grabbing her hand and running away from this wild party.

But he was too slow, or perhaps Beth’s worry was just a figment of his imagination, because she was smiling the next instant, no longer looking at him, and bending over the counter, much like she had at the pool.

It took Greg a moment to understand what was happening next, because he could not merge the images he was seeing with his expectations, and what was happening was so unexpectedly obscene that he couldn’t process it.

Zach held something in his hand: slender, phallic in shape, but small... mostly gray, black at the tip. Greg looked at the item between Zach’s teeth, then at his hands, at the implement in them, moving in sharp,

bold strokes. The motion was recognizable, a thing people did every day, but Greg drew an utter blank for so long, staring at his wife, who was laughing and looking behind her at what Zach was doing.

It was only when Zach inserted the marker – a black Sharpie – into the cap between his teeth that Greg keyed in on what he was seeing, a slow-moving wave of intense nausea rolling through him, his groin aching painfully, his cock inexplicably pulsing.

Beth pushed herself up from the counter and smiled at Zach, who slapped a big hand on her ass and squeezed it, his intense, slightly thuggish eyes singeing the air between them. As Beth turned, casting a fluttery eye bat at the man who had been – Greg supposed – hitting on her, Greg was treated to a brief glimpse through the moving bodies between them at what Zach had done.

He couldn't read it, but he could have easily guessed at the message, scrawled in an unexpectedly intelligent-looking script, with an arrow drawn in the center of her ass, pointing down at the valley between her cheeks.

Beth was walking out of the room, into the now-dimly lit, large living room.

“Liza Brown will be upstairs, ladies and gentlemen, entertaining all callers!” Zach yelled cheerfully, as they passed through the living room. The announcement immediately rippled through the room, drawing sharp, attentive looks from a handful of people instantly, and then, like a rumor too good to be true, buzzing through the room and getting passed along in excited whispers, even among guys who had a handful of hair in their hands and a bobbing head in their lap.

Flashes of the videos he had watched whirled across his field of vision, and Greg felt temporarily displaced. The sound around him seemed to diminish, turning into a muffled blur, and he experimented with the idea that he was in a dream – or a nightmare – and would wake up any moment.

But the distortion passed, and the inescapable fact that this was reality, that his wife was Liza Brown, taking all callers, upstairs, and that this statement meant exactly what he thought it meant, hit him hard in the face like a wall of ice-cold water.

He was unable to move for a few moments.

But then, unsure of which emotions were shredding him from the inside out, he moved toward the living room, turned robotically and walked up the stairs. His feet felt leaden, another sign that this was real. An

attractive brunette, squeezed onto one of the wide steps, paused a blowjob, her partner's dick in her hand, to smile at him, before returning her attention back to his cock.

People had dispersed throughout the upstairs, which was dominated by a surprisingly large open space that looked like yet another living room, with a few doors off it. A group of men were standing around, clothed, sipping drinks, in a circle, watching something that was going on in the middle of it.

Greg couldn't see Beth, but perhaps because he knew she was up here, and would be for some time, he ventured closer to the circle to see what was going on. He got as far as a glimpse of two people, the woman on her hands and knees, the man kneeling on the floor, before his interest returned to his wife.

Because that was all that mattered; that was all he wanted to see.

He passed an open doorway, where a single threesome was just getting started, clothing still being removed. He felt his head spin from sensory overload: he hadn't really believed that this kind of party existed, and there was still a large part of his mind that thought this was unreal.

He saw Zach first, standing in a large bedroom, cock erect in front of his legs, his hands placed casually behind his head. He was looking at the bed, his smug smile there beneath the tangle of his beard. Long after he must have seen Greg enter the room, and stand in the doorway, Zach turned his head toward Greg, eyes still on the bed, without looking at him.

"Man, get out of the doorway," he said.

On the bed was the man from downstairs, an average-looking guy with an average-looking cock, his dress shirt ripped open, Beth straddling him and pulling his belt out of the belt loops. She set it down on the bed next to her, almost like it was something she would save for later, and then unzipped his pants and started to scoot backward, pulling them and the man's underwear with her as she moved.

Greg was edging slowly along the wall of built-in bookshelves toward a chair that he had decided to sit in before he collapsed. He had acquired a drink though he didn't remember doing so, and he reached out to set it on a bookshelf just as Beth turned her attention from the man she was undressing – to Zach.

She whipped her head to smile at Zach, turning in the direction of Greg, but perhaps not even seeing her husband at all. She didn't meet his

eyes, as he desperately wanted her to; it was almost as though he wasn't there. His heart plunged, and the grip of pain started to squeeze inside of him.

There was something about Beth ignoring him that he didn't want, and yet he also craved. The result was a dizzying deregulation of his emotions.

Beth scooted back, her ass upturned toward Zach, who had his pupils glued unapologetically on her asshole, beneath the marker scrawling on her ass, tight and puckered and shiny with cum that had leaked out between her legs. Greg followed Zach's gaze, saw the dark markings, and looked away quickly.

This hole belongs to Zach Pinker, the words read, in a surprisingly cogent script.

Beth was now straddling the man's knees, her hair hanging over her shoulder so that Greg could see her face. She dropped her hand to the guy's cock and wrapped her fingers around it, prompting him to lift his head to watch.

Beth lowered her mouth until it hovered just over his crown, where a drop of precum was erupting slowly from the tip. Greg felt like he had been punched in the gut when Beth pursed her lips, as though she was about to whistle, and blew gently over the bulbous head gripped in her hand.

This was *not his wife*.

She had never, ever, done anything like that to him.

Or any of these other things.

But he had no time to linger on the whys or whats of that thought, because Beth's tongue was emerging from her mouth, the tip pointed and strong. She flicked her tongue at the bead of cum, once, and then twice. The guy gasped audibly and dropped his head briefly to the bed before looking up again.

"Man, in all my life," Zach said, distractedly, and seemingly not to anyone in particular, "I have *never* had my cock sucked by anyone as good as this little girl."

He was still standing with his fingers interlocked at the base of his skull, but after saying this, he dropped one hand to his cock and held it, stroking it distractedly.

Greg's eyes were moving from Zach to his wife, from Beth's tongue that was now making circles around the circumference of his crown, darting

along the ridge, swirling in circles that became more wet, and more sloppy, with each pass.

“Fuck, you gonna suck it or what?” he breathed, exasperated, lifting a hand toward Beth’s head.

“Man, just wait for her to do her thing,” Zach said, his voice neutral. “You won’t regret it.” Zach looked over at Greg, who lifted his eyes only briefly. “You can vouch for that, right man?”

Greg’s stomach went cold, Zach was already snorting derisively. “Maybe not,” he chided.

Beth smiled, her tongue still twisting in wet contortions around the tip of the guy’s cock. She was looking right at him, teasing him with her eyes. Greg scanned her every moment for some telltale sign of the coercion they were supposedly under, for some hesitancy, but he saw none.

Beth turned her head to the side as she bent over and wrapped her tongue around his shaft, the grotesque underbelly of it veined and sticky-wet. Greg sucked in his breath, and stared at her, licking, sucking, pressing her lips together with another man’s dick between them.

Her eyes were closed at first. When, suddenly, she opened them, and they met Greg’s, he was so stunned and simultaneously aroused that his whole body jolted in the chair. Beth’s eyelids closed again, and she dragged her tongue along the underside of his cock on her way back up to the tip. She paused only a moment, her eyes on the desperate man, long enough to make him look even more desperate, before she grinned, shifted herself a little bit back, and then leaned over to take him into her mouth.

The man’s head fell backward as he exhaled, a shuddering staccato of breath that indicated that he had lost control of himself as Beth’s mouth swallowed more and more of his cock.

He wasn’t any bigger than Greg, but Greg stared as every last inch of his dick disappeared into his wife’s mouth – again, not something that Beth did with him. He had never felt her lips close around the base of his cock, never seen her nostrils flare as she struggled to suck his whole cock and breathe.

“Oh, fuck... oh fuck,” the guy said.

Zach was watching with his head tipped slightly to the side, his hand no longer moving on his own shaft.

“I told you,” he said stoically, almost so long after the guy groaned that it didn’t make much sense. Beth’s slurping, wet blowjob pierced the air

in the interim.

Several more guys had entered the room, and Greg just then took notice of them. But they were peripheral actors, seen only in the corner of his eye, because the universe had whittled down to a tunnel that only allowed him to see Beth's lips, curling outward slightly as she dragged her mouth up the man's cock, and then rolling back into her mouth as she went down.

Zach moved without warning, stepping toward the bed and dropping his hand to slap Beth playfully on the ass. "Get that hand back here baby, give these guys a show. Play with your ass."

The way he talked to her! Greg was stunned, even if he had heard this same voice on the videos, even if he had known to expect this... he would never dare command Beth around like that, because *his* Beth, his wife, would at best laugh at him, and at worst, slap him and leave the room.

Or so he had believed.

But this Beth – or better stated, Liza – did not break character for a moment. Still sucking on the man's cock, she reached her right hand behind her, sliding it between her buttocks, and her fingers curled and stroked the wet slick of her pussy and taint. Greg couldn't see what she was doing exactly, but he supposed it was exactly what Zach had ordered her to do. Her hand moved up, her wrist bending as her fingers pumped where her butt hole would be, if he could have seen it.

"Oh fuck," the guy said, his abdomen straining as he lifted his head to look at Beth. "I'm gonna come."

Zach smiled and placed a finger on the tip of his own cock, then looked at it. "Just do it man, she likes surprises." He reached his finger out toward Beth and swirled around her ass, pushing her hand out of the way with a dismissive shove of his wrist.

"Ahhh!" the guy groaned, and as soon as he did, Zach's left hand shot out and went to the back of Beth's head, pushing her down to the base of his cock. He held her there, while the man yelled and arched his back, his load spurting into Beth's throat. There was a sputtering sound as whatever was going into Beth's throat filled her mouth and tried to escape the seal of her lips. Creamy liquid oozed from the seal and rolled onto his balls.

Greg leaned forward, ready to object, but as if he expected this, Zach turned to look at him, grinning. "Cool out, man," he said. "Ain't her first

rodeo.” He pushed lightly a few times on Beth’s head, his fingers curled in her hair, to make his point.

And then, he jabbed the finger that he had been swirling around Beth’s ass, shoving it into her hole, making Beth’s eyes squeeze shut briefly and a mewl garble in her throat, muffled by cock and rattling with sticky cum. Zach gave a maniacal laugh and looked at the wide-eyed stare of the guy who still had his cock in Beth’s mouth, with the pressure of Zach’s grip making it impossible for him to escape Beth’s lips.

It was a terrifying scene, one that made a clang of fear – erotic, glorious, aching, but nonetheless fear – echo in Greg’s own cock.

Zach plunged his finger in and out of Beth’s ass, grinning broadly – almost psychopathically – at the man on the bed. A low whistle came from the trio of guys clustered near the door, watching.

“She likes surprises,” Zach repeated. He pushed hard on Beth’s head, smashing her face into the man’s pelvis, before releasing her.

Beth rose up on her knees, releasing the man’s cock with a wet slurp. She gasped for air. Saliva and cum connected her mouth and his cock in a web of delicate liquid tendrils for a moment, then collapsed, some of it clinging to her chin and chest. Zach still had his finger in her ass, and he drove his hand hard into her, making her gasp and rise up further on her knees just as he seized her neck with his left hand.

He closed his fist around her slender neck, and a slight rosy color filled Beth’s face as her mouth fell open and her body rocked with the thrusting of Zach’s finger.

He released her neck and pushed her down to her hands and knees again. “Get that ass up, baby, everybody wants to see this,” Zach told her.

A pain, empty and cold, engulfed Greg’s torso, as Beth did exactly what Zach told her to. It was not even so much that she was doing it, or what she was doing – it was the practiced ease with which she did it, as if this were a scene the two of them had choreographed and rehearsed together millions of times before. She gyrated her ass as she thrust it up, and Zach dipped three fingers into her pussy as he rose up on his knees to let a huge glob of spit fall from his mouth to her ass.

The men who had come into the room to watch moved closer now, eyes on Beth’s ass, watching as Zach brought his fingers to her hole and began to stuff them inside of Beth, whose only reaction was to purr and

move her bottom in a sexy, twisted circle. She was leaning on her forearms and looking back at Zach, and her audience.

“Oh fuck, that’s so nice and tight, so fucking hot,” Zach was saying, absorbed by his task. His hand was plunging into Beth’s ass, then withdrawing to the rim, and Greg could see his fingers straining against the pressure of her sphincter as he stretched his fingers apart, pushing her open wider bit by bit.

This went on for a while, but eventually some of the guys who were watching it lost patience with merely observing Zach’s playing. They removed what clothes remained on themselves, and two of them moved to the head of the bed, climbing to kneel on it, swollen cocks to the ready in their hands.

Beth looked up at them, and that same over-generous, slutty smile appeared on her mouth. Pushing herself up to balance on one hand, she reached for one cock and wrapped her fingers around it, exchanging a pleased look with its owner. She then turned to the other man and opened her mouth after murmuring, “Feed it to me.”

For the next few minutes, Beth alternated between the two cocks at the head of the bed, sucking first on one, and then, with a flirtatious look, changing to the other. She bobbed three times on each cock, all the way down to the base, before switching back. All the while Zach, a smug and amused expression on his face, watched, his three fingers still kneading away at Beth’s ass.

Greg’s mouth had fallen open, but he was otherwise paralyzed, his hand clamped around the beer, his body frozen in place – all but his cock, which throbbed painfully as he watched the on, in an incredible mix of awe, horror, and arousal.

It was Beth who ended the scene, which Greg had begun to feel might last an eternity. On the next turn at the cock to her left, she swung her hair around and looked back at Zach, panting. “I want it,” she mewled, her ass grinding back into Zach’s fingers.

Zach grinned and glanced over at Greg, raising his eyebrows. Then he looked at Beth. “What d’you want?” He asked her. “You want a cock in every hole, don’t you? Such a little slut.” He smiled, almost affectionately. “I can help you out with that.” Zach looked up at the guy whose cock Beth had in her hand. “Get under her,” he directed. “Let her climb up on there.”

The man wasted no time slithering under Beth's body, his cock dragging along her torso as he did, leaving a streak of precum on her tits and her stomach. Zach left his embedded hand in Beth's ass as she climbed astride the man's cock and plopped her whole body weight onto him. His prick disappeared between her legs, a sticky slurp confirming it had reached its target. Beth put her hands on his chest and drove her hips toward his pelvis, then began to lift and drop them rapidly. Zach slid his fingers out of her ass and watched the spectacle, again with amusement.

Beth reached with her right hand for the second man's cock, and pulled him toward her, positioning him directly in front of her. Within seconds she was working on his dick with her mouth, bobbing her head in unison with her rutting on the man beneath her, one hand digging into his chest and propping her up into the contorted position she had to be in to swallow cock and fuck the guy underneath her.

Zach looked over at Greg at some point, and Greg became aware of his looking at him with an amused smile on his face. He had his hand on his dick, but was not yet inside Beth. When Greg finally stole a glance at him, Zach grinned, like he had finally gotten something he was waiting for. He wiped his mouth with the back of his hand, still smiling, and leaned over Beth, pushing her down with one hand on her lower back.

Beth continued to writhe, moaning, trying to grind and bounce on the bottom guy's cock. Her mouth was still hard at work on the dick in front of her, and she seemed possessed, her body the only thing that controlled her actions.

Zach was still grinning at Greg. His eyes dropped briefly to Beth's ass, so that he could line himself up with her final hole. "Spread it out, baby," he growled, and Beth pushed her legs apart further, like a butterfly.

Zach looked back at Greg as he slowly pushed his dick inside of Beth. A high-pitched squeal, muffled by cock, arose in her throat, and she squirmed against his hand, but never stopped her cocksucking for even a moment.

"You never fucked her in the ass, did you?" Zach said, chuckling, his cock slowly disappearing into Beth. He shook his head and leaned further over her still. Beth could no longer keep the cock in her mouth inside as the angle of her body changed, so it slipped from her mouth wetly and she gasped for air.

Zach wrapped his hand in her hair again and held her head up, chin tilted skyward, face upturned, even as most of her body pressed into the guy underneath her. Zach's weight was on her, and she was sandwiched between their two bodies, her hands against the bottom man's chest. "You ready to take it?" Zach asked her.

Beneath Beth, the man with his dick in her pussy tossed his head back and squinted his eyes closed. "Oh, fuck," he grunted. "Fuck. Jesus."

"I asked you something, Lizzie. You ready to take it?"

"Oh," Beth moaned. "Yes, yes, I want it."

Zach chuckled, again maniacally, and began to saw into Beth's ass, still holding her by the hair. Beneath her, the man began to groan. "Oh fuck, I'm gonna come," he panted, but he was pinned down by Beth's weight and Zach's thrusting bulk on top of her.

Greg saw Beth move her feet in circles as she squealed. Zach started to pound her, grinning. The man whose cock she had been sucking started to move his fist furiously on his cock, hovering over Beth's upturned face.

The third man, at the bottom, came first, lifting his head and almost smashing into Beth's lips. His legs jerked violently and seized up as he arched up into her body, dumping a load of cum deep in her pussy. Beth wailed and panted, her cries becoming higher-pitched and almost hysterical as Zach continued to fuck her ass.

"You're gonna come for me, Liza, aren't you?" He looked over at Greg, his grin half deteriorated by the slack-jawed expression of animal lust that consumes all men just before they come. "Her ass squeezes my cock when she comes," he said. Then he rammed especially hard and deep into Beth. "Do it, you little slut, grind that pussy until you come."

Beth was pinned between Zach and the bottom man, and she grunted and squealed, sweating and moaning grotesquely, as she rubbed her hips and pussy against the bottom guy's pelvis, while Zach looked down at her, obviously amused. Her eyes were squeezed shut and she was working so hard, unable to move as much as she clearly wanted to, that the scene was particularly grotesque.

At last, her panting and squealing reached a fevered pitch, and she writhed violently before her fingers sank deep into the bottom man's flesh, and she screamed. At that moment, the guy whacking off above her face bent over and grunted, as his own orgasm gripped him, and his cum spurted

out, falling onto Beth's face, and then the back of her head, as Zach released her hair and gripped her hips, driving his dick even deeper into her.

"Ahhhhhhh, fuck, fuck yeah!" Zach yelled, his muscles straining. Greg's eyes burned momentarily, threatening to spill over in tears of some unknown emotion, as Zach pummeled three deep thrusts into Beth's ass, each one of them, he knew, filling her asshole with his enormous load of cum.

The man Beth had been sucking off collapsed against the headboard and panted, watching the spectacle to its conclusion, and then for a moment after, as Zach grunted and jammed himself deep into Beth for his final spurts of cum. The guy on the bottom was gritting his teeth, his hands on Beth's shoulders, fingers digging into her flesh. Beth's head was tipped down, and Greg could no longer see her expression.

Only Zach seemed to never lose control completely, pushing himself up and running his hands over Beth's slippery, sweaty flank, then grabbing a handful of her ass and squeezing it possessively, before sliding out of her with a filthy squirt to rest his ass back on his ankles. He was breathing a little heavily, exerted, and he grinned and looked over at Greg.

His cock was still semi-hard, resting on his right thigh, twitching a little. It almost looked as if it was waiting to come back to life. Zach followed Greg's gaze and grinned. "Viagra, baby," he said. "Want some?"

Greg was dumbfounded, and Beth was stirring, so he didn't answer. Beth rolled off the man beneath her, splaying her legs, her hair covering her face for a moment. The sound that she made could have been a sob or a laugh, and Greg didn't know which until she pushed her hair from her face. Then he saw her broad smile, her mouth open in ecstasy. She flung her arm open and absent-mindedly rolled her body around on the bed, murmuring something in a sexual purr that Greg couldn't make out.

Zach looked over at him. "See what you got?" he snickered. "You didn't even know it, did you?"

He dropped a hand between Beth's legs and found her pussy, pinching her clit and making her gasp. "She'll go all night," he said, and then turned his attention to Beth. "Won't you? Yeah, you will. She will," he turned his attention back to Greg. "Because she's a fucking slut, and she likes to get fucked until she can't walk. Yeah, you're a dirty little bitch. Show your little prick of a hubby what a dirty girl does after she gets fucked in the ass."

Beth was rolling on the bed, moaning playfully, during this whole monologue. She rolled up like a feline animal, bending and curving in full, soft undulations, until she was facing Zach with her ass toward the man whose cock she had been sucking.

“No, baby,” Greg felt his mouth say, but the words weren’t even loud enough to be a whisper. Zach was grinning, his hand on Beth’s head, as she took his cock in her hand and brought her mouth to his crown. Greg stared in horror as she opened up and swallowed Zach’s newly-hardened cock, bobbing enthusiastically and slurping as she sucked him off.

Zach was still looking at Greg. “You know what you *can* do,” he said, lazily, his fingers in Beth’s hair, playing with her sweaty, cum-sticky locks. “You ever eat her ass out?”

Greg went cold with fear, and almost felt himself succumbing to the humiliation of doing just that, lost for a moment in the fantastical illusion he himself had created: an illusion in which Zach held all of the cards, could demand whatever he wanted from them, could make Greg suck his cum from his wife’s gaping asshole. The prospect, as an abstract idea, made Greg’s cock throb painfully with the twisted desire he was now becoming used to, but no – he wasn’t going to do *that*.

“I don’t do that,” he said, and reached casually for the drink on the bookshelf. He liked the way he sounded: confident, sure of himself – a luxury afforded to him by the fact that he still did, in fact, have an ace up his sleeve.

Beth was still sucking dutifully away at Zach’s cock. There was a moment of brief tension, and Zach’s face was neutral and somewhat sour, but the moment passed. He sniffed as he grinned, and there was an almost respectful jut to his chin when he jerked his head in reply. “Okay, then.”

He turned his attention back to Beth’s head, placing both hands on it, sucking in his breath. “That’s it, get it all cleaned off,” he told her.

In the meantime, the man who had been at the bottom of the pile had sat up, was examining the liquid that he wiped off his dick, and then rose from the bed, walking away naked to some destination that Greg ceased to care about almost immediately.

New actors came into the room, and stood waiting at the side of the bed, cocks in hand, their bare asses toward Greg. Between their bodies, he was treated to Beth’s long, drawn-out cleanup of Zach’s cock, before he pushed her off of him and she turned toward her waiting "customers."

She seated herself on the edge of the bed, smiling at each man in turn, and then looked at Greg as she brought each of her hands to a cock. Zach was behind her, watching, amused, when she grinned at Greg, and began to suck on each shaft in turn, her watering eyes looking up at each man as she bobbed three times on his dick. First one, then the other.

Zach rose up behind her, standing on the bed, and hung his cock over her head until she paused her cocksucking to look up at him. She smiled, opening her mouth, and Zach crouched to stuff his dick into her mouth, her head tipped far back, her neck exposed so that the lump of his dick could be seen as it traveled the length of her throat.

“She can do two at once,” he said abruptly, standing up, holding his dick in his hand and rubbing it in Beth’s hair as he spoke, grinning. His eyes met Greg’s. “Bet you didn’t know *that*.”

He tapped Beth on the head with his cock, slapping her with it. “Show ‘im,” he said.

Beth smiled at Greg, and his chest again felt blown open, and the world seemed to shift: the woman looking at him simply wasn’t, for all her resemblance to Beth, his wife. The two guys she had been sucking off moved in closer, and Greg felt like closing his eyes, like he couldn’t possibly watch what he was about to see... and yet, he couldn’t tear his gaze away from it.

The two bulbous heads bumped into each other, and Beth pushed her face forward, looking at Greg the whole time, adjusting so he would have a better view. She then opened her mouth, pulling one dick into it, and then stretched her mouth open wider, so wide it was almost hideous, and crammed the second head between her teeth.

And then, the two men converged on her face, blocking Greg’s view of whatever happened next. He could only hear the glugging, the smacking, the sticky awkwardness as they jockeyed for position in her mouth. The last visual he had was of just the fat crowns, bouncing into each other, spit rolling down Beth’s face, her jaw open impossibly wide, her eyes filled with a rudderless, wild glee.

From there, it went on: Beth sucked off whatever cock was put in front of her, then she lay on her back and took two guys in succession, tossing her head and moaning and smiling as they pushed her around like a rag doll, fucking her hard and filling her pussy with cum. Greg caught a

glimpse of her swollen cunt, a creamy slickness coating it like a glaze, her flesh pulsing and quivering with the endless collisions of her orgasms.

Zach watched as she was thoroughly fucked, as she reached out for cocks to put in her mouth, and then he tipped her legs up over her head and let the oozing loads of cum roll onto her ass, before he held her by the ankles, pushing them up over her head to fuck her ass again.

Greg sat in the chair paralyzed in all ways: his mind could not think a thought, the feelings that had been raging from one extreme to the next froze in a single, painful, non-feeling that still managed to ache, and his body was rigid, turgid everywhere to the point of dangerous-feeling pain. The parade of men flipped and twisted and pulled on Beth's body, and she smiled and bent and opened her mouth, swallowing and absorbing everything they gave to her.

At some point in all of that, Anna came into the room. She was naked except for a red garter belt that held up neutral stockings with a red lace trim, and she actually looked quite alluring: her face was flushed, her nipples swollen and bright pink with what looked like a great deal of attention. The knees on her stockings were torn, lending her strange, alternating, beauty – between cheap and oddly austere – a rough, whoreish edge.

Greg was aware of her when she entered, but unable to think a thought beyond that. She curled up like a cat with a bottle of water in one hand and watched as Beth was rammed from behind and sucked on a cock at the same time.

So when, at some unknowable moment, Anna looked up at Greg and he could read in his peripheral vision that dangerous mischief that he had seen in her face at the bar, Greg didn't react. He didn't react as she crawled in front of him, and unzipped his pants, pulling out his cock. He felt her fingers but through a haze – his mind was entirely absorbed by Beth's whoreish smile, the spluttering filth of her sloshing pussy, the sheen of sweat that covered her body from head to toe, milky-colored here and there with always-wet cum, the smell of her pussy juices that seemed to always get stronger, and more bitter, as load after load of cum mixed into it.

He could feel Anna's mouth when she took his dick inside; it was hot and wet and he was bursting at the seams. His orgasm began deep in his groin, reached through his body to grab his stomach and crush it in its grip, sent streaks of colored stars through his vision. Beth was coming as a man

slapped into her, bouncing them both on the mattress, and she turned her head to look at Greg as she came, yelling, “Oh, oh, oh, oh!”

Surely, she saw Anna’s blond head bobbing in Greg’s lap, and this had not been part of the deal, and he might have felt awful about it if he had even really, truly registered that it was happening. Cum strained against the ducts of his cock and made him feel like he might be torn apart as he spewed into Anna’s warm mouth.

Beth was looking at him, her face unreadable, her body bouncing on the mattress, and Greg glanced briefly down at Anna, who was just then releasing him from her mouth, grinning, some strange look of triumph on her face.

Spent, Greg stared at the bed, at the seemingly endless train of men fucking his wife, coming back for more, and all the while Zach grinned and orchestrated, laughing behind his neutral expression. Eventually, Greg began to doze in and out of consciousness. His sleeping moments were punctuated by a change of men, by some particularly loud moaning, or by Zach asking if he wanted some Viagra. Someone brought him a new drink and put it in his hand.

Eventually, he woke from a state of blurry consciousness to a darkened room, and an eerie quiet. Beth was heaped – there was no other word for it – on the bed, Zach next to her, one leg thrown over her body. Her hand was on his chest, and he was holding it, but the embrace seemed to be more one of an accident borne of exhaustion than anything emotive. Greg blinked slowly, and saw Anna’s blond head on the floor next to another man, before he drifted away again.

When he woke up more completely, it was to a fairly quiet moment. People were scattered all over the bedroom, including Beth, who was on her stomach with her arms on either side of her head, almost like she had fallen asleep during some final fuck.

Zach was nowhere to be found.

The scent of sex pervaded the air. A few people still stirred, but mostly everyone had fallen asleep or left. Light was beginning to permeate the horizon, which he could see out of the window. The scene was absurd, suddenly very awful to him, and he was gripped by a desire to leave.

He stood up, staring at his wife and the whole scene in the large bedroom. Some of the more striking moments surfaced in his mind as

snapshots, but they seemed unreal, and he could almost, *almost*, believe that none of it had actually happened.

And then, like a slam of an ice-cold brick, the thought hit him: *the fucking tapes*.

He looked at his watch. It was six am, and he confirmed with another glance out the window that the sun was, indeed, coming up in the east. He walked over to the bed, where several puddles of bodily fluids lay, still wet, between Beth's legs. Her long, lean body was stretched out, and looked beautiful, the shine of cum and sweat dulled to a dry matte as she had lain there.

Her hair was pushed up and over her head, knotted and also still damp. Her lips were puffy and pink, mascara that she had wiped away from her cheeks was still faintly visible on the underside of her jaw, and, of course, at her tail bone, just above the sweet cleft between her buttocks, the black letters of Zach's claim to her ass were unaffected by all that she had done.

In the light of day, a hangover creeping in on him and surveying the aftermath, Greg could kick himself for getting so caught up in all of this that he - and Beth - had forgotten the tapes entirely. Merely hours ago, he wouldn't have known what someone was talking about if they had said the word, "*tapes*," but that seemed so insane to him now that he felt sick.

And then, rearing up like a monster from a lake, the memory of Anna's mouth on his cock, of her throat swallowing his cum, of her odd, malicious little smile.

Greg dropped his hand to Beth's cheek and caught a damp strand of her hair with his fingertips. It clung to her cheek, via a viscous and still wet material that he suspected was cum, though from whom or how long ago, it was anybody's guess.

He wasn't sure why, but he stumbled out of the room and into the rest of the house. He must have consumed a lot more alcohol than he remembered, because his mind was a fog and his brain seemed to roll around inside his head like a lead weight, sending hot pain careening through him each time it knocked up against the confines of his skull.

He walked around somewhat aimlessly. A lot of people had left, and the remainder were scattered about the house like litter, in various states of undress. A guy who looked unbelievably stoned or drunk or both was

pouring things into a glass in the kitchen, but he didn't seem to even recognize that Greg was there as he walked through.

Greg picked Beth's dress and shoes up from the side of the pool, where they were piled, cool and damp, exactly where she had taken them off.

He looked at the pool, in which several flotation devices and articles of clothing floated. A pile of at least two people was heaped on a deck chair near the hot tub, covered by blankets and towels. The image brought to mind used tissues, the dirty feel of a dark room with porn still playing on relentlessly, long after the watcher's climax. He wished that he could reach over to a computer and turn it all off, but there was no neat ending to things that happened in real life.

Head spinning, he trudged back upstairs.

*

"Beth," he said gently.

He had to shake her gently awake, and, when she roused herself, she seemed temporarily confused, then mildly horrified.

"Go get in the car," Greg told her, placing her dress next to her on the bed. "We're leaving."

Beth was propped up on one arm, using her other to push her mussed hair from her face. She looked around, and Greg could see the previous night's adventures coming back to her, as they had to him, in waves. After surveying the room, she looked back at him almost helplessly.

In her features Greg could see a fear that was equal to, or perhaps a mirror image of his own: had they done something that could not be undone? She began to mumble something, but the words were disjointed like his own thoughts, and she stopped after a bit and then suddenly started to crumple.

"Oh shit," she murmured, and a real fear took over her green eyes, turning them dark with a hopelessness that cut through Greg's chest. "The tapes..."

There was a lot packed into that statement, and the rest of the thoughts that lay behind it welled up in her eyes as tears. Had she done all of this, and gotten carried away by it, only to end up back where they had

started? At some point in the evening, she, like Greg, had lost sight of the *reason* for it.

Greg reached out to tuck her hair behind her ear, tenderly, as a sign that it was over now, that they would begin the process of repairing whatever had been damaged together. That's what he meant by it, but seeing that the gesture didn't do much to reassure her, he leaned toward her and kissed her on the lips.

Her mouth was salty, her lips dry and infused with the flavors of her escapades, and Greg was surprised that his reaction to that taste, to the scent of sex on her, was not revulsion but arousal. "Go get in the car," he said, and she was speaking again before he finished the sentence.

"We forgot the tapes..." she said wanly, and a tear pooled in her right eye and fell onto her cheek as she blinked. "Oh, God -"

"I got it," Greg told her, confidently. "Go get in the car."

He said it with such authority, such confidence, that his own voice buoyed himself. Much of life, after all, really was a game of confidence. Zach Pinker was a study in that very phenomenon: a man who could make a woman like Beth be Liza Brown for a night, who got what he wanted by believing he would get it.

And even though Greg's plan was no more than a play, he stood up feeling confident: he was going to play his hand like it was real, and believe that he would get what he wanted, because he believed in himself. He *had* to, because there was no other way that he could imagine this ending.

Beth looked at him for a moment, her eyes narrowed slightly with mistrust or confusion. But when she reached for her dress and began to shakily sort it to pull it over her head, saying, "Okay, okay," that was the final boost that Greg needed.

He kissed her again. "Go get the phones. Wait in the car," he repeated. "I'll be right out."

*

"Wake up, tiger."

Zach was obviously the kind of guy who didn't get woken up by people in such an unceremonious fashion. For someone who had seemed dead to the world in a seemingly chemically-induced coma, he rose out of bed very quickly, muscles flexed, jaw tightened, eyes wild. If Greg hadn't

moved out of the way quickly enough, he would have gotten head-butted by him.

Zach was the kind of guy who woke up ready for a fight. But Greg had been expecting that.

For some reason, though, this didn't give him the spark of quivering fear that it ordinarily would have. In truth, he was often afraid of the men he prosecuted. The more heinous the crime, the scarier it became. He knew that those kinds of people were hardened criminals, and by the time they were there, they didn't have much to lose.

Zach Pinker had the stripes of that kind of tiger, but at the same time, he was missing something. He had a legitimate business and no criminal record, and that told Greg something very important. A lot of Zach's power came from people *assuming* he was a badass.

He did a great impression.

But Greg's plan didn't involve a physical standoff. He was better suited to fight with his wits, and so he had a legal bluff up his sleeve. It all rested on Zach's tepid intellect - he had to know enough to be scared, but not enough to know that he had any escape route except the one Greg was going to offer him.

Greg had a high level of confidence that his plan would work, because if there was one thing he could see plainly about Zach Pinker, it was that he had a lot to lose. He'd seen people with almost nothing left of their dignity sing like canaries when faced with the accusation he was about to make.

And as such, Greg was right at home in this kind of situation.

"I'm gonna need those tapes back, bud," he said calmly. He enjoyed the fact that Zach's face registered surprise, which melted into a sudden wariness.

Even though he could feel the surety of his assessment in his veins, even Greg was surprised by how calm he felt.

"Tapes," Zach said, and he grinned in his smug way, but the cracks in the facade were evident. Greg's confidence had him worried, and behind Zach's cool, worry-free exterior, Greg could see the wheels turning. Greg was like a cat, tail moving in dangerously calm sweeps, staring down a barking dog. Everyone knows that kind of cat has something up his sleeve.

"The tapes. Right," Zach said, his smart-assery fading by the end of his sentence. He had the look of a man upon whom it was dawning that he

no longer had the upper hand, but just didn't know why that was.

"Look, I'm not fucking around," Greg said.

Zach gave him a sarcastic expression of awe and kept grinning.

"Maybe Beth told you what I do for a living," Greg continued.

"You know," Zach said, puffing himself up. "She didn't actually tell me a goddamn thing about you. I don't think she even remembers who you are, bud. Even when you're standing right there watching me fuck her."

Greg tamped down a flare of anger and maintained his composure.

"Well, that's too bad. I hope it doesn't take too long to explain it to you. You know what a prosecuting attorney is?"

Zach didn't seem to think much of this, and for a moment, Greg wondered if he had misjudged him. He had checked into his record, and he didn't have one, and it didn't seem possible that someone this old could not have any idea what that meant. Zach snorted derisively.

Greg had already crossed the Rubicon.

He had to play his card and see how it panned out.

"You happen to remember when all those videos were made?" Greg asked.

"Man, I don't remember what happened yesterday, you want honesty," Zach said, laughing. But the muscles on his hard jaw line were twitching, and his arms were tense. He smelled something, and it had him on alert.

"Well, unfortunately for you, Zach, there's a TV in the background in one of those videos."

"Ooof," Zach said, without feeling.

"Yep. And on that TV is a news broadcast," Greg continued.

There was always a moment when someone got it. It was usually in the police interviews, and Greg saw it more often on video than in real life. Almost like a glitch, a person would go blank for a fraction of a second - blink, and you could miss it - and then reset. It was the moment they realized that there was something out there they hadn't thought of, a thing they had missed that was going to sink them, and they didn't have anything ready for it, because they hadn't thought of it, and they didn't know what it was, and they couldn't very well ask about it.

Zach glitched in this same way, and when he reset his face to the default of overconfident smugness, it looked false. In the back of his mind

he knew something was up, and any second now he would realize what it was, and - hopefully - believe he was in deep, deep trouble.

The whole thing rested on Zach thinking first of how much trouble he was in, so that he would get scared enough to act irrationally. After all, Greg was about to tell him a lie, but if Zach had the reaction Greg hoped he would - and the entire plan was predicated on this bet - there would be no checking up on the facts.

If Zach could think his way to the problem himself, he would want to rid himself of this problem faster than he could find the tapes and give them to Greg.

But Zach was frozen in fear, and so Greg pressed. "It's an interesting news story," he continued, pleased because he sounded even more confident, could feel the tables turning. It was invigorating - the kind of rush he never got at work because it was never personal there. "Some huge pile-up on Highway 4. You might remember it. It happened in June of 2001. June 12, 2001, as a matter of fact."

The pileup was a risk: there *had* been a pileup, and it had happened on June 12, just not in the year he was going to claim it happened. It *had* been on the news, and it *had* been in the background of one of the videos. But the accident had happened in 2002, and Beth - or Liza - was, in reality, nearly 19 on the actual date. But Greg was banking on the fuzziness of memory, banking on Zach from that era being a devil-may-care sort of guy who would never have bothered to think about whether Beth was underaged or not while making these sordid videos, and - crucially - the panic that would further blur Zach's senses once he figured out what Greg was implying.

"For reference," Greg continued, just to help Zach along, "Beth's birthday is in August. Of 1984."

And there it was.

Greg got a rush watching it pour slowly over him: Zach was doing the math.

He had believed the story, and now, whatever his cool exterior looked like, he was panicking on the inside as he ran the numbers, the consequences, the potential outcomes.

"I have a lot of good reasons," Greg said slowly, treading carefully, throwing a lifeline before Zach started thinking too hard, or rationally; before the terror wore off, he needed to give him a plea bargain of sorts.

"To not want those tapes to come out. Which you know. But it seems to me that, if you think about it, *you* might have an even better one."

Zach was silent now. Something else - something Greg couldn't read, and hadn't expected, was building up behind his stoic countenance. Greg felt a sinking feeling: maybe Zach from twenty years ago *was* smarter, and more cautious than Greg had believed. Maybe his memory was better than anticipated.

It didn't bode well. This was Greg's entire arsenal, and if Zach didn't believe it, he had just revealed the lengths he would go to to obtain those tapes. He was also, he realized, in some really gray legal waters with this stunt, should it ever come to anyone else's attention. But that had been the gamble, and at the time, it had seemed like a sure thing.

He decided to up the fear factor before Zach thought too much.

"Before you waste any time thinking about it, there's no statute of limitations issue. It's child pornography, always and forever. But... maybe you'll find a good lawyer, sympathetic jury..."

Greg pulled an envelope out of his back pocket. "I'm the kind of guy who thinks ahead," he said. "I have a non-disclosure agreement here, pretty bland, no mention of the... *details* of the tapes. And you can sign it, upon returning the tapes, and we can both just sleep better knowing that no one will ever mention any of this again. Don't you think?"

"Man," Zach said, shaking his head. He had deflated in an instant, and fear was crawling around on his face now. He put a hand to his head and ran it through his hair. Panic was now flowing freely out of him, around him, and he was tapping his foot rapidly. He was a different man, and something was wrong, and it was Greg's turn to hide a creeping panic inside himself. What was the detail *he* had missed?

"You mean there are actually tapes?" Zach said. He ran his fingers through his hair and exhaled.

It wasn't a performance. Greg knew a performance when he saw one, and if this was acting, Zach had a brilliant career ahead of himself.

He felt like sinking into the floor. A slam of fear hit him with a hard, cold thud, in the chest. His mouth moved uselessly, until he said, in a hoarse whisper: "*What?*"

Zach jerked his head to look up at him, and annoyance flashed across his face.

"Here's the thing," Zach said, foot tapping nervously. He was openly a wreck, and a shell of the dominating man he had seemed just moments before. "I don't... I don't *have* those tapes. I don't have them. I..." he looked up at Greg, a pleading expression on his face. "I thought this was all just a game... I don't know, maybe that Liza was playing. You know, like she wanted to fuck around, but she needed to pretend like she had a reason to be doing it. I mean, man... what the fuck? Those tapes were... destroyed. This is..." He shook his head, at a loss for words. "What the hell are you *talking* about, man?"

He was looking at Greg now, hope on his face. Greg's own face, though, was falling into confusion, because he had anticipated all kinds of crazy responses and planned for them - but this?

He hadn't seen it coming at all.

"The tapes!" Greg hissed. His head was swimming. "I'm talking about the fucking tapes!"

"I don't *have* any fucking tapes," Zach said, balling his fists up.

"You didn't leave a copy of the tapes at Beth's aunt and uncle's house? On a USB key?"

Zach was staring at him now, his mouth open in horror.

"Man, this was two thousand... whatever. And one. They didn't even have... USB keys weren't even a thing, man. Right?"

Zach shook his head. He was now starting to get angry, which only lent credence to his story.

A sudden, forceful flood of anger rushed into Greg's bloodstream. "Stop fucking around, man," he said, standing up straight. He had been sinking, along with his heart and his hopes, slowly toward the floor. "Give me the fucking tapes or you're going to go to fucking jail for child pornography. Do you understand that?"

"I don't fucking *know* what you're talking about, man," Zach shouted, and then looked around, as if he had just told a racist joke. He lowered his voice. "Dude, I fucking swear to God, I thought Liza was just ... I don't know. I thought she was just looking for an excuse, playing some game, I thought you guys were some kinky fucking Bible-thumpers who needed, like, a *game*. Fuck, man. This is fucking stressing me out."

Greg stared at Zach, who put his head back in his hands and shook his head slowly. "Fuck," he repeated. "Fuck, this isn't happening. Tell me this is not happening."

Greg stepped backward and leaned against the wall. His mind had gone into a tailspin, and every correction he tried to make seemed to make the story less comprehensible. The tapes *existed*, the USB key was *real*, he had seen it with his own eyes. Beth had seen it, Beth had verified they existed and that they came from Zach.

"You're full of shit," Greg said, his voice still hoarse. He was grasping at straws, and he knew as Zach looked at him, eyes red-rimmed, real fear in his eyes - he *believed* Zach.

It wasn't adding up, and his head felt like it would explode from the discord.

He slumped down to a crouch.

"Liza burned those tapes," Zach repeated. "I saw her... I was *pissed*, man, at the time. But they're *gone*. I saw them burn."

"I *saw* them," Greg hissed back. "I *watched* them. They're not gone. Someone has a copy of them," Greg mumbled. Anger gripped him again. "*You* have a copy of them, stop fucking around!"

"I don't!" Zach snapped, rubbing his head with both hands. His eyes were wild, and he held Greg's gaze. "And that's a real fucking problem, Greggy. For both of us."

Greg tipped his head toward his knees and groaned. A part of him felt like throwing a temper tantrum, or starting a fight with Zach, and another part of him felt like giving up and crying like a baby.

But neither of these things was going to help. He inhaled sharply and looked up at Zach, whose eyes were wandering around the room, his mind at work, obviously trying, like Greg, to find a foothold in the quicksand that was enveloping them both.

Time ticked by, and a clatter came from the other room, followed by a woman's laughter. Greg's stomach lurched, if possible, even further into his feet, and he felt like he was going to throw up. A glass object, possibly a bottle, rolled on the floor in the hallway, and footsteps in heavy shoes could be heard, headed toward them.

It was all over: his career was fucked, his wife was a slut, they were going to be publicly shamed, he was probably going to lose his job, and the worst part was that it was all coming from somewhere they hadn't expected at all. He looked at Zach again, hoping to see some evidence of him lying, playing his *own* bluff.

But to what end? Zach seemed distraught, believably so - but also he couldn't have expected Greg to come to him with this particular lie.

Greg threw his head back and hit himself on the skull much harder than he had expected. The molten hangover crashed against his skull and a searing pain spread its fingers and wrapped itself around his entire head.

"What the hell are you two crying about in here?" a slurred, female voice giggled from the doorway. Greg didn't need to look over to know it was Anna: she was loosely draped in a red silky robe and still wearing her heels.

Greg watched Zach's face as he lifted his head from his hands, annoyed, and looked at Anna. He was about to dismiss her, turn away, when some aspect of his expression glinted, and his eyes narrowed.

"Is this a fucking funeral or what?" Anna continued, coming into the room and plopping onto the bed. She seemed still drunk, and her robe splayed open to reveal her sloppy, engorged pussy as she folded one leg over the other. She leaned flirtatiously toward Zach and put out her hand to his shoulder, walking her fingers along his bicep toward his collarbone.

Zach looked at Greg while she did this, and his expression had turned into ice-cold murderousness.

Anna looked from Zach to Greg, and then back again, and laughed mirthfully. She turned abruptly to the side and rummaged on the bed for something, pulling out an unopened bottle of wine. "Huh," she giggled. She started to unwrap the top. "Didn't expect you to get up so early," she slurred, vaguely directing herself at Zach. She lifted her eyes and looked at Greg. "Or you."

She winked, and grinned, and peeled away more of the wrapper.

Zach was still looking at Greg, his eyes seemingly compacting in upon themselves, getting colder and denser with each passing second. Rage was brewing behind his stone-like expression, and his jaw shifted, almost imperceptibly, beneath his full beard.

His hand shot out abruptly, and snatched the wine bottle, which Anna grasped tightly with both hands. She protested with a falsetto whine and a silly, slutty giggle.

Zach was turning his head slowly toward her, his eyes leaving Greg's face last, so that his intense scowl snapped to Anna only after his head was turned fully toward her. "You *bitch*," he said quietly.

Anna's clamped hands let go of the bottle, and her silly smile turned into one that was more menacing, a devious glint sparkling in her eye. "Such a potty mouth," she told Zach.

Greg was slowly catching up, but he wasn't where Zach was, yet.

"I'm not fucking around, Anna," Zach said, and Anna made a childish "ooo-oooh," noise and rolled her eyes.

A new, unsettling feeling - like the premonition that a violent crime was about to be committed right in front of him - was oozing into Greg's system. Zach seemed unhinged, Anna seemed provocative, and there was a history of something very trashy and awful, and probably at least somewhat violent - between them that he did not know in full. He had the sneaking suspicion that he should get the hell out of there, or call the cops. But he could also see now that the ever-drunk Anna held the keys to his own salvation somehow, that maybe there was a way to turn this around...

Greg started to get to his feet, suddenly compelled to remove himself from the scene. His body was smart enough to know a danger that was too deep, even if his mind still believed that he could somehow escape this awful story unscathed.

Zach looked murderous, and Anna had stopped laughing, and was now looking down at her lap, adjusting the robe.

"I gotta... I don't want to be here -"

"You fucking stay here," Zach said, without looking over at Greg. He wrested the wine bottle from Anna and held it in his hand, and for a moment Greg was sure that Zach was going to hit her over the head with it. But he froze, halfway up the wall, pushing against it to balance his weight so he didn't have to crouch. He was afraid to move.

"Where did you get them?" Zach hissed.

Anna made another attempt at coyness. "Get wha-"

"How did you copy the fucking tapes, Anna?" Zach said.

Anna played bimbo for a few moments, lolling her head and smiling stupidly, shrugging her shoulders, shaking her head. But for some reason - likely Zach's unrelenting stare, she shrugged the facade away and shook her hair out. With the shake, her features seemed to erase, like an Etch-A-Sketch, and reset into a malevolently smiling expression that seemed instantly much smarter, much more sober, much more calculating than the Anna who had been present up until then.

"Liza's underaged in those videos," Zach spat.

Anna blinked slowly. Then she snorted. "Shit," she laughed. And it only took her a few seconds of nimble calculation to add: "You're in a lot of deep shit, then, aren't you?"

Greg closed his eyes, convinced that he was about to witness a murder. Zach was going to strangle Anna, and there would be no way to explain any of this to the cops, and he would be one of those people he looked at in mystified pity all the time, wondering what the hell had happened, how they had gotten themselves in so deep.

He tried to push himself up along the wall, and then opened his eyes because he started to feel sick.

Zach looked murderous, and he was trembling beneath his skin, his muscles coiled in rage. But he had not grabbed Anna by the throat, and the wine bottle remained in his hand, not swinging through the air.

"Actually *you're* in a lot of deep shit," he heard someone say, and it was several moments before he realized it was his own voice. He was standing up, straightening out, speaking calmly. God, he was fucking *smoothing* his shirt.

Zach was smiling. Anna was slowly, slowly, melting down, still acting tough, but beneath her skin fear was beginning to crawl around. Her eyes jiggled as she searched for meaning in his words, widened as she came across it, and her pulse throbbed visibly in her neck and at her temple.

She set her jaw, and Greg cringed a little inwardly because he was sure she was grinding her teeth.

"...possession and distribution of child pornography..." Greg heard himself saying.

Anna was staring at Zach, who was staring back at her.

She laughed. "So, what?" She looked up at Greg. "You gonna lock me up?"

"How did you get them?" Zach repeated, almost stupefied.

Anna was looking at Greg.

"We can work something out, Anna," Greg was saying. "You're lucky..."

Anna snatched the wine from Zach's hand and twisted the cap open. She took a big swig and wiped her mouth.

She laughed again. "*Jesus*," she said. What exactly she meant by it was impossible to glean from her tone.

"Why?" Greg asked, when she said nothing.

"Why, what?" Anna asked miserably, taking a swig of the wine. She looked at Zach, and narrowed her eyes, as if she wanted him to see something that she felt he could understand. She scoffed, took another swig of wine, and looked at Greg.

Did she have some kind of grudge, something between her and Beth that she wanted to work out this way? Some desire to perversely... what? Win over Zach? Greg searched in vain for motive, for some thread that would make sense, for a *reason*. Zach was doing the same, staring at Anna as if seeing her for the first time, almost laughably repulsed by what he saw.

It was, Greg thought, incredibly ironic. All of it.

"*Why?* Did you do it?" Greg repeated.

Anna grinned and looked into the wine bottle with one eye closed.

"Why, anything?" she replied.

She shrugged at Greg's open-mouthed silence.

"Bored, I guess."

EPILOGUE

Anna never did give any other *reason* for what she'd done. In a drunken stupor, at Zach's house, twenty years before, she had come across the tapes. She had watched them in the basement of Zach's house, where they had been made, while a drunken party raged upstairs. She had put them back where she had found them - right on the shelves of a TV hutch - and left them there for "a while." They were unlabeled VHS-C tapes.

She remembered showing up at Zach's house one night, though she couldn't remember why she had gone there or why she had expected him to be there - "or why," she had added flatly, rolling her eyes, "I cared that you weren't." But she had, for a reason she couldn't really explain - she wasn't sure if she had been helping Beth or jealous of her, mad at Zach or mad at Beth, or just feeling impish - she had taken the entire bottom row of tapes, and moved some other unmarked videos to their place.

When Zach, and then Greg, pressed her on what she had hoped to accomplish, she shrugged. "It was a long time ago," she said.

The tapes had been in the trunk of her car for years, removed only when she sold it - ironically, to Zach - some years later. She remembered taking them out and tossing them in her parents' basement with some other junk of hers, where they lived, in cool darkness, until her parents moved.

"That's when I remembered what they were," Anna said. "I was about to toss them. And then I thought... huh. Who knows? You know? Might come in handy someday."

She had decided to convert them to digital form at some point, after watching "something on TV about tapes disintegrating or some shit. Twenty percent every ten years."

To everyone's surprise - perhaps even including Anna, who looked impressed with herself when she answered Zach's disbelieving question - she had converted them herself: "Used a cable."

And then, Liza Brown had come back to town. And so she had decided to, "I don't know... scare her or something. Fuck up her life. Or not." Anna had shrugged. She just wasn't sure why.

Zach seemed more disbelieving of Anna's story than Greg was, but that was because Zach didn't work in criminal law. Anna's story - the intention-less, haphazard nature of it, the pointlessness of it all - rang true.

Greg had prosecuted many a case, baffled out of his mind, in which people who had committed far greater crimes (and there really was no crime here, just the insinuation of one) for similarly vague, unremembered, banal reasons.

All that mattered was that Anna had enough sense to not want any trouble. She turned over the tapes, the computer old computer she had made the copies on ("doesn't work, anyway) and signed a non-disclosure agreement with the largest, loopiest signature Greg had ever seen. Zach was all-too-happy to do the same. The agreement had no real teeth, but neither one of them read it very carefully. They both wanted the whole sordid affair to disappear, which made Greg proud of the way he had sold them the lie.

"Maybe it just gives her... I don't know," Beth mused, on the drive back to the city, her elbow propped on the car door, a bare leg perched recklessly on the dash, "something *interesting* in her life."

That was all Beth really had to say about Anna, in the end. Her reaction to the story, when Greg told it to her the next day, was not one of anger. Nor was it disbelief, or any other feeling it would have seemed normal for her to have.

"That's so... *trashy*," she had commented. But more like she felt sorry for Anna than anything.

Greg was not entirely sure what he had been expecting to happen afterward: if he tried to recall what he had been thinking, before that night took place, he couldn't find a single memory in his head of thinking ahead. He found *that* hard to believe about himself. He was, after all, a man who traded in aftermaths, one of the sorters of the detritus that was inevitably produced by acts of recklessness. The idea that he hadn't looked ahead to what his own life would be like, to what his relationship with Beth would be like - *before* they embarked on that adventure - mystified him.

But then, it had been a kind of tunnel vision. A thing they had talked themselves into believing was necessary, that had to be done.

His wife had seemed like another person that night. By the time they arrived back at her uncle's ramshackle house from Zach's place, it was almost possible for him to believe that it *had been* another woman, and not his wife, Beth.

Maybe, in many ways, it was.

When they crossed the doorstep that morning, Beth had turned to him, looking back toward him with an expression of want. Her mouth was

downturned, on the verge of crying, and she seemed to want him to hold her, to tell her everything was all right. She shook her head and opened her mouth, stepping toward him. But she couldn't say anything.

Greg pulled her to him. The bare skin on her back was tacky, sweat and cum and God only knows what else having smeared and dried up in patches all over her flesh. The sweet tang of her own juices and the bitter sourness of male cum, the acrid sweat of other men, clung to her, an aromatic mist just above her skin, stronger in waves and patches.

When he held her close to him, the images of the evening, the endless record of her moans and squeals, her enthusiastic smile, the voracious thirst for cock that lit up her eyes, all percolated in his mind, and his cock got hard against her body. He took her head in his two hands and kissed her hungrily, the taste of her mouth sexily filthy, tainted, tinged by the sweet cool taste of an apple juice box she had found and drank in the car while she waited for him.

He pushed her backward and up the stairs, kissing her violently, pleased that she was kissing him back. Her tears dripped into their kiss, salty and warm, and he pulled back to look at her. "I'm sorry," she said, blinking away her tears. "I don't know... what..."

Greg kissed her and pushed her dress up, which made her look at him, only momentarily, in confusion.

"It's okay," he said, tugging the dress up and over her head. It ripped as he did this, and he pushed Beth onto the mattress and looked at her. She was reclined on her elbows, slightly shocked, her mouth open, her eyes wavering between hungrily aroused and mistrustful, tears still damp in their corners.

"It was hot, Beth," he said, shimmying out of his clothes. "I told you. I promise you."

He lay down next to her, and she slipped onto her back, still looking at him in disbelief. He moved his fingers over her reddened nipples, coaxing them to hardness, delighting in her sharp intake of breath when he pinched one.

He moved his hand to her pussy, and worked his fingers gently into her swollen, sticky-wet folds, then deeper, into her thoroughly-fucked cunt, trying to feel its use for himself, the remains of the many, many loads of cum and the stretching and pulling by so many cocks. She mewled as he worked his fingers around in the silky interior.

"Sore?" he asked her, and she nodded.

How to explain to Beth what he felt as he entered her, and fucked her slowly, his cock deep in the well of cum that she had absorbed, her pussy pulverized and stretched, loose around him and yet still so satisfying? It took a long time to bring her to orgasm, fucking her gently like that, surely because she was so fucked-out, had come so many times that she was almost numb as he gently ground against her, and explored the newly stretched and violated places of her body with his fingers and his cock. She finally came, and was almost asleep, when he at last hammered his own load of cum into his wife's overflowing, brutalized cunt.

And after that?

Their sex life, he was surprised to discover, did not change in some insane, irretrievable way. They had hot sex for a while, hotter than before - but it wasn't especially different, not in any way that he could put his finger on. Not in any way that he could know.

But who can really, *really* know someone, and what they are thinking, what they are feeling, even when you're inside of them, consumed by passion?

Beth would never *know* - not even if he somehow found the words to tell her, she could never know it the way that he did - what he was thinking, sometimes, when they fucked after all of this happened. That now, when he fucked her on her hands and knees, her ass turned up to him, and her cheek against the mattress, he could see, as if it were really still there, the long-ago faded black marker on her tail bone, the gushing gape that Zach had made, and that he sawed away at her pussy with a dick made rock-hard by the memory of her sandwiched between two male bodies, being fucked relentlessly full of cum in every hole.

And who was to say, as Beth looked vacantly to the side, her fingers to her lips, her throat moaning at each thrust... that she wasn't thinking of the sharp ache, the tearing fullness, of Zach's cock in her ass?

Sometimes sex is incredibly hot, and there is no way to quantify why that is, or to know what has changed inside the other person that makes their pussy overflow with sweet nectar, or their cock throb to bursting at the seams.

Greg supposed it was the most valuable thing he could have taken from the experience: a willingness to let that go, to allow for the possibility that not every motive, not every sentiment, can be known.

And that ignorance of these things does not preclude enjoyment of them.

And it was his own mystery, his own secret, something that, like everyone else in the story, he wouldn't divulge.

Mostly because: he just didn't *know*.

And maybe that was what lay inside of Anna, or Beth, or even Zach.

Secrets, that didn't get divulged, not because they held any particular value, or because their owners wanted to keep them for a particular reason - but just because there was no earthly way to really share them. *They* didn't seem to know how to reach inside of themselves and define what they had wanted.

And when he thought about it, he was just like them.

The only thing that mattered to him now was that he did know - and so did Beth - that he loved his spouse, that he loved her more than anything he *wanted*.

Maybe that was all you *could* know. Maybe that was as close as you could get to the definition - so ephemeral, so difficult to articulate - of love: that it mattered more than anything else you wanted, that it ranked above all other things.

Maybe *nobody* knew why.

END

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